

The (in)transparency of meaning change and variation

A study of the indefinite *cualquiera*
in European and Argentinian
Spanish

Olga Kellert

Advances in Historical Linguistics 2



Advances in Historical Linguistics

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Abbreviations

ArgSp	Argentinian Spanish
CdE	<i>Corpus del Español</i>
CdE_G/H	<i>Corpus del Español_Genre/Historical</i>
CdE_web	<i>Corpus del Español web dialects</i>
CdE_now_EurSp.	<i>Corpus del Español now European Spanish</i>
COM	common
CORDIAM	<i>Corpus Diacrónico y Diatópico del Español de América</i>
CORDE	<i>Corpus Diacrónico del Español</i>
Decl	declarative
Def	definite article
DER	derogatory
DILE	<i>Diccionario Latinoamericano de la Lengua Española</i>
DLE	<i>Diccionario de la Lengua Española</i>
EVAL	evaluative meanings: e.g. ‘ordinary’, ‘nonsense’
EVAL1	evaluative meaning ‘ordinary’
EVAL2	evaluative meaning ‘nonsense’
EXH	exhaustivity operator
EurSp	European Spanish
FCI	free choice interpretation
Fr.	French
IGN	ignorance
IND	indiscriminative ‘not just any’
Ind	indicative
It.	Italian
LF	logical form
Occ.	occurrence
RCI	random choice interpretation
P*	pragmatically determined property
P,Q,R,S	predicates
QUALQUIER	all forms of <i>qualquiera</i> under investigation from Old Spanish to Modern Spanish
SHIFT	shifts of alternatives from individuals to propositions
SIM	similarity
Sp.	Spanish

Subj	subject
Sbjv	subjunctive
Subord.	subordinate
s.v.	sub voce
XP	phrase (e.g. NP, PP, VP, PrP, KindP, ModifP)
x, y, z	individual variables
$\wedge, \vee$	(and, or)
$\exists, \forall$	(exists, all) quantifiers
λ	lambda operator
$\langle e, t \rangle$	predicate type
$\langle e \rangle$	individual type
$\langle s, t \rangle$	proposition type
$\langle t \rangle$	truth value type
ι	iota-operator

1 Introduction

Meaning variation and change of words or complex linguistic expressions are an integral part of language (change) (Blank 1997, Traugott 1989, Eckardt 2006, among others). However, the question as to how meaning change and variation exactly work is still an unresolved issue in linguistic research. Describing the meaning change of words in time and space and the mechanism underlying it is a challenging task as the historical and/or the cognitive or psychological conditions under which meaning change happens are not always given or known. This is probably one of the reasons why there are different views on meaning change and variation. Some linguists take a more algorithmic and logical perspective on describing this mechanism, assuming that meaning change is based on a compositional reanalysis of the prior meaning into a new meaning, that is, the reanalysis can be made fully transparent and explainable by formal semantic principles as argued by formal diachronic semanticists (Eckardt 2006, Bar-Asher Siegal 2020, Condoravdi 2015, Aloni 2021, among many others). According to these authors, it is possible to describe the reanalysis involved in meaning change on the level of morphosyntactic form (F) and the level of meaning (M) (see also Detges et al. 2021). The important claim of formal diachronic semantics on meaning change is that at both points of time (t_1 and t_2), F suits M in a compositional manner — this is necessary for a reanalysis to take place (see Eckardt 2006, Bar-Asher Siegal 2020, Aloni 2021). The compositionality principle can be summarised as follows. A complex linguistic expression E such as *The boy is sleeping* is compositional if the meaning of E depends on, and only on, (i) the (morpho)syntactic structure of E and (ii) the meanings of E's simple linguistic units (Frege 1997). In other words, the meaning of E depends on the meaning of the definite article *the* and the noun *boy*, which combined together syntactically provide a more complex meaning of 'a particular boy mentioned previously in the discourse', the meaning of the verbal aspect morphology expressed in *is* + Verb + *ing* and the meaning of the verbal lemma *sleep*, which combined together provide the meaning of 'is sleeping' and, finally, the combined meaning of the complex expressions has the sentence meaning 'the boy is sleeping'. The general idea of diachronic formal semantics is that meaning variation and change take place in a transparent way and that every diachronic stage or step in the reanalysis process involves compositionality.

Other linguists take a different perspective assuming that meaning change does not need to be fully compositional or transparent (Croft & Cruse 2012, De Smet & Fischer 2017, among many others).

This book has the general goal of testing the compositionality and the transparency principle in formal diachronic semantics on meaning change and variation of the modal indefinite *cualquiera* ‘any’ in Argentinian and European Spanish in synchrony and diachrony. More precisely, my main goal is to investigate the question as to how the modal meaning of the indefinite *cualquiera* ‘any’ changed into evaluative meanings ‘common/unremarkable’ in European and Argentinian Spanish and into the evaluative meaning ‘nonsense’ in Argentinian Spanish, and how this change fits models of linguistic reanalysis in the frameworks of compositional analysis of meaning change in formal diachronic semantics. While acknowledging functionalist accounts of language change, this book places greater emphasis on testing principles of compositionality and formal transparency, focusing on how structural meaning components interact and reconfigure over time.

1.1 Structure of the book

In Section 1.2 and 1.3, I provide an introduction into the meanings of *cualquiera*, which will define the scope of my study. In Section 1.4, I give a short overview of the current state of the art on meaning change of *cualquiera*, and in Section 1.5, I present very briefly the general methods that will be used to approach my research questions.

Chapter 2 offers a detailed review of the data and analyses discussed in the literature concerning *cualquiera* in Modern European and Latin American Spanish in synchrony and diachrony. We will see that most synchronic and diachronic approaches do not investigate how the new meanings of *cualquiera* are related to the modal meaning ‘any’ and what might have triggered this meaning change.

In Chapter 3, I will present new data and a new analysis of special readings of *cualquiera* in modern European Spanish by extracting new corpus data.

In Chapter 4, I will focus on *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish in synchrony and diachrony and will suggest a synchronic and diachronic analysis for *cualquiera* in this variety.

Chapter 5 presents my research on the diachrony of *cualquiera* in European Spanish. In this chapter, I will focus on the distribution of *cualquiera* in various linguistic contexts or variables such as verbal position and verbal properties of the sentence in which *cualquiera* occurs across time. I will raise the question of

whether these variables play any role in the meaning change of *cualquiera* across time using a quantitative/statistical analysis. In this chapter, I will provide a formal semantic analysis of different steps that led to meaning change of *cualquiera* and its diachronic development.

Finally, Chapter 6 summarises the most important findings of this book and their implications for theoretical research on meaning change.

1.2 Modal reading of Spanish *cualquiera*

The main interest here is the indefinite *cualquiera*, which can roughly be translated with ‘any’ and is hence usually described as a free choice item (FCI) in (certain varieties of) Spanish (see Brucart 1999, Sánchez López 1999, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011/2018, Rivero 2011, Eberenz 2000). To introduce this item and before I turn to its semantics (which is the main focus of this book), let us have a brief look at its syntax and morphology:

- (1) a. *cualquier* libro
CUALQUIERA book
‘any book’
- b. una camisa *cualquiera*
a shirt CUALQUIERA
‘any shirt’ (Aloni et al. 2011: 2 / DLE, s.v. *cualquiera*)
- (2) Esto lo puede hacer *cualquiera*.
this it can do CUALQUIERA
‘Anybody can do this.’ (@ 1¹)

In (1), *cualquiera* is an invariable indefinite element, which can occur pre- or postnominally. In its prenominal position (1a), it usually drops the *-a* and is not preceded by any article, in contrast to the postnominal position, as in (1b), where it is preceded by an indefinite article and cannot drop the *-a*. In (2), it is an indefinite pronoun. In this function, the final *-a* is always preserved. It does not vary for number and gender, its morphological plural form (*cualesquiera*) being almost obsolete today (de Bruyne 2011: 236).

¹The symbol @ indicates that the source of this example is from an internet source. The number represents the index under which the example can be found in the Appendix, where all sources are listed.

1 Introduction

FCIs are indefinites that come along with a free choice implicature or inference (i.e. each individual is a permissible option) (see Arregui 2006, Aloni & Port 2013, Aloni 2021, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018, among many others):

- (3) *Puedes traer cualquier libro.*
can bring CUALQUIER book
'You can bring any book.'
Conventional meaning: 'You can bring me a book and each book is a possible option.' (Aloni et al. 2011: 2)

Cualquier(a) is described in the literature as a lexically encoded free choice indefinite because its free choice inference seems to be integrated into its semantic content in sentences like (3) (see Aloni & Port 2013, Aloni 2021, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018), whereas the free choice inference is possible but not necessarily available with plain indefinites such as *uno* in (4) (see Aloni 2021):

- (4) *Puedes traer un libro.*
can bring a book
'You can bring a book.'
a. Conventional meaning: 'You can bring a book.'
b. Free choice inference: 'Each book is a possible option.'
(Aloni et al. 2011: 2)

FCIs are known to appear in modal contexts such as with modal verbs — followed by *que* 'that' — to introduce free relative clauses with a subjunctive verb, as in (5) (see Quer 2000, Giannakidou 2001, among many others). This also applies to *cualquiera*:

- (5) *Cualquiera que sea tu caso, vamos a intentar que en este artículo encuentres la respuesta.*
find.2SG the answer
'Whatever your case is, we will try to make sure you find the answer in this article.'
FC: 'Each case is a possible option.'
(@ 2)

Importantly, it has been noted in the literature that *cualquiera* as well as comparable items in other Romance languages can have a series of different other interpretations that diverge from the free choice implicature (cf. Alonso-Ovalle

& Menéndez-Benito 2011: 29, Rivero 2011 for Spanish; Fălăuș 2015 for *oarecare* in Romanian; and Chierchia 2006: 543 for *qualunque* in Italian). As will be shown, this is also the case in Spanish.

In what follows, I present interpretations other than the free choice interpretation triggered in modal contexts, such as in (4) or (5).

1.3 Special readings of Spanish *cualquiera*

First, the indefinite *cualquiera* can have a random choice interpretation (RCI) in postnominal position with volitional verbs with perfective aspect (6) (cf. Choi & Romero 2008, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011: 29 and Rivero 2011 for Spanish; Fălăuș 2015 for *oarecare* in Romanian; Chierchia 2006: 543, Kellert 2021 for *qualunque/qualsiasi* in Italian; and Vlachou 2007, 2012 for *quelconque* in French):

- (6) Juan cogió una carta *cualquiera*.
 Juan grabbed a card CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan picked a random card.’

Random choice interpretation (RCI): ‘Juan picked a card, and he chose it indiscriminately — he could have picked any other.’

(Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 13)

RCI is also known under the term ‘indiscriminative function’, i.e. it conveys the agent’s indifference with respect to his/her choice from a given set of alternatives (for Spanish, see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2015: 14, Horn 2000 for English; Vlachou 2007, 2012 for French). The indiscriminative function has been also observed for *wh-ever* relatives in English; for further illustration of this function, see the sentence in (7), where *whatever* indicates that the agent’s (in this case the speaker’s) choice of tool was indiscriminate (von Fintel 2000):

- (7) I grabbed whatever tool was handy.
 (von Fintel 2000: 32)

Second, postnominal *cualquiera* can also have an evaluative interpretation (EVAL). It describes the speaker’s (negative) attitude towards some entity, for example that he/she finds Juan ordinary² (for Spanish, see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011: 29 and Šimík 2008 for Czech)

²Note that EVAL is a descriptive term that refers to different attitude predicates that have different flavours or readings such as ‘ordinary’, ‘common’, or ‘unremarkable’. These different flavours highly depend on the context (see Section 3).

1 Introduction

- (8) Juan es un hombre *cualquiera*. (Spanish)
Juan is a man CUALQUIERA
'Juan is an ordinary man.' (EVAL)
(@ 3)

Third, postnominal *cualquiera* can also have a depreciatory meaning of 'worthless' or refer to low quality (see Rivero 2011, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011 for Spanish; Fălăuș 2015 for Romanian *oarecare*; Vlachou 2007, 2012 on French and Greek FCIs). I consider this meaning to be a subset of the evaluative interpretation (EVAL):

- (9) Es un hombre *cualquiera*. (Spanish)
is a man CUALQUIERA
'He is a man without great qualities.' (EVAL)
(@ 4)

The evaluative reading is particularly interesting, because it leads to further processes of recategorisation and lexicalisation. For example, the French FCI *quelconque* 'whichever' shows a shift from a free choice indefinite to a gradable adjective:

- (10) Elle m'a paru assez *quelconque*. (French)
she me has looked quite QUELCONQUE
'She looked quite common to me.'
(Vlachou 2012: 1530)

Similarly, the French FCI *n'importe quoi* ('whatever', lit. 'does not matter what') can also be used to express EVAL. In contrast to the adjectival use of *quelconque* in (10), *n'importe quoi* is a noun that can be modified by an adjective and has the meaning 'nonsense/bullshit':

- (11) Il raconte du grand *n'importe quoi*. (French)
he tells of-the big N'IMPORTE QUOI
'He talks real bullshit.'
(@ 138)

In the course of this book, I will show similar effects for Argentinian Spanish (ArgSp), where *cualquiera* has lexicalised the meaning EVAL and can nowadays be used as a gradable adjective modifiable by degree adverbs or the degree modifier *muy* or *re* (Rizzo Salierno 2013: 27):

- (12) La peli es (re/muy) *cualquiera*. (ArgSp)
 the movie is very CUALQUIERA
 ‘The movie is (very) unremarkable/bad/not of great interest.’³
 (@ 5 / @ 6)

Cualquiera in Argentinian Spanish can also be used as a noun under transitive verbs, similar to *n’importe quoui* in (11) with the meaning ‘nonsense/bullshit’:

- (13) Me dijiste *cualquiera*. (ArgSp)
 me said CUALQUIERA
 ‘You told me bullshit/nonsense.’
 (@ 7)

In this book, I distinguish between *cualquiera* with the interpretation of ‘unremarkable, bad, not of great interest’, which is mostly found as a predicative complement as in (12) (henceforth: EVAL1) and *cualquiera* embedded under transitive verbs with the meaning ‘bullshit/nonsense’ as in (13) (henceforth: EVAL2).

We find the same lexicalisation pattern in Mexican Spanish for the lexical item *equis* (originally meaning ‘the letter x’), which can be used as an indefinite with a free choice interpretation ‘any’ in conditional clauses as in (14) as shown in Kellert (2020: 137), but can also function as a gradable adjective that expresses EVAL1 as shown in (15) (see Kellert 2020: 139):

- (14) Si por *equis* razón no vas a venir, avísame (MexSp)
 if for X reason NEG go.2SG to come let.me.know
 ‘If you cannot come for whatever reason, inform me.’
 (Kellert 2020: 137)
- (15) un hombre bastante/ demasiado/ muy *equis* (MexSp)
 a man quite/ too/ very X
 ‘a very ordinary man (with no special qualities)’
 (Kellert 2020: 138)

Finally, *cualquiera* can be interpreted as Negative Polarity Item (NPI) in European Spanish, i.e. as an existential indefinite in the scope of negation with the interpretation of ‘not ... any’ (see de Bruyne 2011, §497, Arregui 2006, Chierchia 2006, among others):

³The degree modifier *re* is used in Argentinian Spanish to reinforce the meaning of linguistic expressions. When *re* is combined with gradable adjectives, it has the meaning of ‘very’ (see Rizzo Salierno 2013 and Chapter 4 for further discussion).

1 Introduction

- (16) Estos últimos, además de no comer carne y pescado, no comen these last.ones besides of NEG eating meat and fish NEG eat *cualquier* cosa que sea de origen animal, como la miel, la leche CUALQUIER thing that be of origin animal like the honey the milk y los huevos. and the eggs
‘The latter ones, apart from not eating meat and fish, don’t eat any animal products such as honey, milk, and eggs.’
(@ 8)

However, the NPI interpretation of *cualquiera* as ‘anything’ is restricted to relative clause modification, because without relative clause modification, *cualquiera* has the meaning ‘everything’ or a ‘not just any’ interpretation under negation (see Arregui 2006, among others; for the general phenomenon, see Chierchia 2006):

- (17) No comen *cualquier* cosa.
NEG eat CUALQUIER thing
‘They don’t eat everything.’ or ‘They don’t eat just anything. They eat something special.’
‘They don’t eat anything.’
(@ 9)

Given all the meanings in the examples from (1) to (17), the question arises as to whether these meanings reflect lexical ambiguity or polysemy. In this case, each reading of *cualquiera* has a different denotation (as with the word *paper* in English, which can denote a newspaper, an academic publication, or the physical material itself) (see Hypothesis 1). In the other case, *cualquiera* has only one denotation and the different meanings described above are the result of some pragmatic inference on top of the semantic denotation (see Hypothesis 2):

- (18) Hypothesis 1: *Cualquiera* has different denotations (a case of polysemy).
Hypothesis 2: *Cualquiera* has one denotation and several readings follow from this denotation.

In this book, I will argue that the latter case is true for European Spanish and that *cualquiera* has only one denotation there, namely the denotation of an existential quantifier with the meaning ‘some (or other)’ (see Fălăuș 2014, Aloni 2021, among others for analysing FCIs as existential quantifiers), whereas it is lexically ambiguous in Argentinian Spanish (‘some or other’ and ‘bad’).

1.4 Open issues in previous research and goals of the present book

Despite some progress in the research on free choice indefinites, there is still no agreement about the semantic relation between RCI and EVAL1 (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2015: 4), that is, on whether these interpretations or at least some subset of them have a common semantic source (i.e. semantic denotation) and, if so, how one interpretation is related to another. Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011) assume as a working hypothesis that *cualquiera* is ambiguous between the random choice interpretation (RCI) and the evaluative interpretation as ‘unremarkable’ (EVAL1) in Modern Spanish. However, as they mention themselves, this working hypothesis should be studied in detail (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011: 41). In this work, I will test this hypothesis. Moreover, I will also study *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, which allows EVAL2, in contrast to European Spanish, as will be shown in Section 4.

1.4 Open issues in previous research and goals of the present book

Most synchronic accounts of *cualquiera* focus on one of its particular interpretations such as the random choice interpretation (see Choi & Romero 2008, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011) or the free choice interpretation (see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010, Aloni & Port 2013, Fălăuş 2015, among others). There is no systematic investigation of the distribution and restrictions of the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera*. Moreover, previous accounts do not try to unify the meanings that we are concerned with in this investigation or to derive one meaning from the other. It thus remains to be seen whether the evaluative meaning can be derived from the free choice function of indefinites.

The main aim of this book is to fill this gap by offering a new analysis that can unify different meanings of *cualquiera* that look unrelated in synchrony, namely the FCI and RCI meanings ‘any’ and ‘random’ and the EVAL meanings ‘ordinary, bad, common, nonsense’. In order to achieve this goal, it will be crucial to incorporate a diachronic perspective on meaning variation. In fact, as I will demonstrate, it turns out that at some diachronic stage, EVAL1 was derived from FCI through a certain syntactic and semantic reanalysis of FCIs. By looking at the history of the meanings and functions of *cualquiera* we will be able to identify how one particular meaning evolved from the other. In sum, a diachronic perspective can help us to reconstruct the relation between different meanings in a compositional way.

This perspective of combining synchrony and diachrony has not been discussed so far in the literature on the semantic evolution of *cualquiera*. The few

existing diachronic studies concentrate on the question of how the pronoun *qual* (*cual* in Modern Spanish) and the verb form *quiera* (want.3SG.PRES.SBJV) became grammaticalised into one complex compound (see Palomo 1934, Lombard 1938–39/47–48, Rivero 1988, Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, Mackenzie 2019, among others). These accounts, however, do not discuss the question of what consequences this grammaticalisation process has for the interpretational component of *cualquiera*. Furthermore, it is still unclear when and how the different meanings associated with this form have emerged.

Moreover, there is no systematic quantitative analysis of diachronic data on *cualquiera* that includes a statistical significance test providing empirical support for a change. While Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo (2009) and Aloni & Port (2013) have presented a quantitative description of *cualquiera*, they did not use any statistical test to verify their hypotheses. Also, the classification of the data in the literature is not satisfactory. Aloni & Port (2013) examine a number of syntactic and semantic properties of *cualquiera*, but they do not attempt to establish a correlation between the different factors considered. From their results we do not learn whether different functions correlate with different syntactic positions of *cualquiera* (e.g. +/- prenominal position, +/- preverbal, +/- appearance in episodic context or copular constructions).

In view of the shortcomings of previous studies, it seems relevant to use a more detailed syntactic classification for a corpus analysis of synchronic and diachronic data on *cualquiera*. In particular, I will look at the morphosyntactic and semantic properties of the verb forms that co-occur in the sentences in which *cualquiera* appears and will describe them with respect to their modality, lexical specification, tense, and aspect. This will allow us to observe correlations between the different meanings of *cualquiera* and the aforementioned verbal properties. As for the diachrony of *cualquiera*, I will investigate the first occurrences of its different meanings in order to draw conclusions about the order in which these meanings appeared over time.

In light of these empirical and theoretical gaps, this book aims not only to unify the different meanings of *cualquiera* through a diachronic compositional analysis but also to make a methodological contribution by grounding this analysis in a combination of annotated corpus data, statistical evaluation, and informal native speaker consultation. While most previous work has focused on isolated interpretations of *cualquiera*, this study systematically traces the development of its modal and evaluative readings across time and regional varieties. The approach taken here relies primarily on principles of compositionality and transparency in formal semantics rather than functionalist or discourse-based explanations. Through this lens, the book explores how shifts in meaning can be modelled

as semantically and syntactically motivated reanalyses. In doing so, it presents the first comprehensive monograph on *cualquiera* that integrates corpus-based evidence, diachronic distribution, and theoretical modelling to account for both synchronic variation and historical change.

1.5 Data and methodology

In order to describe the evaluative properties of *cualquiera* in Modern European Spanish, I have extracted data with a noun + *cualquiera* (henceforth (UN) N *cualquiera*) from the *Corpus del Español web dialects* (CdE_web), which is annotated for different regional varieties of Spanish. The data on the postnominal as well as on the pronoun *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish and in other Latin American varieties including European Spanish was extracted from the corpus *Corpus del Español*.

In order to respond to my diachronic research question, I have chosen 150 randomised occurrences per century from the 13th to the 20th centuries from the *Corpus del Español_hist-gen* (henceforth CdE_hist-gen) and have annotated them according to 30 syntactic and semantic properties. As some of the texts contained in CdE_hist-gen are taken from editions that have low philological reliability, as reported in Octavio de Toledo & Rodríguez Molina (2017), I selected only those texts that these authors classify as suitable for linguistic analysis. In addition, I used particular search algorithms, which will be specified in the respective parts of the description of the corpus analysis. These algorithms were designed to target approximations of syntactic and semantic properties of my small sample in the whole corpus CdE_hist-gen. The goal of this task was to see whether it is possible to identify similar linguistic patterns of diachronic change in the whole corpus without taking into account manual annotation and the distinction between texts regarding their philological reliability. For the diachronic research in Argentinian Spanish, I used the diachronic corpus CORDIAM, *Corpus Diacrónico y Diatópico del Español*, which contains a total of 10,889,176 words from 19 Latin-American countries from 1494 to 1905, with documents from archives, journals, and literature. It is annotated for geographical origins. The corpus CORDIAM does not contain many instances of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish in comparison to CdE_hist-gen (around 150 in total). I therefore also used a larger diachronic corpus, CORDE (*Corpus Diacrónico del Español*), which is a diachronic corpus with written texts spanning from Old Spanish to 1974 with annotation of geographic origin (country), and which contains 544 instances of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish. I analysed all diachronic data from Argentinian Spanish from CORDIAM and CORDE as the data collection was relatively small.

1 Introduction

The data I analysed for the quantitative analysis can be found on GitHub: <https://github.com/olga-kel/Historical-Linguistics>.

The quantitative analysis was based on statistical methods such as the chi-square test and the linear regression model (see Baayen 2008). I have used the R software programme for the statistical analysis of the data. The generation of the plots and histograms was carried out in Microsoft Excel.

Corpora are the main source of data in this book. In addition to the corpus data, I informally consulted several native speakers of European and Argentinian Spanish. These consultations were not part of a systematic experimental survey but served to validate the corpus-based analysis of the use and interpretation of *cualquiera* through selective, informal interviews. These interviews were conducted with linguistics students from Spain, as well as with members of the Facebook group *Lingüística Argentina*, where both students and instructors with a background in linguistics responded to my questions. The selection of informants with linguistic training is based on the assumption that such individuals tend to be more reliable language informants, as they are often better able to articulate and reflect on language use. The informal judgments were used to assess whether speakers' intuitions align with the corpus-based findings, which remain the central foundation of this study. Future experimental work will be necessary to more systematically describe the distribution of *cualquiera* in both European and Argentinian Spanish.

For the semantic analysis of synchronic and diachronic data, I used formal semantic frameworks of FCIs (Chierchia 2006, Aloni 2021, Aloni & Port 2013, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018, among others) and models of semantic reanalysis within formal semantics (Eckardt 2006, Aloni & Port 2013, among others).

2 Current state of research on *cualquiera*

In this chapter, I review the current state of research on modern uses of *cualquiera* in different varieties of Spanish. Many empirical and theoretical studies of *cualquiera* are based on European Spanish, as will be shown in this chapter. There are a few descriptive studies of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish (ArgSp) (see Section 2.1.5). However, these studies do not relate the description of *cualquiera* to the theoretical studies discussed in Section 2.2 through Section 2.5. I will fill this gap in Chapters 3 and 4 by analysing the variation between Modern European and Modern Argentinian Spanish in theoretical terms. I will also look at the diachrony of *cualquiera* in Chapters 4 and 5, which will show the syntactic and semantic conditions under which the evaluative meaning can occur in diachrony.

2.1 Informal description of syntactic and semantic properties of modern *cualquiera*

In European Spanish (EurSp), *cualquiera* can be used as a pronoun, determiner, noun, and postnominal modifier. As a pronoun and determiner, it has a restricted distribution with respect to verb mood and modality. However, as I will show, this restricted distribution is not present with *cualquiera* as a noun or postnominal modifier. In modern Argentinian Spanish, the word can also be used as a gradable adjective without the verb mood restrictions found in European Spanish. As many uses of *cualquiera* are the same in both varieties (Argentinian and European Spanish) – besides its use as an evaluative noun with the meaning of ‘nonsense’ and as an adjective in the sense of ‘bad/ordinary’ in Argentinian Spanish but not in European Spanish – I only explicitly mark the language variety Argentinian Spanish, when these special uses are important for the discussion.

2.1.1 Classification of indefinites

Table 2.1 shows a classification of indefinites across languages that takes into account their syntactic and semantic properties according to Haspelmath (1997). This classification will help to characterise the uses of *cualquiera* in synchrony and diachrony. As can be seen, the evaluative meanings of indefinites as described in Section 1 for *cualquiera* and other indefinites in Romance languages are missing.

Table 2.1: Classification system of FCIs according to Haspelmath (1997)
adapted from Aloni, Guevara, et al. (2010)

Abbr.	Label	Example
SK	specific known	Somebody called. Guess who?
SU	specific unknown	I heard something, but I couldn't tell what it was.
IR	irrealis	You must try somewhere else.
Q	question	Did anybody tell you anything about it?
CA	conditional antecedent	If you see anything, tell me immediately.
CO	comparative	In Freiburg, the weather is nicer than anywhere else in Germany.
DN	direct negation	John didn't see anybody.
AM	anti-morphic	I don't think that anybody knows the answer.
AA	anti-additive	The gravity of such act goes beyond any justification.
FC	free choice	Anybody can solve this problem.
UFC	universal free choice	John kissed any woman with red hair.
GEN	generic	Any dog has four legs.
IND	indiscriminative	I do not want to go to bed with just anyone anymore.

One important concept to describe the meaning of indefinites like *cualquiera* is genericity. Genericity refers to the way in which language expresses generalisations about kinds or classes of entities, rather than specific instances of those kinds (Carlson 1977, Krifka et al. 1995). This can involve statements about typical properties or behaviors of a group as a whole, rather than about individual members of that group. Generic sentences are not anchored in any specific point in time or specify any particular referents. For example, *Any dog has four legs* is

2.1 Informal description of the properties of modern *cualquiera*

a characterising sentence because it makes a general statement about dogs as a category. In contrast, *Ben's dog is dangerous* is specific.

2.1.2 The pronoun *cualquiera* and the determiner *cualquier*

Cualquiera can be used as an indefinite pronoun in modern Spanish to express generic statements, i.e. statements about every person or every entity, especially when it is used as a subject in declarative sentences (Brucart 1999, Sánchez López 1999, Eberenz 2000, DLE, s.v. *cualquiera*):

- (1) Esto lo hace *cualquiera*.
this it does CUALQUIERA
'Anybody does this.'
(@ 12)
- (2) *Cualquiera* lo hubiera hecho mejor.
CUALQUIERA it have.SBJV done better
'Anybody would have done it better.'
(@ 13)

The indefinite pronoun *cualquiera* can be followed by a prepositional phrase [*de* DP] 'of DP' (Sánchez López 1999: 1041, DLE, s.v. *cualquiera*) in which case the DP restricts the quantificational domain of *cualquiera*, e.g. in examples (3) and (4) the quantification applies to a particular set of reasons and translators, respectively (for the quantificational property of *cualquiera*, see Section 2.2):

- (3) *cualquiera* de las razones enumeradas
CUALQUIERA of the reasons listed
'any of the listed reasons'
(@ 14a)
- (4) *cualquiera* de esos traductores
CUALQUIERA of those translators
'any of those translators'
(@ 14b)

Cualquiera can also be used as a (quantificational) determiner¹ similar to *cada* 'each' in declarative sentences to express generic statements (Sánchez López 1999:

¹In this book, I will use the terminology of Zamparelli (2000) to refer to quantifiers in prenominal position such as *some/any/every N* and the Spanish counterparts as (quantificational) determiners.

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1034, 1036; DLE, s.v. *cualquiera*; Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010; Rivero 2011):

- (5) *Cualquier* persona tiene derecho a decidir sobre su cuerpo.
CUALQUIER person has right to decide about their body
'Any person has the right to decide about her/his body.'
(@ 15)
- (6) *Cualquier* ciudadano tiene derecho a elegir.
CUALQUIER citizen has right to vote
'Any citizen has the right to vote.'
(@ 14c)

The similar interpretation of *cualquiera* and universal quantifiers such as *cada* 'each' and *todo* 'all' can be illustrated by the adverbial modification of both universal quantifiers and *cualquiera* by *casi* 'almost' and other adverbs such as *excepto* 'except/but' that restrict the domain of quantification from every possible element to a smaller part (see Arregui 2006, among others):

- (7) *Casi* todos saben hablar inglés.
almost everyone know speak English
'Almost everybody can speak English.'
(@ 17)
- (8) *Casi cualquiera* puede decirte eso.
almost CUALQUIERA can tell.you that
'Almost anybody can tell you that.'
(Arregui 2006, e.g. 65 a.)

Cualquiera can be used as a determiner inside a Determiner Phrase (DP) that specifies a relative clause with a subjunctive as shown in (9). This relative clause has an indifference interpretation, 'I don't care about the flaws he has' (see DLE, s.v. *cualquiera*):

- (9) *Cualquier* defecto que tenga, yo lo voy a querer igual.
CUALQUIER defect that has I him will to love anyway
'Whatever flaws he/it has, I will love him/it anyway.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 24, @ 18)

Subjunctive relative clauses such as the one in (9) are interpreted similar to conditional clauses as in (10) (see Quer 2000):

2.1 Informal description of the properties of modern *cualquiera*

- (10) Aunque tenga defectos, yo lo voy a querer igual.
although have.3SG.SBJV defects I him will to love anyway
'Even if he/it has flaws, I will love him/it anyway.'
(@ 19)

Both types of conditionals require a subjunctive. The subjunctive includes worlds other than the actual world. Thus, the example in (9) not only takes into account the actual world where the person under discussion might have only a specific flaw, but all other flaws in all possible worlds that the speaker can think of (see Quer 2000, Chierchia 2006, Becker 2014 on the role of the subjunctive). The effect of the subjunctive in the relative clause is that the assertion 'I will love him' is pragmatically strengthened, because it is evaluated with respect to worlds in which the person under discussion might have some or all kinds of flaws. The assertion is considered as true without any restriction.

We now turn to *cualquiera* as a pronoun. In this use, it can have different syntactic functions, such as that of a subject pronoun, as shown in (11), or as a copular predicate inside a conditional clause with a subjunctive, as in (12).

- (11) *Cualquiera* sea el defecto que tiene, yo lo voy a querer
CUALQUIERA be.3SG.SBVJ the defect that has I them will to love
igual.
anyway
'Whatever may be the flaw she has, I will love him anyway.'
(@ 20)

- (12) Sea *cualquiera* el defecto que tiene, yo lo voy a querer
be.3SG.SBVJ CUALQUIERA the defect that has I him will to love
igual.
anyway
'Whatever be the flaw he has, I will love him anyway.'
(@ 21)

It is a very common observation in the literature that free choice indefinites have a restricted distribution (Quer 2000, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018, among many others). They are usually licensed in modal contexts, e.g. with modal and generic verbs or in the subjunctive (see Chapter 1.2) and ruled out in episodic² sentences in English

²I define a context as episodic if the sentence at issue involves an event variable *e*, and *e* is existentially closed: *Jean is eating fruits*. $\exists e$ [eating fruits (*e*) & Agent (*e*, Jean)].

and Spanish, which are usually marked by perfective aspect as in (13) (see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010, Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. 2010, Dayal 2013, among others):

- (13) a. *Juan cogió *cualquiera* de las cartas de esta baraja.
 Juan take.3SG.PST CUALQUIERA of the cards from this deck
 ‘Juan took any of the cards from this deck.’
 b. *John took any of the cards from this deck.
 (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010: 34)

However, as has been noted by Quer (2000), Rivero (2011), and Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2010), among others, it is possible to find the determiner *cualquiera* in episodic contexts only if the noun phrase is modified by a relative clause (so-called ‘subtriggering’ examples):

- (14) a. *Juan compró *cualquier* revista.
 Juan bought CUALQUIER magazine
 ‘Juan bought any magazine.’
 b. Juan compró *cualquier* revista que tuviera fotos de
 Juan bought CUALQUIER magazine that had photos of
 actualidad.
 current events
 ‘Juan bought whatever magazine had photos of current events.’
 (Rivero 2011: 67)

Quer (2000) argues that free choice indefinites (FCIs) like *cualquiera* are licensed by relative clauses, as in example (14b). These clauses create a context where we talk not just about one specific event, but about many possible situations – for example, things that usually happened in the past. In this context, the meaning of *cualquiera* becomes connected to the idea that something was true in many similar situations or possible worlds, which means different versions of how things could have happened. The clauses as in (14b) introduce a modal context, which is linked to the quantificational meaning of habitual or generic sentences in the past, where a generic operator quantifies over possible worlds or situations (see Krifka et al. 1995). The sentence in (14b) has a conditional interpretation associated with generic/characterising statements: if there was a magazine with current events, John would buy it, or every time there was a magazine with photos of current events, John would buy that magazine. The typical cases of licensing of FCIs under subtriggering involve modal contexts such

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as a conditional-like interpretation. To sum up, given its restriction to modal contexts, *cualquiera* as a determiner and as a pronoun is ungrammatical as the object of a present or past tense indicative verb that refers to a specific event or situation as in (14a).

What has not been investigated in the literature so far is the use of determiner or pronoun *cualquiera* under indicative copular verbs that predicate over individuals or entities. In the following context, the property of being a man is predicated over the person Juan. In this context, only the indefinite article *un* is judged as acceptable by speakers, whereas the determiner *cualquier* and the pronoun *cualquiera* are not, according to the literature Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011) and speakers' judgments in informal elicitation:

- (15) Juan es un hombre (de 30 años).
Juan is a man of 30 years
'Juan is a (30-year-old) man.'
(@ 22)
- (16) a. * Juan es *cualquier* hombre (de 30 años).
Juan is CUALQUIER man (of 30 years)
'Juan is any 30-year-old man.'
- b. * Juan es *cualquiera*
Juan is anyone
'Juan is anyone.'

One possible explanation of the ungrammaticality in (16a) is that *cualquier/cualquiera* are not used in the modal or generic context required for its licensing as shown in (6) through (12). However, if *cualquiera* is used in a licensing context such as a partitive phrase as in (17a) or a subtriggering clause as in (17b), the sentences are grammatical:

- (17) a. Si tu hospedaje es *cualquiera* de estos hoteles a continuación
if your lodging is CUALQUIERA of these hotels at following
¡nos lo vas a agradecer!
us it going to thank
'If you are staying at any of these hotels mentioned below, you will
thank us!'
(@ 23)

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- b. Sabio es *cualquiera* que sepa seguir los movimientos,
wise is CUALQUIERA who know.3SG.SBJV follow the movements
las fases de la vida para mantener el yīn y yáng en armonía
the phases of the life to maintain the yīn and yáng in harmony
en su interior.
in their interior
'Wise is anyone who knows how to follow the movements, the life
cycles...'
(Genís Sol, *Flujo del espíritu humano*, 35)

To sum up, *cualquiera* as a pronoun or determiner is not licensed in episodic or affirmative predicative contexts without an overt modal.

One rescuing context of the determiner or the pronoun *cualquiera* in predicative contexts without a modal is negation, which shows that *cualquiera* is polarity-sensitive (see Chierchia 2006, Section 2.2.2 and Section 2.4 on FCIs under negation):

- (18) El Sr. Miguel Ángel no es *cualquier* empleado de CC.OO, es director
the Mr. Miguel Ángel not is CUALQUIER employee of CC.OO is director
del gabinete de estudios de CC.OO.
of.the office of studios of CC.OO.
'Mr. Miguel Ángel is not just any worker of CC.OO, he is the director of
CC.OO's research bureau'
(@ 24)
- (19) La curva que sale no es *cualquier* curva. Es una parábola.
the curve that come.out NEG is CUALQUIER curve is a parabola
'The resulting curve is not just any curve. It is a parabola.'
(@ 25)

To sum up, *cualquiera* as a pronoun or as a determiner is not permitted with indicative mood, which refers to actual situations or property descriptions in the actual world without subtriggering or negation.

2.1.3 Postnominal *cualquiera* and *cualquiera* as a noun

As will be shown in this section, postnominal *cualquiera* has a status different from that of the pronominal and the determiner *cualquiera*. The first difference is that postnominal *cualquiera* is usually used in indefinite noun phrases, as in (20) (i.e. the structure UN N *cualquiera*). In contrast to the determiner and pronoun

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cualquiera, UN N *cualquiera* can be used in contexts that refer to actual situations or properties of actual entities/individuals. The question is thus whether UN N *cualquiera* still expresses modality in these contexts.

In (20), it is asserted that Juan took a card. The semantic contribution of *cualquiera* is to express that this card was taken randomly, which is the so-called random choice interpretation (RCI). It is commonly assumed in the literature that this interpretation correlates with the appearance of volitional verbs, which imply some agent that has desires or goals, such as *coger* ‘to take/to pick’ as in (20). The RCI implies a modal meaning expressing that the agent Juan could have picked any other card (see Menéndez-Benito 2010, Choi & Romero 2008, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018, Sánchez López 1999: 1041; Arregui 2006; Rivero 2011):

- (20) Juan cogió una carta *cualquiera*.
 Juan picked a card CUALQUIERA.
 Random Choice (RC): Juan picked a card and he chose it indiscriminately
 – he could have picked any other.
 (Menéndez-Benito 2010: 2)

However, in affirmative contexts such as in (21)–(23), with indicative copular³ verbs as in (21) or with perception verbs such as *mirar* ‘to look (at)’ or *ver* ‘to see’ like in (23), *cualquiera* has the evaluative interpretation ‘ordinary/common/unremarkable’ (see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018, DLE, s.v. *cualquiera*):

- (21) Juan es un estudiante *cualquiera*.
 Juan is a student CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan is an unremarkable student.’ (EVAL)
 (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 3)

³The copula *be* has different uses (see Higgins 1979, Zamparelli 2000, Kellert 2015, and references therein). It can be used predicationally such as *Today is a common day (for me)*, or it can be used identificationally/specificationally *Today is the 21st of July 2010* or *Today is Monday*. The predicative use usually comes with an indefinite article such as *Today is a/*the nice day*. Another test to tease the functions apart is to look at the type of the subject of the copula. In the predicational use, the subject is an individual type, e.g. *Jean is a man*. In the identificational use, the subject is expressed by a demonstrative or deictic pronoun, e.g. *This is Jean* or *It's Jean*. According to this typology of copular verbs, it is easy to see that UN N *cualquiera* in *Juan es un hombre cualquiera* ‘Juan is an ordinary man’ or in *Es un hombre cualquiera* should be interpreted predicationally, i.e. UN N *cualquiera* is a copular complement that describes some property of Juan. From this point on, I will use the term predicative *cualquiera* to refer to UN N *cualquiera* as a predicative complement of predicative verbs such as *ser* ‘be’ and similar verbs (*parecer* ‘resemble’, etc.).

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- (22) Eran dos mujeres *cualquiera*.
were two women CUALQUIERA
'They were two ordinary women.' (EVAL)
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 24, @ 26)
- (23) Te miró y vio un hombre *cualquiera*, no vio al diablo.
you looked and saw a man CUALQUIERA NEG saw the devil
'(S)he looked at you and (s)he saw in you an ordinary man, not the devil.'⁴ (EVAL)
(@ 14d)

The evaluative function can also be expressed in a sentence that refers to an episodic context, in which *cualquiera* modifies a noun that must refer to some entity or individual that the speaker knows and evaluates negatively, see the interpretation in (24a) (note that the native speakers I consulted informally also admit the so-called ignorance interpretation (IGN), as in (24b), where the speaker simply does not know the exact nature of the N):

- (24) La carta de ajuste, en la pantalla, se complementaba con la
the card of adjustment on the screen REFL complemented with the
música ramplona de una zarzuela *cualquiera*.
music mediocre of a zarzuela CUALQUIERA (@ 14e)
- a. 'The testcard, in the screen, was complemented with the vulgar
sound of some ordinary zarzuela.' (EVAL)
- b. '...with the vulgar sound of some zarzuela that I don't know.' (IGN)

Another type of evaluative meaning, namely the pejorative or derogatory interpretation, can be observed with *cualquiera* as a noun in UN *cualquiera*,⁵ see

⁴Although *un hombre cualquiera* appears syntactically as a direct object, it can be argued that it functions semantically as a *predicative complement*. In this construction, the NP does not refer to a specific, individuated entity but rather ascribes a *property* or *classification* to the referent of the pronoun *te*. This reading is supported by the contrastive structure of the sentence: "*no vio al diablo*" ('(s)he didn't see the devil'), which highlights that the speaker is categorising the addressee not as a specific man, but as *the kind of man who is ordinary or unremarkable*. This interpretation aligns with analyses of *object-predicate structures* found in sentences with verbs of perception or evaluation, such as *Lo consideró un héroe* ('He considered him a hero') or *La llamó una tonta* ('He called her a fool'), where the postverbal NP has a *classificatory* or *attributive* function.

⁵One could assume that *cualquiera* in *un(a) cualquiera* was historically interpreted as an adjective with an elided noun (e.g. 'person'). "Nominal gapping is permitted with PPs and postposed

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the examples in (25) and (26). The morphological plural form *cualesquiera*, which was used in earlier periods of Spanish (see Section 2.5), is no longer accepted in Modern (European) Spanish, as shown in (27) (DLE, s.v. *cualquiera*), although it is still marginally found in literary language:⁶

- (25) Juan es un *cualquiera*.
Juan is a CUALQUIERA
'Juan is a nobody.'
(Martínez García 2005: 36)
- (26) María es una *cualquiera*.
María is a CUALQUIERA
'María is a prostitute.'
(@ 27)
- (27) Son unos/unas *cualquiera*/**cualesquiera*.
are some CUALQUIERA/CUALESQUIERA
'They are nobodies/prostitutes.'
(@ 28/@ 29)

It seems that no modality is involved in contexts where UN (N) *cualquiera* has an evaluative meaning, such as under copular verbs. The question is thus what status *cualquiera* has in these predicative contexts with affirmative sentence mood and whether it is still used as an indefinite element there. It is often assumed in the literature that postnominal *cualquiera* acts as a determiner (see Section 2.1.4 on data and discussion of this assumption). Note that the postnominal *cualquiera* cannot be analysed as a (degree) adjective in European Spanish, because it cannot be modified by degree adverbs (see Section 2.1.5 for Argentinian Spanish):

- (28) Un hombre (*muy) *cualquiera*.
a man very CUALQUIERA
'A man (*very) *cualquiera*.'
(@ 4)

restricted adjectives in Spanish, as in *El Ø rojo* 'the red one' (Bosque 2001: 34). However, in contemporary Spanish, *un(a) cualquiera* has become lexicalised and typically refers to a 'prostitute'.

⁶In this work, I abstract away from singular and plural differences of *cualquiera* with respect to their interpretation.

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This conclusion is confirmed by the absence of morphological agreement. Adjectives usually inflect for person, number, and gender in Modern Spanish in contrast to *cualquiera* which is invariable (Seco 1986, s.v. *cualquiera*, Rainer 1993, s.v. *cualquiera*). In its marginal use in written Spanish, the plural is realised on *cual* (originally a relative pronoun) and not on the ending *-a* in *cualquiera*, as we would expect if *cualquiera* were lexicalised as an adjective:

- (29) ordinario, ordinaria, ordinarios, ordinarias
ordinary.M.SG. ordinary.F.SG. ordinary.M.PL. ordinary.F.PL.
'ordinary'
- (30) cualquiera, cual(es)quiera, *cualquiero, *cual(es)quieros,
cualquiera.SG. cualquiera.PL. cualquiera.M.SG. cualquiera.M.PL.
*cual(es)quieras
cualquiera.F.PL.
'any'

These restrictions can be accounted for diachronically as *cualquiera* is a morphological compound of the relative pronoun *cual* and the verb *querer* (see Chapter 5). This is why no gender or plural agreement on the ending *-a* (originally a subjunctive form) is possible in written Spanish (see Chapter 5).

However, we do find the plural form *-s* on the ending *-a* in some Latin American varieties of Spanish (e.g. *cualquieras que sean....*, see Rainer 1993: 298) and according to Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo (2009) few cases of spoken European Spanish (e.g. *unas cualquieras*, see Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009: 1125), which can be interpreted as a loss of transparency of the word *cualquiera* such that the item can no longer be interpreted compositionally as a compound of the relative pronoun *cual* and the verb *querer* in these varieties. As will be shown in Section 2.1.5, *cualquiera* can be analysed as an adjective in these varieties because of degree modification (see Section 2.1.5 for details):

- (31) La peli es (muy/re) cualquiera.
the movie is (very/really) CUALQUIERA
'The movie is (very) ordinary/mediocre.' ('okay' in ArgSp/ *EurSp)
(@ 5 / @ 6)

The variation in Spanish can be interpreted as a sign that the reanalysis of *cualquiera* from a relative clause into a degree predicate is more advanced in Argentinian Spanish than in European Spanish.

2.1.4 Syntactic analyses of postnominal *cualquiera*

The syntactic and semantic status of postnominal *cualquiera* is still unclear in the literature. Lapesa (2000) interprets the definiteness restriction of *un/*el hombre cualquiera* as evidence that *cualquiera* is a quantificational determiner like *cualquier* in *cualquier hombre*. The ‘determiner’ *cualquiera* can co-occur with *un* and not with *el* because *un* does not have any semantic content according to Lapesa (2000 [1974]). Determiners that do not have any semantic meaning are analysed as weak determiners in the literature, whereas determiners that contribute semantic content to the overall meaning are called strong determiners (see Zamparelli 2000).

The same observation and conclusion about the determiner status of *cualquiera* has been made by Rivero (2011), who has shown that postnominal *cualquiera* cannot combine with quantified or definite nouns, but only with bare nouns or indefinite nouns (*un, una, unos, unas* N-sg/N-pl) or nouns modified by numerals (*dos, tres*, etc.). The following example in (32) is from Rivero (2011: 72):

- (32) a. *Puedes comprar {muchos / algunos / todos / los / estos} libros
 can buy many some all the these books
 cualesquiera.
 CUALESQUIERA
 ‘You can buy {many/some/all/the/those} random books.’
- b. *Puedes comprar {este / ese / aquel / el } libro
 can buy DEM.PROX DEM.MED DEM.DIST the book
 cualquiera.
 CUALQUIERA
 ‘You can buy {this, that, the} random book.’

To conclude, it is assumed in the literature on postnominal *cualquiera* that it is a strong (quantificational) determiner because it cannot co-occur with other determiners of the same kind. As will be shown in Section 3.1 on corpus data from Modern Spanish, postnominal *cualquiera* can co-occur with other strong determiners. Similar data will be shown on diachronic corpus data in Section 5. I will conclude that postnominal *cualquiera* is not a determiner.

In order to explain the licensing of postnominal *cualquiera* in episodic contexts, Rivero (2011) assumes that postnominal *cualquiera* encodes lexical modality; that is, *cualquiera* licenses itself and thus does not need a licenser. According to Rivero (2011), the item *quiera* inside *cualquiera* is interpreted as a modal operator that creates a modal context and licenses *cualquiera*. The following structure is a

representation of the Logical Form (LF), according to which the item *quiera* is interpreted as a modal operator that scopes over the sentence with a perfective verb:

- (33) LF: [Sentence [Modal *quiera*] [Sentence Juan compró [NP [NumP una] revista cual [Modal *quiera*]]]]

Although Rivero (2011) did not consider predicative contexts in affirmative sentences in which UN N *cualquiera* is also licensed, one could assume that her explanation covers these cases as well:

- (34) LF: [Sentence [Modal *quiera*] [Sentence Juan es [NP [NumP un] hombre cual [Modal *quiera*]]]]

However, Rivero (2011) is silent about in what sense *cualquiera* expresses modality in unlicensed contexts such as episodic or predicative contexts.

2.1.5 *Cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish

Before turning to the use of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, it is important to introduce various forms of linguistic variation in order to understand the difference between European and Argentinian Spanish. Linguistic variation refers to the differences in language use among speakers or within a single speaker in different contexts. Diaphasic, diastratic and diamesic variation are important types of linguistic variation (Ferguson 1994, Labov 1972, Koch & Oesterreicher 2011). Diaphasic variation, also known as register or style variation, refers to the changes in language use depending on the context or situation. Diamesic variation is influenced by factors such as the formality of the situation or language use that varies on a scale from very formal to very informal or from “*Distanzsprache*” ‘language of distance’ to “*Nähesprache*” ‘language of immediacy’ in terms of Koch & Oesterreicher (2011) and Koch (1999). For example, a person might use formal language in an administrative/formal context (French: *Que désirez-vous manger?* ‘What do you want to eat?’) or informal language in the communication with friends (vs. *Vous voulez manger quoi?* ‘What do you want to eat?’).

Diastratic variation, also known as sociolectal variation, refers to the differences in language use associated with social groups (Labov 1972, Trudgill 2000). This type of variation is influenced by factors such as socio-economic status, age and gender.

2.1 Informal description of the properties of modern *cualquiera*

Argentinian Spanish is influenced by language-contact-induced variation in the context of Italian immigration and by a particular sociolect called *Lunfardo*.⁷ The status of Italian loanwords and Lunfardo in the present use of Argentinian Spanish became part of the Argentinian identity (Kailuweit 2016). Argentinian Spanish is an interesting variety for linguistic research due to the language contact and sociolect influence on the Spanish variety (see Conde 2011a,b, Engels & Kailuweit 2011, Kailuweit 2016, Würth 2019, Kellert 2023, Kellert & Francia 2024). The massive immigration of over 4 million Italians to Argentina in the late 19th/early 20th century triggered a well-known case of language-contact-induced variation in Spanish (see Engels & Kailuweit 2011). The majority of Italian loanwords used in Argentinian Spanish today (e.g., *pibe* ‘little kid, boy’, *laburo* ‘job’) belong to Lunfardo that originated in the lower classes of Buenos Aires (Engels & Kailuweit 2011, Würth 2019) and which is thought by some to have emerged among criminals and thieves (Moosekian 2016). According to Conde (2011b), Lunfardo became a “variety of Argentinian Spanish”, which nowadays mainly belongs to colloquial language (Teruggi 1974, de Weinberg & Beatriz 2000, Wunderlich 2012). Lunfardo and Italian loanwords have been studied based on various data types and methodologies such as a combination of historical and literary texts (Engels & Kailuweit 2011, Kailuweit 2016), interviews on personal perceptions of Lunfardo (Würth 2019), word recognition tasks (Moosekian 2016) and social media communication data (Kellert 2023, Kellert & Francia 2024). Some researchers tie the use of Lunfardo and Italian loanwords to social factors like wealth and status. Würth (2019) has shown in her study that Lunfardo is primarily used by the lower social classes. Moosekian (2016) has shown in her study that Lunfardo is no longer used by the younger generation. Kellert (2023), Kellert & Francia (2024) have shown a considerable use of Lunfardo words and Italian loanwords in social media communication, thereby confirming the observation that this sociolect is part of everyday communication and part of Argentinian identity as argued by Kailuweit (2016).

A special use of *cualquiera* is found in Argentinian Spanish according to studies of Conde (2011a), Rizzo Salierno (2013). These studies describe the usage of *cualquiera* as belonging to informal and colloquial contexts as used primarily by the younger population. According to Conde (2011a) it has a function of an indefinite pronoun with the meaning similar to *cualquier cosa* ‘anything’ and mean-

⁷*Lunfardo* originated from waves of massive immigration from Europe between 1881 and 1914 (see Fernando 2002). Lunfardo was originally spoken only in the River Plate region, with a vocabulary enriched from several immigrant languages including Italian (Conde 2011a). Sociolinguistic properties of Lunfardo still reflect some connection to Italian immigration (Kellert & Francia (2024).

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ings derived thereof in expressions like *decir cualquiera* or *mandar cualquiera* ‘say something out of place, inconvenient, tell a lie’ or in expressions like *estar en cualquiera* ‘to be in a bad situation, be in trouble’ (literally ‘to be in any [place]’; see also Company-Company 2009a for *estar en cualquiera*). This use is documented for Lunfardo.

- (35) Lexical entry of *cualquiera* (Conde 2011a, *Diccionario etimológico del lunfardo*, s.v.)
cualquiera. pron. indef. En las exprs. ss.: DECIR o MANDAR CUALQUIERA: decir algo fuera de lugar, inconveniente o disparatado; inventar una mentira. | 2. ESTAR EN CUALQUIERA: pertenecer a ambientes delictivos o relacionados con la drogadicción; estar distraído. (Del esp. *cualquiera*: persona intedeterminada, que pasa a significar aquí “cualquier cosa”.)
‘*cualquiera*. indef. pronoun. In the expressions such as: DECIR o MANDAR CUALQUIERA: say something out of place, inconvenient, or unreflected; to invent a lie. | 2. 2. ESTAR EN CUALQUIERA: to belong to criminal environment or to environments related to drug addiction; to be distracted. (From Sp. *cualquiera*: indeterminate person, which comes to mean here “anything”)’

However, this use of *cualquiera* is not restricted to this variety. According to a note by Di Tullio (2015) in the framework of DILE (*Diccionario Latinoamericano de la Lengua Española*), under verbs such as *decir* or *mandar* ‘to say’, *cualquiera* means ‘nonsense/incorrect/false’:

- (36) A: Me dijiste que venías temprano. B: *Cualquiera*.
me told that would.come early CUALQUIERA
A: ‘You said that you would come early.’ B: ‘Nonsense’
(Di Tullio 2015; DILE, s.v.)
- (37) mandaste *cualquiera*
said CUALQUIERA
‘You said nonsense’
(Di Tullio 2015; DILE, s.v.)

There is a similar pejorative use of the free choice indefinite pronoun *n’importe quoi* (lit. ‘it doesn’t matter what’) under verbs of saying and copular verbs in Modern French, where it has been nominalised (see Paillard 1997, Pescarini 2009, Section 3 for details):

2.1 Informal description of the properties of modern *cualquiera*

- (38) *dire/c'est (du grand) n'importe quoi.*
say/it is (of-the big) N'IMPORTE QUOI
'to say/it's (total) bullshit.'
(@ 30 / @ 31)

In this use, *cualquiera* can be modified by a number of degree modifiers or affixes. According to Rizzo Salierno (2013), all of them refer to extreme or high degrees (see Rizzo Salierno 2013: 27).

- (39) *re-*: prefix⁸ that indicates an extreme degree of a gradable predicate
- muy, mal*
 - demasiado, absolutamente, totalmente* 'too, absolutely, totally'
 - ito, -azo*: affective suffixes
 - ísimo*: suffix indicating extreme degree, mostly used with feminine nouns
- (40) *Es demasiado cualquiera, casi me hace estrellar mi cabeza contra*
is too CUALQUIERA almost me makes slam my head against
el monitor.
the monitor
'It's too *bad/ordinary*, it almost makes me slam my head against the
monitor.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 27; ArgSp)
- (41) *Es una mina, re cualquiera.*
is a girl very CUALQUIERA
'It is a very ordinary girl.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 26; ArgSp)
- (42) *Bueno vieja, pero entonces cambiale el título al thread porque*
well old lady but then change the title to the thread because
si no *es cualquiera mal.*
otherwise is CUALQUIERA bad
'Well, buddy, but then change the title of the thread, otherwise it's really
bad.'⁹
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 27; ArgSp)

⁸I disagree with the analysis of *re* as a prefix as it is always written as a separate word in social media and can be reinforced by repetition *re re cualquiera* 'very very bad'.

⁹If *mal* has a status of a degree modifier modifying *cualquiera* then the syntactic order is inverse in *cualquiera mal/cualunque mal* as compared to *re cualquiera*, where the degree modifier is placed before *cualquiera* rather than after it. In the future, I will test the hypothesis as to whether *cualquiera* can be analysed as a degree modifier itself in *cualquiera mal*.

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- (43) Si es un ranking de todos los tiempos este que pusiste es
if is a ranking of all the times this that put.2SG is
cualquier-ita!!!
CUALQUIERA-ITA
'If this is a ranking of every time, this one you posted is *bad!!!*'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 27; ArgSp)
- (44) *Cualquier-aza* ese video.
CUALQUIERA.AFFECTIVE that video
'That video is extremely *bad*.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 27; ArgSp)
- (45) Es *cualquier-ísima* tu planteo.
is CUALQUIERA.ELATIVE your proposal
'Your proposal is extremely *bad*.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 27; ArgSp)
- (46) Es *absolutamente cualquiera*.
is absolutely CUALQUIERA
'It is absolutely *bad*.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 28; ArgSp)
- (47) Es *totalmente cualquiera* eso de haber puesto a Roger con la voz
is totally CUALQUIERA that of having put to Roger with the voice
de Syd.
of Syd
'Having put Roger with Syd's voice is totally *bad*.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 28; ArgSp)
- (48) Eso de la tanga es *completamente cualquiera*.
that of the thong is completely CUALQUIERA
'That thong thing is completely *bad*.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 28; ArgSp)

Cualquiera can also have an attributive use in a postnominal position as in European Spanish (see Section 2.1.4):

- (49) Esto es *un video cualquiera*.
this is a video CUALQUIERA
'This is an ordinary video.'
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 26; ArgSp)

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- (50) Acá les dejo *las fotos cualquiera* de hoy.
 here you leave the photos CUALQUIERA of today
 ‘Here you have *ordinary* photos of today.’
 (Rizzo Salierno 2013: 26; ArgSp)

According to Rizzo Salierno (2013), *cualquiera* can also be used under transitive verbs and be interpreted in a pejorative or derogatory way in Argentinian Spanish. However, she does not say anything about its different syntactic function in this context:

- (51) *Me contestó cualquiera o ni* me respondía.
 me answer.PST.3SG CUALQUIERA or not.even me respond.3SG.PST
 ‘(S)he either answered me *bullshit* or not even answered at all.’
 (Rizzo Salierno 2013: 26; ArgSp)
- (52) Se ve.3SG que *me dijo cualquiera* la mina.
 it looks that me told CUALQUIERA the girl
 ‘Apparently she told me *bullshit*, that girl.’
 (Rizzo Salierno 2013: 26; ArgSp)

To sum up, *cualquiera* can be used as an adjective with degree affixes and has an evaluative meaning of ‘ordinary/bad’ in Argentinian Spanish (Rizzo Salierno 2013). It can also be used under transitive verbs such as *decir/mandar cualquiera* or *estar en cualquiera* as a direct object comparable to *cualquier cosa* with a derogatory meaning of ‘bullshit’ (Conde 2011a, Di Tullio 2003, Company-Company 2009a).

Table 2.2: *Cualquiera* with evaluative meanings in Argentinian Spanish

	Copular predicate	Transitive verbs
<i>es cualquiera</i>	<i>decir cualquiera</i>	
is CUALQUIERA	to say CUALQUIERA	
Evaluative meaning	+ (EVAL1 ‘ordinary, bad’)	+ (EVAL2 ‘bullshit’)
Degree modification	+	?

Previous studies on special uses of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish reviewed in this section do not provide a synchronic or diachronic corpus analysis with

a quantitative description of various uses and meanings of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, nor do they discuss the reasons for the synchronic and diachronic variation of *cualquiera* (Table 2.2). The present study aims at filling this gap in the quantitative corpus description of the synchronic and diachronic variation of *cualquiera* in European and Argentinian Spanish by focusing on its use in the synchronic and the historical corpus (see 3 for European Spanish and 4 for Argentinian Spanish). In Chapter 3 and Chapter 4, I will present new corpus data with a quantitative description, offer a semantic analysis of *cualquiera* in their evaluative uses and discuss reasons for the syntactic and semantic variation of *cualquiera* in European and Argentinian Spanish.

2.1.6 Summary

The table (Table 2.3) sums up the current state of research with respect to different syntactic functions of *cualquiera* and their interpretations. The main observation is that the indicative mood is correlated with different interpretations – EVAL, RC, and ignorance – in both European and Argentinian Spanish. The difference between the two varieties is that in Argentinian Spanish, *cualquiera* with evaluative interpretation is used less restrictively across different syntactic categories, whereas in European Spanish it is only UN (N) *cualquiera* that allows the evaluative reading (Table 2.2).

In the following section, I will look more closely at the distribution of different interpretations of *cualquiera* as defined in the literature.

2.2 Formal semantic analysis of *cualquiera*

In this section, I will give a brief overview of semantic analysis of *cualquiera* from the literature, which is necessary to understand the formal semantic analysis in this section. I will first introduce the notion of total variation and present formal analyses of *cualquiera*.

2.2.1 Total variation of *cualquiera* and partial variation of *algún*

Algún is an epistemic indefinite that signals the speaker's ignorance (IGN) with respect to the identity of the individual or object denoted by the indefinite. This makes it incompatible with continuations that specify the referent of the *algún* phrase, as illustrated in (53) (see A&M 2010 for *algún* phrases, Kratzer & Shimoyama 2002 for German *irgendein*, Aloni & Port 2013 for Italian *un qualche*,

Table 2.3: Syntactic and semantic functions of *cualquiera* in Modern European and Argentinian Spanish

	Syntactic context		Semantic interpretation			
	Degree modifica- tion	Indicative mood in episodic or predica- tive context	Evaluative interpreta- tion (EVAL)	Free choice (FC)	Random choice (RC)	Ignorance interpreta- tion
Pronoun	no	no (EurSp) yes (ArgSp)	no (EurSp) yes (ArgSp)	yes	no	no
<i>cualquier</i> N	no	no (EurSp) yes (ArgSp)	no (EurSp) yes (ArgSp)	yes	no	no
<i>un/una</i> (N) <i>cualquiera</i>	no (EurSp) yes (ArgSp)	yes	yes	yes (with partitives and under modals)	yes (episodic tense, volitional verbs)	yes (episodic tense)

Chierchia 2006 for *un* NP *qualunque*, Jayez & Tovenar 2005, and others for French *quelque* and *un* NP *quelconque*, Fălăuș 2014 for Romanian *un* NP *oarecare*):

- (53) Maria se casó con algún medico. # En concreto con el Dr.
Maria REFL married with some doctor in particular with the Dr.
Smith.
Smith
‘Maria married some doctor. Concretely, Dr. Smith.’ (Alonso-Ovalle &
Menéndez-Benito 2013: 36)

The impossibility of such types of continuation is captured by the “anti-singleton condition”, which expresses the idea captured by Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011) and Giannakidou & Quer (2013) that *algún* can only be used if there is more than one alternative known to the speaker (e.g. *algún estudiante* ‘some or other student’). This condition expresses *epistemic indeterminacy*

or *anti-specificity* (see also Giannakidou & Quer 2013, Etxeberria & Giannakidou 2014). Specificity is given when “a speaker uses an indefinite noun phrase and intends to refer to a particular referent” (von Heusinger 2011: 10). Giannakidou & Quer (2013) suggest that the phenomenon of referential vagueness is the absence of specificity, i.e., the absence of referential anchoring and the absence of referential intent. To sum up, *algún* is anti-specific and expresses referential vagueness. It signals the lack of referential intent that characterises specificity (von Heusinger 2002, 2007, 2011). Referential vagueness consists in the minimal variation in possible values, and in uncertainty about which one is the actual value.

One crucial dimension along which epistemic indefinites vary concerns the extent of variation (‘freedom of choice’) imposed on the domain of quantification, which can be *total* or *partial* (see Fălăuș 2014, among others, and Section 2.2.3). It has been argued that certain epistemic indefinites (e.g. *irgendein*, *un NP qualunque*, *un NP oarecare*) can sustain TOTAL variation, requiring that *all* relevant alternatives in the domain of quantification qualify as *equally* possible options. For example, the sentence in (54), with the Romanian epistemic indefinite *un NP oarecare*, states that Maria has the obligation to work with a colleague and that this could be any colleague:

- (54) Maria *trebuie* să lucreze cu *un* coleg *oarecare*.
 Maria must SBJV work with a colleague OARECARE
 ‘Maria must work with a colleague/any colleague.’
 (Fălăuș 2014: 32)

In contrast to this total freedom of choice, there are epistemic indefinites that trigger a weaker inference — partial variation — *some, but not necessarily all* alternatives in the relevant domain are epistemic possibilities. As such, they are compatible with the exclusion of some of the possible options. The difference can be most readily observed in the scenario in (55), as was shown first by Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2010) and restated by Fălăuș (2014):

- (55) Maria, Juan, and Pedro are playing hide-and-seek in their country house.
 Juan is hiding. Pedro believes that Juan is inside the house.
- a. Juan *tiene* que estar en *alguna* habitación de la casa.
 Juan has to be in some room of the house
 - b. Juan *trebuie* să fie în *vreo* cameră din casă.
 Juan must SBJV be in some room of the house
 ‘Juan must be in a room of the house.’ (Fălăuș 2014: 32)

The context makes it clear that not all rooms of the house are possible choices, that is, the variation associated with the indefinite is limited to a subset of elements in the relevant domain. While the use of *algún* is perfectly acceptable in this scenario, a total variation item like *un NP oarecare/qualunque/cualquiera* would be deviant (see Fălăuş 2014).

In contrast with *cualquiera*, *algún* requires non-exhaustive variation. The oddness in (56) illustrates a presupposition conflict. The two anti-specific indefinites *algún* and *cualquiera* require opposite things: the former requires non-exhaustive variation,¹⁰ while the latter (the free choice indefinite) requires exhaustive variation (but see Section 2.3 for grammatical instances of *algún N cualquiera* with evaluative interpretation of *cualquiera*):

- (56) #Juan ha hablado con algún estudiante cualquiera.
 Juan has talked with some student CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan has spoken with some student.’
 (Ettxeberria & Giannakidou 2014: 19)

N cualquiera is anti-specific and referentially vague because it is not used referentially and the speaker does not refer to a specific individual (see Giannakidou & Quer 2013, among others). Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2010) assumes that *cualquiera* occurs with nouns that do not denote singletons. The anti-singleton restriction follows from the FCI reading of *cualquiera*, which compares at least two alternatives and conveys that all alternatives count as possible or that the agent does not discriminate between at least two alternatives for his choice. This explanation can explain why *cualquiera* as an FCI does not occur with definite nouns that denote unique individuals like proper nouns do.

Summary of *cualquiera/algún*: both are anti-specific indefinites and both express referential vagueness. They signal the lack of referential intent that characterises specificity. The indefinite *cualquiera* expresses total variation, meaning that all options are evaluated epistemically, whereas in case of *algún* only a subset of possibilities are considered as candidates.

2.2.2 Formal analysis of free choice

This subsection introduces the formal analysis of Free Choice Indefinites within the Alternative Semantic Framework.

¹⁰Examples expressing non-exhaustive variation in Spanish are expressions like *etcétera* ‘etc.’, *cosas así* ‘this kind of stuff’, *entre otras cosas* ‘among other things’.

2.2.2.1 Preliminaries: An introduction to alternative semantics

In order to show how *cualquiera* can be analysed in alternative semantics, I will give a short introduction to the latter based on Fălăuș (2014).

On this approach, the semantics of FCIs involves considering alternative semantic values. The theory was developed in a framework of bidimensional semantics (cf. Rooth 1985), where alternatives are introduced and computed separately from regular semantic values. The starting point is the interpretation of an exchange such as the following:

- (57) a. A: Who came to the party?
b. B: Paul and Sue.

This utterance conveys that Paul and Sue are the only individuals in the context for which a certain property holds (here: having come to the party), a meaning that goes beyond what is explicitly uttered. There are two components leading to this enriched, non-literal interpretation: (57a) a set of alternatives (e.g. contextually relevant individuals) and (57b) the exclusion of the (non-entailed) alternatives. This enriched or strengthened meaning, the one obtained via the consideration and exclusion of alternatives, is often triggered by focus.

Free choice items also activate alternatives. A phrase such as *any student* activates domain alternatives, that is, subsets of (contextually relevant) students (e.g. {Mario}, {Marco}, etc.). Free choice items are indefinites (i.e. existentially quantified elements) that systematically activate sets of alternatives that expand (compositionally) until they find a (quantificational) operator that selects them (e.g. universal quantifier, existential quantifier, negation, question operator) as shown in (58). Alternatives can be of different types (e.g. individual, propositional) and as a consequence are accessible to both sentential and non-sentential (generalised) quantificational operators, which eventually determine the interpretation of the indefinite. Individual alternatives can expand and give rise to alternatives of a higher type, e.g. propositional alternatives, which then get caught by a sentential operator $\exists p$ or $\forall p$, such as the ones in (58) (see Kratzer & Shimoyama 2002, Chierchia 2006, Aloni 2007, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, among others):

- (58) Indefinites in alternative semantics after Kratzer & Shimoyama (2002: 8)
For $\llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^{w,g} \subseteq D_{\langle s,t \rangle}$:
- a. $\llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^{w,g} = \{\lambda w'. \exists p[p \in \llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^{w,g} \wedge p(w') = 1]\}$
 - b. $\llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^{w,g} = \{\lambda w'. \forall p[p \in \llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^{w,g} \rightarrow p(w') = 1]\}$

The contribution of the indefinite remains constant, namely, to provide a set of alternatives, its different readings being the result of associating with different operators.

When a set of propositional alternatives combines with the existential operator as defined in (58), it yields the proposition that is true in case at least one alternative in the relevant set is true. In contrast, the universal quantifier in (58) yields the proposition that is true in case every alternative in the relevant set is true.

Now, importantly, as will be shown below in Section 2.2.2.2, *cualquiera* provides alternatives that always combine with the universal operator $\forall p$ in modal contexts (i.e. under modal verbs, conditionals, subtriggering, and other modalised constructions). Let us see how this approach works for *cualquier libro* ‘some book/any book’ in (59). The domain of alternatives of *cualquier libro* consists of all individual books of a contextually relevant set, for instance {*Don Quijote*, *El camino*, ...}. These alternatives grow to become propositions {You can buy *Don Quijote*, You can buy *El camino*, ...}:

- (59) Puedes tomar *cualquier* libro.
 can take CUALQUIER book
 ‘You can take any book.’
 (@ 32)

In order to derive the free choice meaning in (59) that every alternative (i.e. every book) is a possible option and not just some of them, we compute the enriched meaning of the sentence in (60), by interpreting the exhaustivity expressed by *cualquier*, i.e. we negate all alternatives that do not match the assertion, which yields the following enriched meaning (summarised under the tenet that all alternatives must be taken into account). The enriched meaning does not contain the statement according to which only one alternative can be taken into account (represented by $\perp$ which basically means not-computable):

- (60) Total exhaustivity of alternatives ($a \vee b \vee c$) =
 You can take ($a \vee b \vee c$) $\wedge$
 $\neg$ You can take ($a \wedge b$) $\wedge$
 $\neg$ You can take ($a \wedge c$) $\wedge$
 $\neg$ You can take ($b \wedge c$) $\wedge$
 $\neg$ You can take ($a \vee b$) $\wedge$
 $\neg$ You can take ($b \vee c$) $\wedge$
 $\neg$ You can take ($a \vee c$) $\wedge$
 $\neg$ You can take $a \wedge \neg$ You can take $b \wedge \neg$ You can take $c = \perp$

To sum up, I have discussed so far that *cualquiera* triggers alternatives and total exhaustification over the alternatives in modal contexts (see Section 2.2). In the following section, I will show one possible formalisation of FCIs in Alternative Semantics.

2.2.2.2 Aloni's (2007) formalisation of FCIs

According to Aloni (2007), Aloni & Port (2013), and Aloni (2021), FCIs trigger the application of the total exhaustification over alternatives as demonstrated in (60) and represented formally by an exhaustivity operator EXH (see also Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010). This operator has a similar function as the focus adverb *only* which associates with alternatives and expresses that only a certain alternative is true. The SHIFT¹¹ function expresses that the exhaustification of domain alternatives shifts to the exhaustification of propositional alternatives, that is, for (61) it is possible that only Peter falls or it is possible that only Mary falls. The total exhaustification expresses that there is no alternative proposition that is left out by the exhaustification:

- (61) Anyone can fall.
- a. $[\forall](\Diamond(\text{SHIFT}_{\langle s,t \rangle}(\text{EXH}[\text{anyone, fall}])))$ ¹²
 - b. $\Diamond$ only Peter fall $\Diamond$ only Mary fall $\Diamond$ only Bob fall ...
(Aloni et al. 2011)

She accounts for the distribution of FCIs under modals such as in (62) and negation as in (63), as well as in contexts that also recover universal quantification of exhaustified propositional alternatives without always expressing an overt modal verb such as subtriggering in (64) and degree comparatives as in (65).

- (62) Canonical FCI
- a. Sentence: You can bring any book.
 - b. Logical form: $[\forall x](\text{book}(x) \rightarrow \Diamond \text{SHIFT}_{\langle s,t \rangle}(\text{EXH}[\text{any book, } \lambda x. \text{you bring me } x]))$
 - c. Predicted meaning: For each book it is possible that you bring me only that book.

¹¹Shift means here type shifting, i.e. conversion of one type into another type, e.g. from a type of individuals into a type of propositions.

¹²the forall-sign in brackets is a typographic convention often used in semantic literature to flag interpretive or pragmatic layers distinct from syntactic structure.

- (63) Embedding of the FC effect
- Sentence: You cannot bring any book.
 - Logical form: $[\neg][\forall](\Diamond\text{SHIFT}_{\langle s,t \rangle}(\text{EXH}[\text{any book}, \lambda x. \text{you bring me } x]))$
 - Predicted meaning: You cannot freely choose which book you bring me. It is not the case that for each book you can bring me that book.
- (64) Licensing by subtrigging (see Aloni 2007)
- Sentence: Anyone who tried to jump fell.
 - Logical form: $[\forall](\downarrow\text{SHIFT}_e(\text{EXH}[\text{anyone, who tried to jump}]) \text{ fell})$
 - Predicted meaning: All persons who tried to jump fell.
- (65) FCIs in comparatives (see Aloni 2021)
- Sentence: John is taller than any girl.
 - Logical form: $[\forall](\text{SHIFT}_e(\text{EXH}[d, \lambda d. \text{tall}(j,d)]) > \text{SHIFT}_e(\text{EXH}[d, \lambda d. \text{tall}(\text{any girl}, d)])$
 - Predicted meaning: For all girls x , John is taller than x . (Aloni et al. 2011)

Aloni (2007, 2021) and Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. (2010) also account for the ungrammaticality of FCIs such as *any* in episodic contexts in (66) that refer to some factual events by showing that the exhaustivity operator cannot apply there. This is represented as $\perp$ in (66).

- (66) Ruling out FCIs in episodic contexts
- Sentence: # Anyone fell.
 - Logical form: $[\forall](\text{SHIFT}_{\langle s,t \rangle}(\text{EXH}[\text{anyone, fell}]))$
 - Predicted meaning: $\perp$ (Aloni 2021)

Aloni argues that the sentence in (66) would give the following incorrect interpretation: for each person only that person fell. A past event described by the perfective aspect can either express that everyone fell or that a certain person/-group of people fell. A modal verb as in *Anyone can fall* rescues the interpretation, as it shifts the exhaustivity to different worlds (i.e. it becomes interpretable as *For every person it is possible that this person fell*) and not only the actual world (see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010, Aloni 2021, among others). This is how

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these authors account for the relation between modality and free choice indefinites.

Although Aloni makes a correct prediction for FCIs such as English *any* and the determiner/pronoun *cualquiera* in European Spanish, which need a modalised context to be licensed and are not permitted in episodic contexts (see Section 2.1), her analysis does not account for the distribution of (postnominal) *cualquiera* in episodic contexts and with copular verbs in present or past tense in European and Argentinian Spanish (see Section 2.1 and Section 2.2.1). The question is how the distribution of *cualquiera* should be accounted for in a system where *cualquiera* triggers alternatives and total exhaustivity over these alternatives. I will deal with the current state research on postnominal *cualquiera* in episodic contexts in Section 2.3.

2.2.2.3 Summary

It has been shown that, according to the current state of research, FCIs such as *any* or *cualquiera* on their free choice meaning have a universal interpretation if embedded under a possibility modal and other modalised constructions such as subtriggering that recover a possibility modal. According to Aloni (2007), FCIs trigger total exhaustification over alternatives, captured by an exhaustivity operator EXH. This operator associates with a universal quantifier that operates on propositions. In this way Aloni can account for the universal inference of FCIs, which is a conventional implicature as indicated by the impossibility of cancelling under negation.

2.2.3 Semantic analysis of *cualquiera* in episodic contexts

2.2.3.1 Informal description

We saw in Section 2.2.1 that *cualquiera* is supposed to be excluded from episodic contexts with a free choice interpretation. However, it can express agent-related modality, such as the random choice interpretation. According to Choi & Romero (2008), Choi & Romero (2008), and Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011, 2018), postnominal *cualquiera* used in episodic contexts under volitional verbs has a RC interpretation:

- (67) Juan necesitaba un pisapapeles, de modo que cogió un libro
Juan needed a paperweight of way that he took a book
cualquiera de la estantería y lo puso encima de la pila.
CUALQUIERA from the shelf and it he put on top of the pile
'John needed a paperweight, so he took a random book from the shelf'

and put it on top of the pile.’
(Choi & Romero 2008: 97)

Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011, 2018) assume that postnominal *cualquiera* is ambiguous between RC and EVAL (but see Choi & Romero 2008, who do not mention the ambiguity):

- (68) Juan compró un libro *cualquiera*.
Juan bought a book CUALQUIERA
‘Juan bought a book.’
- a. John bought a book, and he chose it indiscriminately. (Random Choice)
 - b. John bought a book, and the book is not special or remarkable (according to the speaker). (Unremarkable reading, EVAL)
(Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 2)

In order to distinguish EVAL from RC, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011, 2018) have created different contexts:

- (69) Scenario. Juan went to the bookstore. He wanted to buy *The Unbearable Lightness of Being*, and did so. I don’t think this book is special in any way.
- (70) Scenario. Juan went to the bookstore, and bought a book at random. The book turned out to be *The Unbearable Lightness of Being*. I think this book is remarkable.

In the scenario in [(69)], I can truthfully utter [(68)] on its unremarkable interpretation (since I consider the book that Juan bought unremarkable) but not on its random choice interpretation (as Juan didn’t make an indiscriminate choice). In contrast, my utterance of [(69)] in the scenario in [(70)] would be false on the unremarkable interpretation but true on the random choice interpretation. (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 2f.)

According to Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2018), on the RC interpretation, the noun modified by *cualquiera* must represent an object that the agent of the sentence must have chosen indiscriminately. They assume that, in this use, *cualquiera* appears in object position of volitional verbs. Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011) assume that the RCI is restricted (e.g. not possible with unaccusative verbs), whereas EVAL is always possible:

While the unremarkable interpretation is always possible, the random choice interpretation has a restricted distribution. First of all, for this interpretation to obtain, the sentence has to describe a volitional event (Choi & Romero 2008) and *uno cualquiera* should not be in the subject position of agentive verbs. If that condition is not met, *uno cualquiera*¹³ only has the unremarkable interpretation. Copular sentences are a clear case. The sentences in (a) and (b) convey that the subject is unremarkable within the class of individuals denoted by the noun phrase: (a) says that Juan is a regular clerk and (b) that Juan is a student just like the rest.

- (71) a. Juan es un oficinista *cualquiera*.
 Juan is a clerk CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan is an unremarkable clerk.’
 b. Juan es un estudiante *cualquiera*.
 Juan is a student CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan is an unremarkable student.’
 (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 3)

The following examples only have the ‘unremarkable’ reading (=EVAL) and not RC, because they do not contain volitional verbs:

- (72) a. Ayer Juan tropezó con un objeto *cualquiera*.
 yesterday Juan stumbled with an object CUALQUIERA
 ‘Yesterday, Juan stumbled on an unremarkable object.’
 (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 3)
 b. La levadura destruyó un molde *cualquiera*.
 the yeast destroyed a baking pan CUALQUIERA
 ‘The yeast destroyed an unremarkable baking pan.’
 (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 3)

Nouns modified by postnominal *cualquiera* that represent subjects of volitional verbs such as *hablar* ‘speak’ or objects of non-volitional verbs cannot have RC as the authors assume, but only EVAL:

- (73) Habló un estudiante *cualquiera*.
 spoke a student CUALQUIERA
 ‘An unremarkable student spoke.’ (# ‘a random student spoke’)
 (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 4)

¹³A&M refer to UN N *cualquiera* as *uno cualquiera*.

Furthermore, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011) assume that *cualquiera* can also have a free choice interpretation under some modals, which they call harmonic interpretation (HI):

When *uno cualquiera* is embedded under some modals, another possibility arises: *uno cualquiera* introduces a distribution effect with respect to the worlds that the modal ranges over. For instance, *Coge una carta cualquiera!* ('take any card!') can be interpreted as conveying that any card is a permitted option.

(Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 1)

Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011) assume that *cualquiera* is lexically ambiguous between RCI/HI on the one hand and EVAL on the other:

As a working hypothesis, we will assume that *uno cualquiera* is ambiguous between one form that can give rise to the random choice and harmonic interpretations (the form that we will focus on), and another that conveys the unremarkable interpretation. To determine whether this hypothesis is tenable it would be necessary to provide a detailed analysis of the unremarkable interpretation, a non-trivial task that we will not be able to undertake here.

(Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 8)

To sum up, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011, 2018) show that RCI is restricted to objects of volitional verbs and it does not arise under non-volitional verbs. The 'unremarkable' reading is completely unrestricted; it can appear everywhere:

Table 2.4: The distribution of RCI and EVAL of UN N *cualquiera* (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018)

Interpretation	Restrictions	
	Available	Unavailable
Random choice	object of volitional verbs	subject of volitional verbs non-volitional verbs
Unremarkable	unrestricted	unrestricted

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Under their approach, the restriction to volitional verbs follows from the modal component of UN N *cualquiera* (cf. Section 2.1.4). The modal component of UN N *cualquiera* expresses that every alternative of UN N *cualquiera* conforms to the agent's decision to choose this alternative. Thus, RCI can only apply to volitional verbs, as they express the agent's decisions to do something (e.g. picking some book).

The random reading disappears whenever there is nothing for the agent to choose, as for example with unaccusative verbs, because unaccusative verbs do not match with the decision condition according to which the agent does something in accordance to his/her decision (see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018).

Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2018) assume lexical ambiguity between RCI/HI and EVAL and that EVAL is unrestricted. This hypothesis needs to be tested (see Chapter 3).

Chierchia (2006: 574) observes yet another interpretation of Free Choice indefinites in episodic contexts. He notes that the existential FCI UN N *qualsiasi* in Italian can be used in episodic contexts under a covert modal operator that expresses speaker's modality, namely speaker's ignorance (see also Section 2.2.1 for the ignorance reading expressed by Spanish *algún*):

- (74) Gianni è uscito di corsa e non sapendo che fare, ha bussato ad
Gianni is exited in hurry and NEG knowing what to.do has knocked at
una porta *qualsiasi*.
a door *QUALSIASI*
'Gianni ran out and not knowing what to do, knocked on any door.'
Speaker's ignorance: it is possible that for every door x Gianni knocked
at the door x. (Chierchia 2006: 574)

Note that free choice relatives in English can also express an ignorance reading (IGN) in episodic context (see Condoravdi 2015: 216), that is, in (75) the speaker is ignorant about the identity of the book John bought:

- (75) Whatever book John bought was very expensive.

According to Chierchia the sentence in (74) could be interpreted as something like "it follows from what the speaker knows that Gianni knocked at a door." The FCI implicature would then be "it is consistent with what the speaker knows that any door might have been the one knocked at" (Chierchia 2006: 574). Chierchia thus assumes that the speaker considers it a possibility that for every door x,

Gianni knocked at the door x. It is important to mention that the modality is associated with the speaker and not with the agent *Gianni*, according to Chierchia (2006) (see Section 2.3 for agent’s modality).

Recall from the Section 2.1 that native speakers agree on the possibility of an ignorance interpretation of UN N *cualquiera* in episodic contexts (see 24, repeated here in 76):

- (76) La carta de ajuste, en la pantalla, se complementaba con
the test.card of adjustment on the screen REFL complemented with
la música ramplona de una zarzuela *cualquiera*.
the music vulgar of a zarzuela CUALQUIERA
a. ‘The testcard, in the screen, was complemented with the vulgar
sound of some ordinary zarzuela.’ (EVAL)
b. ‘...with the vulgar sound of some zarzuela that I don’t know.’ (IGN)
(@ 14e)

The ignorance interpretation is not mentioned in the literature on Spanish *cualquiera* (see Kellert & Francia 2024, on the ignorance interpretation on a similar item in Argentinian Spanish: *cualunque*). In this book, I do not pursue the study on the ignorance reading in episodic contexts of *cualquiera* either.

2.2.3.2 Formal analysis of the Random Choice interpretation

The random choice interpretation, RCI, has been described very well in the literature. I will illustrate two prominent proposals, which both assume that postnominal *cualquiera* has a RCI whenever *cualquiera* occurs under volitional verbs (see Choi & Romero 2008, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018). As I will show, neither approach accounts for the evaluative function of postnominal *cualquiera*.

Choi & Romero (2008) assume that *cualquiera* has a similar denotation as von Fintel’s (2000) denotation of *wh-ever* in English. Von Fintel (2000) adopts Dayal’s (1998) insight that *-ever* Free Relatives (FRs) introduce a layer of quantification over possible worlds and proposes that *-ever* in *-ever* FRs induces a presupposition of variation on either counterfactual worlds or epistemic worlds. Von Fintel (2000) points out that a subtype of *-ever* FRs expresses “indifference” on somebody’s part. Compare (77a) and (77b). Both of them assert the same proposition paraphrasable using a definite description, namely, the proposition that the person who was at the top of the ballot won the election yesterday (see Choi & Romero 2008: 88).

- (77) a. In yesterday’s election, who was at the top of the ballot won.
b. In yesterday’s election, whoever was at the top of the ballot won.

Unlike (77a), (77b) conveys an extra meaning triggered by *-ever*, such that the identity of who was at the top of the ballot did not matter to winning yesterday's election. Put differently, the identity of the denotation of *-ever* FRs does not matter for the general nature or outcome of the election.

In von Fintel (2000), this essential link follows from the presupposition of variation given in (78), which is identified as the nature of *-ever*'s contribution. The presupposition of variation tells us that if the individual denoted by an *-ever* FR had been different, the truth value of the assertion in the actual world would still be valid in all the counterfactual worlds.

- (78) Presupposition of variation for (77b): If the person who was at the top of the ballot had been different, the same thing would have happened: that (new) person would have won.

That is, the presupposition triggered by *whoever was on the top of the ballot won* conveys that if the person who won the election had been different in all the counterfactual worlds, the truth of the proposition *the person at the top of the ballot won* would also hold in the counterfactual worlds. From this presupposition of variation, it is inferred that regardless of who was at the top of the ballot, *being at the top of the ballot* and *winning yesterday's election* are in an essential relation.

In von Fintel (2000), a sentence containing an *-ever* FR is formalised as in (79). In the formulae, *F* indicates the modal base for *-ever* FRs, which is a set of worlds on which the presupposition of variation operates. *P* refers to the denotation of the NP property contained in the *-ever* FR, and *Q* refers to the property expressed by the rest of the sentence. Sentences containing an *-ever* FR assert that the thing that has *P* is *Q* in the actual world, as shown in (79). Note that, according to von Fintel (2000), *-ever* FRs denote definite descriptions on the assertion level. This is represented by the iota-operator ι . The presupposition triggered by *-ever* says that in every world *w'* (of the corresponding modal base) that are different from the actual world only with respect to the referent of the *-ever* FR, the asserted proposition has in *w'* whatever truth value it has in the actual world *w₀* (see Choi & Romero 2008: 88):

- (79) Whatever $(w_0)(F)(P)(Q)$ according to von Fintel (2000)
- a. **Asserts:** $Q(w_0)(\iota x.P(w_0)(x))$
 - b. **Presupposes:** $\forall w' \in \min_{w_0} [F \cap \lambda w''. \iota x.P(w'')(x) \neq \iota x.P(w_0)(x)]: Q(w')(\iota x.P(w')(x)) = Q(w_0)(\iota x.P(w_0)(x))$

Choi & Romero apply the formalisation in (79) to the sentence in (80). The modal base *F* is counterfactual, and thus a presupposition of counterfactual variation is conveyed, as in (80a-ii).

- (80) a. In yesterday's election, whoever was at the top of the ballot won.
- i. **Assertion** : $\lambda w_0. \text{win}(\iota y. \text{top-of-ballot}(y, w_0), w_0)$
 - ii. **Presupposition** : $\lambda w_0 \forall w' \in \min_{w_0} [F \cap \lambda w''. [\iota y. \text{top-of-ballot}(y, w'') \neq \iota y. \text{top-of-ballot}(y, w_0)]: \text{win}(\iota y. \text{top-of-ballot}(y, w'), w') = \text{win}(\iota y. \text{top-of-ballot}(y, w_0), w_0)]$
- b. In prose:
- i. **Assertion**: In w_0 , the person who was at the top of the ballot in w_0 won.
 - ii. **Presupposition**: In each world w' , a counterfactual world of w_0 , if someone else had been at the top of the ballot in w' , the person who was at the top of the ballot in w' won in w' iff the person who was at the the top of the ballot in w_0 won in w_0 .

Choi & Romero (2008) apply von Fintel's formalisation of *wh-ever* to the Spanish indefinite *cualquiera* with a minor change: the ordinary meaning of Spanish indefinite *cualquiera* contains an existential quantifier and not an iota operator as in von Fintel's analysis of *wh-ever*. The Spanish example in (81) expresses the assertion that some book was picked and put on a pile and a presupposition of variation according to which there are other maximally similar worlds in which a book has been picked and put on a pile (see Choi & Romero 2008: 91):

- (81) a. Juan cogió un libro *cualquiera* y lo puso encima de la pila.
 Juan took a book CUALQUIERA and it put on.top of the pile
 'Juan took some book and put it on top of the pile.'
- i. **Assertion**: $\lambda w_0. \exists x. \text{book}(x, w_0) \ \& \ \text{pick}(j, x, w_0) \ \& \ \text{put-on-pile}(j, x, w_0)$
 - ii. **Presupposition**:
 $\lambda w_0 \forall w' \in \min_{w_0} [F \cap \lambda w''. \{x: \text{book}(x, w'')\} \neq \{x: \text{book}(x, w_0)\}]:$
 $\exists x. \text{book}(x, w') \ \& \ \text{pick}(j, x, w') \ \& \ \text{put-on-pile}(j, x, w')$
 $\exists x. \text{book}(x, w_0) \ \& \ \text{pick}(j, x, w_0) \ \& \ \text{put-on-pile}(j, x, w_0)$
- b. In prose:
- i. **Assertion**: In the actual world w_0 , there is some book in w_0 that John picked up and put on the pile in w_0 .
 - ii. **Presupposition**: In all counterfactual worlds w' minimally different from w_0 with respect to the identity of the set of books, there is some book in w' that John picked up and put on the pile in w' iff there is some book in w_0 that John picked up and put on the pile in w_0 .

In contrast to Choi & Romero (2008), Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2018) assume that the random choice interpretation introduces a modal domain consisting of worlds compatible with agent's decisions. Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2018) describe RC using a modal component presented in (83b) according to which the relevant cards that Juan did not choose but could have chosen are part of the cards the agent had at the time he took the decision d_e . The modal component states that Juan's decision could be fulfilled by taking any card in the domain. The following components are part of truth conditions (for the formalisation see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018):

- (82) Juan cogió una carta *cualquiera*.
 Juan took a card CUALQUIERA
 'Juan took a random card.'
- (83) a. *Existential Component*: In w , there is an event e of Juan taking a card x .
 b. *Modal Component*: For every (relevant) card y in w , there is a world w' compatible with d_e where there is an event e' of Juan taking y that fulfills $d_{e'}$ (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 32)

I dub this approach *intentional randomness*, as the agent who picked a random card had made the decision to do so.

2.2.3.3 Discussion

I would like to discuss three critical points concerning the previous analyses of *cualquiera*. First, no study so far suggests a detailed analysis of the evaluative interpretation of UN N cualquiera in episodic and predicative contexts or makes a proposal as to how to analyse the relation between the evaluative meaning and RC/FC.

The second critical point concerns the description of the random choice interpretation. I will show in Chapter 4 that *cualquiera* can express unintentional/unvoluntary randomness too, which is the result of an unreflected/unplanned action. Let us consider the following scenario:

- (84) Scenario: Imagine Juan is a lunatic. He sleepwalks and picks up several objects in his sleep, including some cards:
 Juan cogió una carta *cualquiera*.
 Juan took a letter CUALQUIERA
 'Juan took a random card.'

In this scenario, *cualquiera* has a RC interpretation even though the event of taking the actual card was not intentional and even though Juan did not decide to take a card. Moreover, I will show in Chapter 4 on diatopic variation of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, that there are volitional/intentional verbs that have an evaluative interpretation as their only meaning when they select *cualquiera* as a direct object, such as *mandar cualquiera* ‘to say bullshit’ (see also Fr. *dire n’importe quoi* ‘to say bullshit’). The following examples, also from Argentinian Spanish, demonstrates such a case.

- (85) Perdón respondí *cualquiera*.
 sorry answer.1SG CUALQUIERA
 ‘Sorry, I answered *nonsense*.’
 (@ 33, Buenos Aires/neighborhood Congreso, 25 years old; Argentinian Spanish)
- (86) Osea respondí re *cualquiera* lo que me preguntaba, no sé
 well answered very CUALQUIERA what that me asked NEG know
 qué carajo, habré estado muy dormida pero como que contesté
 what hell must.have been very asleep but as if answered
 las preguntas por la mitad...
 the questions by the half
 ‘I answered with complete nonsense to what I was asked, I don’t know, what the hell, I must have been very tired because I answered the questions only partially.’
 (@ 34, female blogger, Buenos Aires, 25 years old; ArgSp)

We thus need to find a better distinction between RCI and the evaluative interpretation that is based on more criteria than just the presence of a volitional/intentional verb. The relation between random choice and evaluative meaning needs to be explained. I address this issue in Chapter 4.

Another critical point of previous approaches to RCI is that they are too restrictive. Both approaches of RC in Section 2.2 suggest that there is a correlation between volitional verbs and RC of postnominal *cualquiera*. However, this is too restrictive. There are examples of UN N *cualquiera* in mathematical contexts under copular verbs or in subject position with free choice interpretation. Note that UN N *cualquiera* should not have RC interpretation in subject or predicative position under either approach in Section 2.2. Let us consider the following examples:

- (87) El punto P de coordenadas (a,b) es un punto *cualquiera*.
the point P of coordinates (a,b) is a point CUALQUIERA
‘The point P of coordinates (a,b) is a random point.’
(@ 35)
- (88) una muestra *cualquiera* nos vale.
a sample CUALQUIERA to.us is.worth
‘Any random sample is good for us.’
(@ 36)

In these examples, random choice is implicit; that is, what is random about the point or the sample is that the point P or the sample is defined in a way such that they were picked randomly or can be picked randomly. Random choice is thus not restricted to the occurrence of volitional verbs expressed in the sentence, but to contexts in which it makes sense to recover a choice. Note that in these examples, the evaluative reading of ‘ordinary, average, common’ does not make sense at all, because there is no point in the coordination system that can be described as unremarkable or common for the speaker in a mathematical context and it does not make sense to talk about an unremarkable sample in statistics. I thus disagree with Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011, 2018), who predict an unremarkable reading of UN N *cualquiera* in affirmative sentences in predicative position such as (87) and in subject position such as (88).

2.3 *Cualquiera* under negation

In this section, I will examine FCIs under negation more closely, as negation will play a role in the corpus data description of UN N *cualquiera* in Chapter 3.

The use of FCIs under negation was first described by Horn (2000). The speaker in (89) says that she wants to distinguish or discriminate among the possible candidates she wants to go to bed with. In other words, the speaker wants to be selective. According to Horn, *not* negates the indiscriminacy. Thus, *not just any* has an anti-indiscriminative interpretation (see Horn 2000, Aloni & Port 2013, among many others):

- (89) I don’t want to go to bed with just anyone anymore. I have to be attracted to them sexually.
(Aloni et al. 2011: 8)

Fălăuș (2013) offers a more general analysis of FCIs under negation. According to Fălăuș, Italian *qualunque* in (90) has the denotation of an existential quantifier like *some* in English (see Fălăuș 2013 for formal representation and Section 2.1.4). Moreover, *qualunque* triggers alternatives {a, b, c,...}, such as alternative books {*Don Quijote*, *War and Peace*, ...}. Postnominal *qualunque* is focused, which triggers a domain restriction on the quantification of ‘some’. The sentence with a focused *un libro qualunque* is interpreted as meaning that Gianni did not read a book in the initially considered domain of quantification (say D), but he read a book in some other domain (say D’), e.g. some exceptional book. The book in the domain D’ is singled out pragmatically, according to Fălăuș (2013).

- (90) Gianni non ha letto un libro *qualunque*.
 Gianni NEG has read a book QUALUNQUE
 ‘Gianni didn’t read just any book.’
 (Italian, Fălăuș 2013: 95)

The negation and focus interact in (90). If *qualunque* were not focused in (90), negation would operate on every domain alternative and *qualunque* would be interpreted as a negative polarity item similar to English *any* under negation. It would get a different interpretation, namely the plain negation of *Gianni did not read any book*. However, such a function of plain negation is expressed by negative words such as *niente/nessun* ‘anything/any’ in Italian:

- (91) Gianni non ha letto niente / nessun libro.(Italian)
 Gianni NEG has read nothing / no book
 ‘Gianni did not read anything/any book.’

Instead, the negation in (90) operates on a restricted set of alternatives; that is, it negates every domain alternative out of a particular set of alternatives.

The same facts have been observed for Spanish *cualquiera*, which is stressed under negation according to Arregui (2006), represented in capital letters as CUALQUIER (see Arregui 2006). If *cualquier* is not stressed, it is ungrammatical, because it would be then interpreted as *some* under negation as in (93).

- (92) No compró *cualquier* libro.
 NEG bought CUALQUIER book
 ‘S/he didn’t buy just any book.’
 (Arregui 2006)

- (93) *No compró *cualquier* libro.
 (intended NPI interpretation: ‘S/he didn’t buy any book.’)
 (Arregui 2006: e.g. 2)

There are other indefinite items that are used in the scope of negation with the NPI interpretation, namely negative indefinites such as *ningún* or *nadie*:

- (94) No vió a nadie.
 NEG saw to anyone
 ‘S/he didn’t see anyone.’
 (@ 37)

What remains unclear under Fălăuş (2013) and Arregui’s (2006) proposal is the role of stress. It is a general rule that all FCIs, regardless of whether they are stressed or not and no matter what syntactic position and function they have, produce the anti-indiscriminative interpretation under negation (see Section 2.2.2). Stress is a side effect at best, not a necessary condition:

- (95) Mi padre no es *cualquiera*.
 my father NEG is CUALQUIERA
 ‘My dad is not just anyone.’¹⁴
 (@ 38)
- (96) Hoy no es *cualquier* día, sino ese en el que todo puede
 today NEG is CUALQUIER day, but that in the which everything can
 cambiar.
 change
 ‘Today is not just any day, but that day when everything can change.’
 (@ 39)

Another critical point is that this proposal does not say anything about the domain restriction of the indefinite *qualunque*. What property do the books in the old domain D and new domain D’ in (90) have? How shall we account for the fact that the new domain D’ must contain a particular or a distinguished book that is not like any other books?

¹⁴If stress played an important role, we would not observe the robust correlation between the anti-discriminative effect of FCIs under negation (see Section 3).

- (97) Gianni non ha letto un libro *qualunque*. # Ha letto un libro come Gianni NEG has read a book QUALUNQUE # has read a book like tanti. (Italian)
many
'Gianni did not read just any book. # He read a book like any other book.'

Another approach to FCIs under negation is offered by Aloni (2007). According to her, FCIs under negation operate on the universal inference triggered by FCIs. The negation has scope over the conjunction of *all* alternatives (it is not the case that you can bring along book A and you can bring along book B). This has the effect that the free choice is denied under negation, yielding the interpretation 'you cannot freely choose to bring any book':

- (98) *No puedes traer cualquier libro.*
You cannot bring along just any book.
 $\neg [\Diamond \text{you bring along book } a_1 \text{ or } \Diamond \text{you bring along book } a_2 \text{ or } \dots], \text{ for any book } a_i \in D$
'You cannot freely choose which book you bring me.'

The result of the negation is the logical inference that you can bring along some book, but not all books. This logical inference is known in the literature as a *quantitative scalar implicature* (see Chierchia 2006, 2013). To sum up, according to Aloni (2007), negation has scope over the universal quantification of free choice *cualquiera* when *cualquiera* is used under negation.

The prediction of this account is that FCIs under negation always produce the negation of free choice independent of stress. This is indeed the case, as pronominal *cualquiera* produces the same effect (see 95 and 96). As FC is denied under negation, free choice should not be interpreted as a conversational implicature, that is, it should only be available in certain pragmatic contexts, because it is not cancellable and does not disappear under negation in Modern Spanish. Since negation cannot cancel the free choice inference, this inference must then be either a presupposition or a conventional implicature (see Potts 2005 for tests of conventional implicature). Neither of them is cancellable. Both hypotheses exist in the literature: free choice is a presupposition (von Stechow 2000, Choi & Romero 2008) or free choice is a conventional implicature (Aloni 2007, 2021). In this work, I ignore the status of the inference and focus instead on whether free choice is the *only* lexical meaning of *cualquiera* and whether other meanings can be derived from this lexical meaning.

Aloni's account does not address about further implications of free choice alternatives under negation, such as the implication that the alternative candidates

in (98) are interpreted as bad candidates on some pragmatic scale (see Horn 2000). One could derive the following inference using free choice under negation in (98). The negation of free choice entails careful or determined selection. The speaker in (98) thus asks to select a book carefully with determination. Careful selection of a book triggers the inference that the book in (98) must have the property of being distinct from other books that are not carefully selected (an interesting book, for instance). It is impossible to carefully select a book that does not stand out among other books. Imagine a scenario where all books are the same. In this scenario, it is impossible to select a book carefully. The hearer could thus interpret *No puedes traer cualquier libro* in (98) as the negation of picking out a book with an undistinguished property and hence the imperative or advice to bring a distinctive book in (98). As I will show, *un libro cualquiera* can denote a kind of a book, which has an undistinguished property of a book or a property of a book that all books share (see Chapter 3). As I will argue, it is this kind interpretation that has been lexicalised on UN N *cualquiera* in predicative contexts or episodic contexts such as *es UN N cualquiera* (see Section 3.3).

2.4 Frequency of different interpretations of *cualquiera*

In order to quantify different interpretations of Sp. *cualquiera*, Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. (2010) have classified corpus data from Corpus del Español (CdE) with respect to the classification system in Table 2.5, which uses Haspelmath's (1997) classification system of indefinites across languages that represent syntactic and semantic properties as demonstrated in Section 2.1

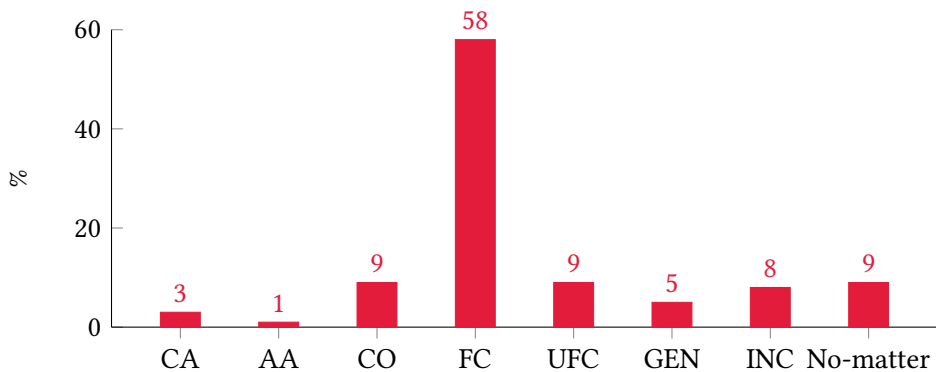


Figure 2.1: Distribution of *cualquiera* in Modern Spanish (i.e. 20th c. Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. 2010: 19)

2.4 Frequency of different interpretations of *cualquiera*

Table 2.5: Classification system of FCIs according to Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. (2010). Arrows mark contexts where any expressions appear with enriched interpretations, such as free choice, universal, or indiscriminative readings, often dependent on modal, generic, or negative operators.

	Abbr.	Label	Example
a.	SK	specific known	<i>Somebody</i> called. Guess who?
b.	SU	specific unknown	I heard <i>something</i> , but I couldn't tell what it was.
c.	IR	irrealis	You must try <i>somewhere</i> else.
d.	Q	question	Did <i>anybody</i> tell you anything about it?
e.	CA	conditional antecedent	If you see <i>anything</i> , tell me immediately.
f.	CO	comparative	In Freiburg, the weather is nicer than <i>anywhere</i> else in Germany.
g.	DN	direct negation	John didn't see <i>anybody</i> .
→ h.	AM	anti-morphic	I don't think that <i>anybody</i> knows the answer.
→ i.	AA	anti-additive	The gravity of such act goes beyond <i>any</i> justification.
→ j.	FC	free choice	<i>Anybody</i> can solve this problem.
→ k.	UFC	universal free choice	John kissed <i>any</i> woman with red hair.
→ l.	GEN	generic	<i>Any</i> dog has four legs.
→ m.	IND	indiscriminative	I do not want to go to bed with <i>just anyone</i> anymore.

As can be seen from the Figure 2.1, the most frequent function of all the possible contexts where *cualquiera* appears in Modern Spanish in the 20th century is clearly the FC(I) function, that is, the distribution of total exhaustification of *cualquiera* over alternatives (Figure 2.1).

The graph also shows that it can have other functions as well (e.g. the indiscriminative [IND] and 'no matter' interpretations). The latter interpretation is not defined in Table 2.5. The meaning distribution misses the evaluative reading of *cualquiera*, which I will investigate also with respect to its frequency in Modern Spanish in Chapter 3.

2.5 Summary of different properties of *cualquiera* in synchrony

The critical review of the state of research in this chapter has shown that *cualquiera* has different syntactic functions (determiner, nominal modifier, pronoun, noun, degree adjective), as well as different semantic functions, as summarised in Table 2.6.

When *cualquiera* acts as a quantificational determiner or pronoun, it is used as a FCI with a restricted distribution (modal contexts, episodic contexts with subtriggering, epistemic modality, or negation) in European Spanish. It has a universal interpretation if embedded under a possibility modal. In non-modal environments, such as episodic contexts and predicative contexts in affirmative sentences, N *cualquiera* has usually an evaluative interpretation of ‘unremarkable’ or a random choice interpretation in European Spanish. In predicative contexts in negative sentences, it expresses negation of free choice (the so-called ‘not just any’ interpretation). *Cualquiera* has the status of a degree adjective in Argentinian Spanish.

2.6 Diachronic research on *cualquiera*

2.6.1 Grammaticalisation of *cualquiera*

It is still a debate in the literature on the diachrony of *QUALQUIER* and other indefinites in Romance as to whether they are an innovation of the Romance languages, in particular whether they have undergone a grammaticalisation path that led from separate words into a single compound (henceforth: the Innovation or Grammaticalisation Hypothesis) or whether they are directly related to Latin indefinites, either inherited or remodelled, i.e. by the substitution of elements in the course of language development or even as a conscious imitation of Latin models (henceforth: the Continuation Hypothesis; see Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, Pato 2012, Mackenzie 2019, Kellert & Arias 2024, and references therein). Under the Innovation Hypothesis, most previous diachronic studies concentrate on the question of how the relative pronoun *qual* and the verb *querer* ‘want, wish’ became grammaticalised into a single complex compound (see Palomo 1934, Lombard 1938–39/1947–48, Meier 1950, Rivero 1988, Espinosa Elorza & Lancis 2006, Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, among others). According to Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. (2010), the grammaticalisation process cannot be retraced in the diachronic corpus CdE because it took place prior to the written documentation of Old Spanish, or, in other words, the

2.6 Diachronic research on *cualquiera*

Table 2.6: Semantic and syntactic properties of *cualquiera* in Modern Spanish according to previous studies

Semantic and syntactic properties	<i>algún</i>	<i>cualquier</i> NP/ <i>cualquiera</i> as pronoun	NP <i>cualquiera</i>	Source
FCI/Hi	no	yes	Yes under modal verbs, subtriggering, comparatives, negation.	Fălăuș (2013, 2014), Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011, 2018) Aloni (2007, 2021)
RCI	no	no	Yes (in object position under agentive verbs) No (in subject position, adverbs and/or under non-agentive verbs).	Choi & Romero (2008), Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011, 2018)
IGN	yes		Yes in Argentinian Spanish (like Italian <i>qualsiasi</i>).	Chierchia (2006), Kellert & Francia (2024)
EVAL 1 ‘ordinary’ ‘bad’/‘out of place’ EVAL 2	no	no in Sp. yes in ArgSp	Yes . for EVAL as ‘ordinary’ Distribution unrestricted in Sp., i.e. <i>cualquiera</i> is lexically ambiguous and can appear under modal contexts as well Yes in ArgSp for EVAL as ‘ordinary’ and ‘bad/out of place’ Distribution restricted in ArgSp under specific verbs such as copular verbs and verbs of saying.	Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2011, 2018), Rivero (2011), Fălăuș (2015), Conde (2011a), Rizzo Salierno (2013)
NPI	yes	no	no	Arregui (2006), Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. (2010)
Modifiable by adverbs like <i>excepto</i> / <i>casi</i>	no	yes	?	Arregui (2006)
Sub-triggering	no	yes	?	Quer (2000), Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. (2010)

compound *qualquier*, -e, -a already existed in the earliest periods in this corpus (see also Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, Rivero 1988). I will review both hypotheses in this section.

2.6.1.1 Continuation hypothesis

According to some linguists, Romance FCIs are based on or and/or influenced by Latin FCIs, including calques from Latin (henceforth: the Continuation Hypothesis). As early as the late 19th century, Meyer-Lübke (1899: 57) assumed that Italian *qualunque* was remodelled on Latin *qualiscumque* ‘(of) any (kind) whatever’, composed of *qualis* ‘which’ + *cumque* ‘ever’, where the second component was substituted with *unquam* ‘any, any-’, hence *qual[is] unqua[m]* (> Old and Modern Italian *qualunque*) (see also Cortelazzo & Zolli 1979: 335; Rohlfs 1966-1968, vol. II: 222–223). Etymological dictionaries and some linguists also assume that the French indefinite *quiconque* has its source in Old French *qui que* ‘whoever’ + *onques* ‘ever’ (< Lat. *unquam*), which was influenced by Latin *quicumque* (see Becker 2014 citing Godefroy 2006 [1880–1902]–1902, vol. 6: 511; Gamillscheg 1969: 737; Greimas 1998: 489; Tobler & Lommatzsch 1925–2002–2018, vol. 8: 91). Menéndez Pidal (1928) assumes that Old Spanish *qual quier*, *qui quier*, *qual-sequiera* represent the Old Spanish equivalents of the Latin indefinites *quilibet*, *qualislibet*. Meier (1950: 387f.) assumes that Old Sp. *qualquiera* and *quienquiera* ‘whoever’ were already fixed expressions in Old Spanish. However, he admits that the attested morphological variation of -quiera (e.g. -quiere, -quisiere) poses a problem for the fixed expression hypothesis. Another problem for the Continuation Hypothesis is that Old Spanish *qualquier*, -e, -a contains a verb different from the verb inside the Latin indefinites, which have -libet (lit. ‘pleases’),¹⁵ with the consequence that, like in the case of It. *qualunque* mentioned above, one has to assume a substitution with forms of (Old) Sp. *querer* ‘to want, to love’. The Spanish verb *querer* stems from Latin *QUAERERE* ‘to search, to investigate, try to find’ (Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009), which has acquired the volitional meaning of ‘want’ (see Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009: 1152, Fn.24). Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo (2009: 1152) assume that the free choice property can be more directly derived from ‘to try to find’ than from ‘to want, to desire’.¹⁶ Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo also note that Old Spanish

¹⁵Latin has also indefinite forms with the verb form *vis* ‘you want’: *QUIVIS*, *QUODVIS* lit. ‘who you want’, ‘what you want’, etc. (see Pato 2012: 304).

¹⁶This view is problematic for different reasons: First, in Catalan or Italian the Latin verb *VOLERE* was chosen (*qualsevol*, *qualsivoglia*), and, second, typologically, there is a whole range of volitional verbs that can feature in indefinites (Haspelmath 1997), but to my knowledge, verbs meaning ‘to search’ are not among them.

qualquier, *-e*, *-a* can be often found as a graphically separated form in the 13th century, a fact that they interpret as being against the Continuation Hypothesis (see Section 5.1.2 for details).

In most of the accounts that I have subsumed under the label Continuation Hypothesis, it remains somewhat unclear whether the authors believe in an organic development, in calques from written Latin, or in a combination of the two.

Pato's (2012) position on the origin of *cualquiera* is not very clear. He seems to suggest that both the Continuation and the Innovation Hypotheses are correct in that – although *qualquier*, *-e*, *-a* may be an innovation (but he does not explicitly say so) – Old Spanish inherited certain syntactic operations from Latin that can be applied to it. In particular, he is referring to the phenomenon of interposition, in which a noun or an NP is placed between the pronoun and the verb *quier* (e.g. *qual manera quier* lit. 'which manner one wants'). He explicitly calls it "a structure inherited from Latin" (Pato 2012: 273). Pato seems to believe that *qual quier* was a quasi indefinite pronoun which could be separated by some linguistic material such as nouns, similar to 'what manner soever'.

However, Pato argues that the form without interposition, i.e. *qual quier* N(P) 'which one wants N(P)' continued the path of grammaticalisation, becoming more fixed after the 13th century, as shown by graphically synthetic form *qualquier* and later *cualquier* (Pato 2012: 297).

I will first review Pato's argumentation for the Continuation Hypothesis and then discuss the problems it entails.

Pato (2012) assumes that the structure with interposition is a characteristic phenomenon of Spanish in the 13th century, which had already arisen in Latin, where *quibet* "may be separated by tmesis into *qui* and *libet*" (Gildersleeve & Lodge 1900: 62, quoted by Pato 2012: 304). The example given by Gildersleeve is Sallust, *De coniuratione Catilinae* 5,4, which reads *quouis rei lubet* 'of any thing'.¹⁷ According to Pato, some Romance languages have inherited this structure. He suggests that the interposition corresponds to the classical poetic structure of tmesis, which is used to separate a syntactic structure for emphatic reasons: "la tmesis o «transposición de palabras» (Institutio Oratoria, Quintiliano) es una licencia poética y retórica clásica (variante del hipérbaton) que consiste en la separación de los dos elementos que forman un compuesto" 'tmesis or "transposition

¹⁷The example itself is not quoted by either Gildersleeve & Lodge or Pato, but was retrieved from the edition of Sallust's works by Ahlberg (1919: 5). *Quouis* is a variant of *cuius*, genitive of the relative pronoun *qui*, and *lubet* is a variant of *libet*. Pato himself (2012: 305) tries to provide a further example from the late Latin *Lex Romana Visigothorum* (which was in use on the Iberian Peninsula): "[...] qui cuius libet rei possessione privati sunt [...]". However, this does not seem to be a case of interposition, if it means, as I think, "who [*qui*] are deprived of the possession of any [*cuius libet*] thing [*rei*]."

of words” (Institutio Oratoria, Quintilian) is a classical and rhetorical license (a variant of hyperbaton) consisting of the separation of two elements forming a compound’ (Pato 2012: 280).

Pato (2012) examines a corpus of works (directed) by Alfonso X of Castile (the Wise), where *qual quier* mostly shows interposition of the following nouns: *estrella* ‘star’, *grado* ‘degree’, *manera* ‘manner’, *logar* ‘place’, and *planeta* ‘planet’ (e.g. *qual manera quier* ‘whichever manner’). The interposition occurs more often than the absence thereof (“sin interposición” ‘without interposition’), which he analyses as *qual quier* NP (97.5% vs 74%, respectively). Pato observes that the form *qual quier* also appears as a single word form in the 13th century. However, he only investigates the separated form (i.e. *qual quier manera* vs. *qual manera quier*). The interposition seems mostly characteristic of the scientific texts of the corpus, in particular of the *Los libros del saber de astronomía* and the *Cánones de Albateni* (Pato 2012: 301).

Table 2.7: Distribution of relative clause structures with and without interposition across different scientific and didactic texts in Old Spanish. The table reports the percentage and raw frequency of each structure by text, as well as overall totals. Adapted from Pato (2012: 282).

	Con interposición		Sin interposición		Totales por texto	
1. <i>Libros del saber de astronomía</i>	58%	(334/578)	19%	(32/168)	49%	(366/746)
2. <i>Cánones de Albateni</i>	15%	(86/578)	--	--	11.5%	(86/746)
3. <i>Espéculos</i>	10%	(60/578)	4.1%	(7/168)	9%	(67/746)
4. <i>Formas e imágenes</i>	4.5%	(26/578)	9%	(15/168)	5.5%	(41/746)
5. <i>Libro del cuadrante señero</i>	4%	(21/578)	--	--	2.8%	(21/746)
6. <i>Judizios de las estrellas</i>	4%	(21/578))	10%	(17/168)	5%	(38/746)
7. <i>Lapidario</i>	2.4%	(4/578)	14%	(24/168)	5%	(38/746)
8. <i>Libro de las cruces</i>	--	(1/578)	13%	(22/168)	3%	(23/746)
9. <i>General estoria, I</i>	--	(1/578)	4%	(7/168)	1%	(8/746)
Total number per structure	97.5%	(564/578)	74%	(124/168)	92%	(688/746)

Pato assumes that interposition is correlated not only with text genre (scientific texts) but also with a certain information-structural function in which the NP was focused in the position between *qual* and *quier*: “parece sensato pensar que la interposición podía emplearse para enfatizar el sustantivo temático, por tanto era una variación aprovechable, pero con carácter literario” ‘it seems sensible to think that the interposition could be used to emphasise the topic noun, therefore it was a usable variation, but with a literary character’ (Pato 2012: 284).

There is a problem with Pato's version of the Continuation Hypothesis. Apart from the fact that Pato is not explicit on the exact relation between the Romance and the supposed Latin structure, i.e. is it really a structure inherited from Latin (as he explicitly says) or an effect of Latinising writing, as other parts of his article may suggest? The fact that interposition occurs mostly in scientific texts would rather suggest the latter.¹⁸

2.6.1.2 Innovation hypothesis/Grammaticalisation hypothesis

According to some linguists, wh-based FCIs such as Spanish *cualquiera* developed from wh-relative clauses.

An early approach of this type is that by Lombard (1938, 1947). Importantly, the author remarks that the verbal component of *quienquiera* and similar formations (including our QUALQUIER) cannot be a calque of Latin models, for the simple reason that *quier(e)* and *quiera* do not translate the corresponding verbal components of the Latin items. These are *libet* 'it pleases' (with no logical subject) and *vis* 'you want' (in 2nd person singular), whereas the Spanish formations show the verb *querer* 'to love, to want' in the 3rd person (and in the subjunctive). The Spanish structure shows an indeterminate logical subject in the meaning of 'one' (a typically Romance usage, but not typical of Latin), which can sometimes be made more precise by using an impersonal reflexive construction (of the type *quien se quier,-e,-a*). Lombard (1938, 1947) thus considers not only QUALQUIER but also Sp. *quienquiera*, *quien se quiera*, *dondequiera* 'wherever', as well as an impressive number of similar formations in many other Romance varieties, as pan-Romance innovations. According to Lombard (1938: 187), in the beginning, the verbal forms in these expressions were, in reality, relative clauses, where the choice of the verb was free (e.g. Old Sp. *tenie gomito é lanzaba cual manjar que le daban*¹⁹ 'He was sick, and thrust out whatever food they gave him'), but later the verbs meaning 'to be' and 'to want' yielded more or less fixed expressions, which could have a relative clause of their own, which could also become fixed (like in *cualquiera que sea*, Port. *como quer que seja*, Catalan, *qualsevulla (qualsevol) que sia*, It. *qual vuolsi sia*).

¹⁸Alternatively, in particular considering the fact that both *Los libros del saber de astronomía* and *Canones de Albateni* are based on Arabic sources, Pato (2012: 306) does not exclude that the interposition phenomenon of *qual quier* might be a calque from Arabic, as suggested by Fernández Fernández González (1992).

¹⁹Quoted from Gessner (1895: 159), where the example is identified as stemming from *Libro de los exemplos* (467 a m).

Ainsi, l'indéfini relatif esp. *cual que* a donné l'indéfini général *cual [que] quiera*, qui a donné le nouvel indéfini relatif *cualquiera que*, qui a donné le nouvel indéfini général *cualquiera que sea*, qui peut même donner le nouvel indéfini relatif *cualquiera que sea que*. De ces trois types d'indéfinis relatifs, seuls les deux premiers, *cual que* et *cualquiera que*, ont réellement une existence.

'Thus, the relative indefinite esp. *cual que* gave rise to the general indefinite *cual [que] quiera*, which gave rise to the new relative indefinite *cualquiera que*, which gave rise to the new general indefinite *cualquiera que sea*, which may even give rise to the new relative indefinite *cualquiera que sea que*. Of these three types of relative indefinite, only the first two, *cual que* and *cualquiera que*, actually exist.'

(Lombard 1938/39: 188)

In a similar vein, more recent authors (Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, Haspelmath 1997, and others) claim that wh-based FCIs such as Sp. *cualquiera* have emerged as a result of a grammaticalisation process in which free relative clauses were reanalysed as indefinite noun phrases (see also Palomo 1934, Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, Girón Alconchel 2012, Brucart 1999: §7.5.7). However, there is no consensus on the precise process of grammaticalisation of Old Spanish *qualquiera*.

One possible explanation why there is no consensus is that the indefinite *qualquiera* was already present in Old Spanish documents. It is thus difficult to confirm the hypothesis of the grammaticalisation on the basis of empirical proof.

The origin of Spanish *cualquiera* according to some authors, is represented in (37) (cf. Cuervo 1893-1895 in Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009: 1086). Note that this grammaticalisation path is a simplified representation, which takes modern graphical representation as basis (Elvira 2007).

- (99) a. Haga en él cual castigo quiera (Step 1)
do.IMP in him which punishment want-you
'Do upon him the punishment which you may want.'
- b. Haga en él cual quiera castigo
→ Free Relative with NP in situ (so-called Split-DP) (Step 2)
- c. Haga en él cualquier(a) castigo
→ Postverbal Indefinite, monoclausal analysis (Step 3)
'Do to him whatever punishment you want'

The most characteristic signs for the grammaticalisation of *qualquier*, *-e*, *-a* according to Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo (2009) are briefly described as follows: The indefinite *qual-quier*, *-e*, *-a* changed in frequency, in phonology (i.e. the loss of *-e* in the form *qual quier*), and in its morphosyntactic status (see also Lehmann 1995 for typical features of grammaticalisation). Its previous semantic interpretation was weakened as well; that is, its etymological interpretation has been lost and it acquired a new syntactic status. I will return to the frequency and especially to the semantic weakening in Section 2.6.2. As for the phonological weakening, the loss of *e* in the form *-quier* is not specific to the item at issue here but is due to a general phonological apocope that applied to all kinds of syntactic categories from the 13th to the 14th century. It can thus hardly be counted as evidence for grammaticalisation.

Given the list of arguments for the Romance *Innovation Hypothesis*, which have been already convincingly discussed in Lombard (1938, 1947), I assume that this hypothesis is stronger than the Continuation Hypothesis, i.e. Old Sp. *qualquiera*, *-e*, *-a* is derived from a relative clause structure.

2.6.2 Semantic change in time

Not much research exists on the diachrony of the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* in European or Argentinian Spanish. According to Company-Company (2009a), the change in meaning of *cualquiera* from FCI to EVAL is due to a *subjectification process*, whereby the meaning of *cualquiera* acquires a more subjective interpretation over time (see also Traugott 1989 for *subjectification* as trigger of meaning change in English). Company-Company (2009a) suggests that the free choice indefinite *cualquiera* has undergone the change into the evaluative *cualquiera*, triggering speaker-independent alternatives to a more subjective meaning dependent on the speaker's evaluation. However, it remains to be seen what this subjective interpretation exactly means and how this change towards a more subjective meaning occurred. I will deal with this question in Chapters 4 and 5. With respect to the diachrony of *cualquiera* in European Spanish in Chapter 5, I will also study the grammaticalisation of *cualquiera* in order to understand how the occurrence of the evaluative meaning fits into the grammaticalisation process, which according to the literature correlates with a loss and not with an enrichment of meanings of the grammaticalised construction (Traugott 1989, Heine et al. 1991, among others). With respect to the diachrony of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, Rizzo Salierno (2013) assumes that the potential linguistic precedent of the gradable predicate *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish is possibly related to the gradable predicate *cualunque*, an Italianism (see

Section 2.1.5). *Cualunque* appeared in Argentinian Spanish during the Italian immigration (on *qualunque* in Italian, see Chierchia 2006, Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. 2010, among others) (see Section 2.1.5). Like *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, *cualunque* also allows degree modification (unlike in Italian, see Kellert & Francia 2024) and can be used predicatively or attributively in a postnominal position, as happens with *cualquiera*, and have an evaluative interpretation like ‘ordinary’:

- (100) El que yo digo era re *cualunque*.
the that I say was very CUALUNQUE
‘The one that I said was very ordinary.’
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 28)
- (101) Es una flaca *cualunque* que se cree que es Marilyn Monroe.
is a woman CUALUNQUE that REFL believes that is Marilyn Monroe
‘She is an ordinary woman who thinks she’s Marilyn Monroe.’
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 29)

However, the change from an indefinite pronoun/determiner/postnominal modifier *cualunque* to a gradable adjective *cualunque* and for that matter the transfer of this function to *cualquiera* remains unexplained. I will deal with this change in Chapter 4.

With respect to the question how different meanings developed, it remains an open question how the reanalysis of the indefinite *cualquiera* into an item with the evaluative meaning ‘common/unremarkable’ in European Spanish and into a degree adjective with meaning ‘unremarkable/bad’ or an evaluative noun with the meaning ‘nonsense’ in Argentinian Spanish fits models of linguistic reanalysis in the frameworks of formal semantics (Eckardt 2006, Bar-Asher Siegal 2020, Aloni 2021, among others). According to these authors, it is possible to describe reanalysis on the level of morphosyntactic form (F) and/or on the level of meaning (M) as shown in (102).

- (102) Scenarios of reanalysis (see Aloni 2021):
Scenario 1: {F1;M1}^{t1} → {F2;M2}^{t2}
Scenario 2: {F1;M1}^{t1} → {F1;M2}^{t2}
Scenario 3: {F1;M1}^{t1} → {F2;M1}^{t2}

Reanalysis can take place both at the morphological/syntactical level F and at the semantic level M (Scenario 1), or it can be restricted to one level (Scenarios 2 and 3). Diachronic semantics deals with changes in Scenarios 1 and 2. The

important claim of the formal semantic studies is that, at both points of time (t1 and t2), F suits M in a compositional manner — this is necessary for a reanalysis to take place (see Eckardt 2006, Bar-Asher Siegal 2020, Aloni 2021).

2.7 Open questions on *cualquiera* and outlook for this book

In this section, I discuss open questions and present the outlook for this book.

2.7.1 Questions on synchrony

There is no detailed discussion or definition of the non-modal meaning of *cualquiera* ‘ordinary/common’ (which I have called the evaluative meaning, EVAL1) in predicative contexts in Modern Spanish and how this meaning of *cualquiera* is related to other meanings such as the free choice meaning ‘any’ and the random choice meaning ‘random’. The examples discussed in the literature seem to indicate that this evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* depends on the verb class, i.e. it is specifically found with non-volitional verbs (e.g. *copular* verbs, episodic tense, perception verbs) (see Section 2.3). EVAL2 is also present with verbs such as *hacer/decir cualquiera* ‘do/talk nonsense’ in Argentinian Spanish and French *n’importe quoi* (see Section 2.1). I will therefore look into verb classes more systematically and address the question how the definition of EVAL can capture the variation in meanings under predicative verbs such as the meaning ‘common’ and the derogatory version of it, such as ‘nothing special/unremarkable’ (EVAL1) and the meaning as ‘nonsense’ under volitional verbs such as *hacer/decir* (EVAL2). This meaning variation correlates to the variation in varieties of Spanish (Argentinian vs. European Spanish), as the meaning ‘nonsense’ (EVAL2) is only present in Argentinian Spanish (see Chapter 3 for European Spanish and Chapter 4 for Argentinian Spanish).

Another question that needs to be answered is what syntactic and semantic status the postnominal *cualquiera* has in European Spanish. Is it a determiner or something else? And what status does the evaluative *cualquiera* have under volitional verbs in Argentinian Spanish? Is it an indefinite pronoun or a noun?

It also remains to be seen whether all readings of *cualquiera* or at least a subset of them can be derived from a more general meaning of *cualquiera* or whether *cualquiera* is lexically ambiguous as Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito (2018) suggest (see Section 2.2.3). My working hypothesis is that the evaluative meaning is the result of a reanalysis of the *modal cualquiera* (i.e. *cualquiera* that is used

under a modal) in certain syntactic and semantic contexts in diachrony. I will address these issues within the synchronic and diachronic study of *cualquiera* in Chapters 3, 4 and 5.

The classification system of *cualquiera* chosen by Aloni, Aguilar Guevara, et al. (2010) in Section 2.5 is not satisfactory, because it mixes up syntactic and semantic properties of *cualquiera* and does not correlate them. For instance, conditional antecedents and comparative clauses are syntactic structures that can license *cualquiera*. Consequently, conditional antecedents and comparative clauses are syntactic contexts, as both sentence types can license FCIs. From the results in Figure 2.1 in Section 2.5, we do not learn whether different functions correlate with different syntactic positions of *cualquiera* (e.g. +/- prenominal position). The classification map in Table 2.5 in Section 2.5 does not contain a definition of the ‘no matter’ interpretation, making it difficult to judge how it is different from the indiscriminative interpretation (IND). Moreover, the RC and evaluative interpretations are absent from the classification system as well as from the frequency distribution in Table 2.5 and Figure 2.1 in Section 2.1 and Section 2.2.3.3. Given the critical points mentioned with respect to Table 2.5, I decided to use a more detailed syntactic classification of *cualquiera* for my corpus analysis of the word in synchrony and diachrony (see Chapters 3, 4, and 5). I will describe the evaluative function of *cualquiera* in more detail in Chapters 3 and 4 and relate it to its grammatical function (i.e. N *cualquiera* in Chapter 3 and *decir cualquiera* in Chapter 4). The diachronic study in Chapters 4 and 5 will help us understand the syntactic and semantic status of *cualquiera* in different positions and different varieties of Spanish.

2.7.2 Questions on diachrony and the diatopic variation of *cualquiera*

One important diachronic question is how the evaluative meanings *cualquiera* came into existence in European and Argentinian Spanish. Does it have the same origin? In order to answer this question I will study the diachrony of *cualquiera* with EVAL2 in Chapter 4 and the diachrony of EVAL1 in Chapter 5. According to many linguists (Blank 1997, Traugott 1989, Eckardt 2006, among others), semantic change is often triggered by pragmatic enrichment of the target utterance. For instance, the new meaning can be the result of reanalysing the old meaning with contextual information (some pragmatic implicatures). The open question is whether the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* in European and Argentinian Spanish is based on some pragmatic reanalysis in a compositional manner.

I will argue in Chapters 3, 4, and 5 that the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* is the result of using free choice indefinites in certain syntactic positions, such as

the predicative position. I will show that the appearance of the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* is an example of Scenario 1 in (102). Moreover, I will argue that the evaluative meaning is the result of pragmatic strengthening because the free choice meaning (the original meaning) is enriched by contextual information in certain pragmatic contexts in which some attitude holder *x* expresses her evaluation towards the proposition ‘every possibility is an option’ (FCI) or towards the proposition ‘every possibility matches agent’s decisions’ (RCI) expressed by *cualquiera*. This contextual interpretation has triggered a reanalysis of *cualquiera* into an evaluative predicate in European and Argentinian Spanish with further reanalysis into a degree predicate in Argentinian Spanish. I dub my analysis ‘modal indefinites under attitudes’. My analysis thus combines research from two different camps: modal and polarity sensitive items as discussed in this section and semantics dealing with attitudes and evaluation (e.g. personal taste predicates) (see Heim 1982, Lasersohn 2005, among others), which I will introduce in Chapters 3 and 4.

3 Evaluative meaning of postnominal *cualquiera* in European Spanish

As I already showed in Chapter 2, the evaluative reading of (UN) N *cualquiera* ‘common, ordinary’ can appear after predicative verbs, such as the copular(-like) verbs *ser* ‘to be’ and *parecer* ‘to seem’ (see Section 2.1.3). In this chapter, I investigate the evaluative meaning of (UN) N *cualquiera* in more detail. In order to do so, I will start with the description of (UN) N *cualquiera* in predicative contexts and extend this description to other verbs.

My observations are primarily based on corpus data from *Corpus del Español* (CdE), in particular the following subcorpus CdE_web dialects_EurSp. On particular occasions, I also use speaker judgments. The crucial result of my observations, which will serve the analysis of *cualquiera*, is that predicative UN N *cualquiera* appears extremely often (ca. 98% of all data), especially under negation (around 80%), see Section 3.1.

As I will argue in the subsequent sections (Section 3.2–Section 3.5), negation and the predicative position of UN N *cualquiera* trigger the reading ‘a common N’ or ‘an ordinary N’ which I subsumed under the term EVAL to distinguish it from modal readings such as ‘any’ and ‘random’. In order to explain certain types of data, such as coordination with adjectives, I will postulate a reanalysis of *cualquiera* into a (frequency) adjective (i.e. with the meaning ‘common’) in European Spanish (see Section 3.5). I will argue that negation plays an important role in this reanalysis, as it introduces a contrastive property into the discourse, which strengthens the property interpretation of postnominal *cualquiera* as ‘common’ or ‘unremarkable’.

The chapter is organised as follows. In Section 3.1, I first present some data concerning the distribution of postnominal *cualquiera*, which show that it typically occurs in predicative syntactic contexts, and, most frequently, under negation. I will then describe the evaluative function in more detail in Section 3.2. I will argue that what I call the ‘common’ reading can be assumed as the basic meaning of postnominal *cualquiera*, from which the derogatory meaning of ‘low value’ can be derived. In Section 3.3, I present and discuss some additional properties of postnominal *cualquiera*, in particular the possibility of an overt experimenter,

the extensional meaning of the ‘common’ reading and its relationship to the free choice reading, and the possibility of postnominal *cualquiera* under modal verbs. After a brief intermediate summary in Section 3.4, I will show in Section 3.5 that *cualquiera* in its ‘common’ reading can be derived from the FCI function if we analyse it as a quantifier under a generic operator in predicative and episodic contexts. Section 3.3 will offer an analysis according to which *cualquiera*, when it occurs under definite nouns, is no longer interpreted as a quantifier, but as an item referring to a property of types of individuals. I will argue that both analyses, the quantifier analysis and the adjectival analysis, are needed in order to capture the corpus data and the ambiguity between the free choice and the evaluative interpretation of *cualquiera* observed in the literature (see Chapter 2, in particular my discussion of Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2011, 2018).

3.1 Distribution of postnominal *cualquiera* in the Corpus del Español_web dialects

In this subsection, I only used the subcorpus Corpus del Español_web dialects (henceforth: CdE_web dialects) because other subcorpora did not allow for the automatic extraction of frequencies in European Spanish by the time I collected data in CdE in 2016.¹ Henceforth, I will use square brackets [] for the different constructions I searched for in this corpus, e.g. [V UN N *cualquiera*] (= postnominal *cualquiera* after the verb).

Table 3.1 summarises the distribution of +/- affirmative mood of [V UN N *cualquiera*]. It appears in negative contexts (with implicit or explicit negation) more often than in affirmative ones.

The most frequent verb type that precedes UN N *cualquiera* is the copular verb *ser* ‘be’ (98% of all verbs), whose most frequent verb form (verb token) is the indicative present tense (*es* ‘is’, 88%). The less frequent verb type are transitive verbs such as *poner* ‘put’ (Table 3.2).

The observation that the most frequent verb token is *es* 3rd person singular and not plural suggests that UN N *cualquiera* is usually used by speakers to describe a property of a single person or entity and not a property of different entities or people. As we will see in Section 3.2, the most frequent token is *un día cualquiera* ‘an ordinary day’. Thus, UN N *cualquiera* is mostly used to describe the day of speaker’s reference as ordinary or usual.

¹In the meantime, many larger subcorpora have emerged that also allow for automatic frequency extraction. In the future, I will make a comparison between these subcorpora.

3.1 Distribution in the Corpus del Espanol_web dialects

Table 3.1: Distribution of +/- affirmative contexts of V+ UN N *cualquiera* in CdE_web dialects in European Spanish. The first line shows the percentages and the second line the absolute numbers of occurrences.

V + UN N <i>cualquiera</i>	V + UN N <i>cualquiera</i> in affirmative contexts	Neg + V + UN N <i>cualquiera</i>
100%	18%	82%
353	66	287
(explicit negation = 283 = 99% of total negation)		

Table 3.2: Distribution of verbs in V + UN N *cualquiera* in CdE_web dialects in European Spanish. Other determiners were disregarded due to low frequency. The first line shows the percentages and the second line the absolute numbers of occurrences.

V + UN N <i>cualquiera</i>	Ser + UN N <i>cualquiera</i>	Other verbs
100%	98%	2%
353	345	8
	es (88% = 308)	<i>puse, prestó</i>

All examples that I have examined show that 82% of [V UN N *cualquiera*] occur under implicit negation as in (1)² or explicit negation as in (2), whereby explicit negation is a more frequent type (99% of total cases with negation):

- (1) ¿Sigues pensando que fue un día *cualquiera*? [...] es lunes 5 de do.still thinking that was a day CUALQUIERA [...] is Monday 5 of diciembre de 2011.
December of 2011
'Are you still thinking that it was a normal day? [...] it's Monday, December 5, 2011.'
(@ 40)
- (2) [...] que esto no es un libro *cualquiera*, esto es un libro de James Dashner.
[...] that this not is a book CUALQUIERA this is a book of James Dashner
'[...] that this is not an ordinary book, this is a book from James Dashner.'
(@ 41)

²I counted as implicit negation only those cases where the context was very clear that the speaker does not believe that the proposition expressed by V UN N *cualquiera* is true.

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Affirmative contexts appear less frequently than negative contexts (see Table 2.7). Recall that affirmative contexts usually represent a puzzle for the licensing of *cualquiera* as an FCI (see Section 2.2) unless rescued by some operators (see Section 2.3).

In affirmative contexts (i.e. contexts without explicit or implicit negation) the verb in [V UN N *cualquiera*] can be of different types, such as transitive verbs and predicative verbs, that is, verbs that take predicative complements as their argument. Predicative verbs are the most common verb type in this corpus as will be shown in Table 3.1. They are often realised as a copular verb in present indicative, as in (3) and (4):

- (3) Parece una chiquilla *cualquiera*, vestida con una túnica liviana
seems a girl CUALQUIERA dressed with a tunic lightweight
que adorna su cuerpo hermoso y esconde el brazo derecho
that adorns her body beautiful and hides the arm right
mutilado.
mutilated
'She looks like a common little girl, ...'
(@ 42)
- (4) De todos modos, tampoco os esperéis la gran historia. Es una
of all ways neither expect you the great story is a
historia *cualquiera*.
story CUALQUIERA
'Anyways, don't expect a big story either. It's a story like any other.'
(@ 43)

There are fewer occurrences of other verb types that are not copular verbs, e.g. transitive verbs such as *prestó* and *puse* in (5) and (6). Non-copular verbs that appear in [V UN N *cualquiera*] are usually realised with perfective aspect, expressed in Spanish with the *pretérito indefinido* (in so-called episodic contexts; see section Section 2.3 for discussion of episodic contexts):

- (5) La NYK *prestó* un contenedor *cualquiera* a la BBC.
the NYK lent a container CUALQUIERA to the BBC
'The NYK borrowed a random container to the BBC.'
(@ 44)

- (6) Le puse un nombre *cualquiera*.
 I gave a name CUALQUIERA
 'I put some random name.'
 (@ 45)

With respect to the distribution of the determiner preceding N *cualquiera*, the most frequent determiner in the corpus under investigation is the indefinite determiner UN, as already observed in the literature (see Chapter 2). However, there are few cases of N *cualquiera* being preceded by definite determiners, demonstratives, and quantifiers (definite determiner N *cualquiera* 136 = 0.30 per mil vs. indefinite N *cualquiera* 1541 = 3.36 per mil).

In the following examples, the definite noun refers to a certain kind of man, namely to the common man as a type. One could also describe this type as *el hombre de la calle*, lit. 'the man from the street' or 'common/normal man':

- (7) El hombre *cualquiera* del autobús no siente vergüenza alguna,
 the man CUALQUIERA of.the bus NEG feels shame any
 aunque debería,...
 although should
 '[...] The common man from the bus does not feel any shame, although he should,...'
 (@ 82)

- (8) Las armas de este hombre *cualquiera*, de aspecto normal, se
 the weapons of this man CUALQUIERA of appearance normal REFL
 resumen en: prudencia.
 summarised in: prudence
 'The weapons of this common, normal-looking man are summarised in: caution.'
 (@ 83)

Cualquiera also occurs with quantified nouns (see Section 2.1.4 on the discussion concerning quantified nouns):

- (9) Esto lo saben mucha gente *cualquiera*.
 this it know many people CUALQUIERA
 'This is known to many ordinary people.'
 (@ 84)

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- (10) Las cifras del IMC se obtienen tras el estudio de los datos
the figures of.the BMI REFL obtener.3PL.PRS after the study of the data
de muchísimas chicas *cualquiera*.
of very.many girls CUALQUIERA
'The figures in the IMC are obtained after studying many ordinary young women.'
(Fulton, *Seis semanas*, El índice de masa corporal)
- (11) vamos a morir algún día *cualquiera*
go.1PL to die some day CUALQUIERA
'we will die on some ordinary day'
(@ 85, @ 86)

It has been shown that postnominal *cualquiera* occurs more often under negation than in affirmative contexts (see Table 3.1). The question arises as to what the interpretation of postnominal *cualquiera* is in affirmative and negative contexts. I will analyse the interpretations in these contexts in more detail in Section 3.2.

In the following sections, I will first focus on UN N *cualquiera* as opposed to other determiners, as it is the most frequent type in European Spanish. As predicative UN N *cualquiera* is a very important type in this variety according to my corpus analysis, I will investigate this type more closely, especially the meanings of UN N *cualquiera* under predicative verbs. I will then provide an analysis of *cualquiera* under definite nouns.

3.2 Interpretations of postnominal *cualquiera*

I have analysed all examples of postnominal *cualquiera* and will present the results by focusing on the interpretations of the most frequent tokens after the verb in affirmative and negative contexts. One heuristic for approaching the semantic readings of UN N *cualquiera* is to investigate the range and types of appositives and adverbial modifications that co-occur with UN N *cualquiera*, as they can provide us with additional information about the syntactic and semantic status of *cualquiera* (see also Condoravdi 2015: 227 for English). I have looked at the possible appositives and adverbial modifications that UN N *cualquiera* can have within the corpus CdE_web dialects as well as the pragmatic context in which this construction appears. I do not report the frequency of appositives or adverbial modification as there are only few examples (1 or 2) of a particular type of appositives or adverbial modification. However, I do report the frequency of interpretations that I identified via adverbial modification, appositives, and pragmatic context.

3.2.1 Readings in affirmative contexts

There is a total of 187 occurrences of postnominal *cualquiera* in affirmative contexts with the search algorithm [!no Verb Article Noun *cualquiera*]. The ten most frequent instances in the corpus are: *es un día cualquiera*, *es un chico cualquiera*, *era un día cualquiera*, *acaban comprando un ereader cualquiera*, *narra un día cualquiera*, *para coger un libro cualquiera*, *dado un número cualquiera*, *empecé una tarde cualquiera*, *coges una foto cualquiera*, *ha un servicio cualquiera* (English ‘it’s a normal day, it’s a normal boy, it was a normal day, they end up buying some (random) ereader, it’s a normal day, to take any book, given a random number, a normal afternoon began, you take any/random photo, there is a normal service.’)

As can be seen from the ten most frequent occurrences in affirmative contexts, postnominal *cualquiera* appears under indicative verbal mood, e.g. *es/era/empecé* ‘is/was/began ...’ or under non-indicative verbal mood, e.g. infinitives, imperatives, future, etc. as in *para coger*, *coges* ‘to take, you choose’. The present form *coges* has an imperative interpretation in the example (13). Under non-indicative verbal mood, the interpretation is the FCI ‘any’ or RCI ‘random’:

- (12) ¿Leéis el prólogo antes que el libro o lo dejáis
 read.PRS.2PL the prologue before that the book or it leave.PRS.2PL
 para el final? Hoy es un gran día para coger un libro **cualquiera**
 for the end today is a great day to take a book CUALQUIERA
 y sumergirse en sus páginas.
 and immerse in its pages
 ‘Do you (plural) read the prologue before the book or do you leave it for
 the end? Today is a big day to take any/a random book...’ (@ 286)
- (13) Coges una foto **cualquiera**, de cualquier cosa, le metes un par
 take a photo CUALQUIERA of CUALQUIER thing, it.DAT put a pair
 de filtros y ya tienes una obra de arte.
 of filters and already have a work of art
 ‘Take any foto/a random foto, of anything, [...]’.
 (@ 286)

Under indicative verbal mood, postnominal *cualquiera* has the interpretation of ‘normal’, ‘common’, ‘ordinary’ or ‘typical’ (henceforth COM) in all examples except three, where it has the derogatory interpretation of ‘low value’ (henceforth DER) or the random interpretation (RCI):

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- (14) Aaron parece un hombre *cualquiera*, acomodado a la rutina del
 Aaron seems a man CUALQUIERA, adjusted to the routine of the
 barrio donde vive, ocupado en su trabajo.
 neighborhood where lives busy in his work
 ‘Aaron looks like a normal man, adjusted to the routine of his
 neighborhood, immersed in his work’. (@ 279)
- (15) - Hola, soy Celia. - ¡¡Hola Celia!! - Tengo 23 años y soy adicta. -
 ¡¡Bienvenida!! ¡Cuéntanos tu historia! -
 Empecé una tarde *cualquiera* de un mes *cualquiera*.
 started a afternoon CUALQUIERA of a month CUALQUIERA.
 La llamada de La lista era fuerte y poderosa.
 ‘Hello, I’m Celia. Hello Celia. I’m 23 years old and I’m an addict. Welcome.
 Tell us your story. I started on an ordinary day of an ordinary month.’ (@
 283)
- Two examples under indicative verbal mood have an explicit derogatory interpretation, which is identifiable by expressions like ‘there are worse days’ or ‘mediocre’.
- (16) En fin, baños y cenas (otra guerra, ya me duché ayer, no me laves la
 cabeza, la hermana me ha escupido.....). A las nueve más o menos a la
 cama, los dientes y los cuentos; mientras ella les lee los cuentos yo recojo
 por tercera o cuarta vez la cocina; cuando acabo les voy a hacer unos
 arrumacos a los niños en la cama, les gusta que me despida de ellos.
 Terminado; al sofá, soma, quiero soma, y enciendo la puta tele, me alieno
 un poco y si no caigo rendido, me paso al ordenador, a trabajar un poco en
 mis cosas, o a desenchufar me un poco más leyendo blogs como el tuyo.
Este es un día *cualquiera*, pero te juro que los hay mucho
 this is a day CUALQUIERA but to you swear that there are much
peores.
 worse
 ‘This is an ordinary day, but I swear to you that there are much worse
 days.’ (@ 278)
- (17) Por todo esto se podría decir que es una **comedia *cualquiera*** de las que
 nos han llegado en los últimos tiempos, y realmente eso es lo que es. La
 diferencia es que a esta no le sobran minutos ni escenas, que el ritmo no
 baja demasiado y no llega a aburrirte, y, sobre todo, que hasta consigue

3.2 Interpretations of postnominal *cualquiera*

robar te alguna carcajada, lo que cada vez es más difícil con las comedias de Hollywood.

Solo por eso, **una película mediocre como esta** ya merece más
only for that a movie mediocre like this already deserves more
la pena que muchas otras.
the worth than many others

‘For all these reasons we can say that **it’s an ordinary comedy** among those that we had in recent time [...] Only for this reason, **a mediocre movie like this one** is more worth than other movies.] (@ 284)’

In only one example, *cualquiera* has the interpretation of ‘random’ under the transitive verb ‘buy’ (see §2 for RCI):

- (18) mis consultantes acaban comprando un ereader *cualquiera* (el
my clients end.up buying an ereader CUALQUIERA (the
más barato) y cargándolo de libros en su ordenador, [...] (the
cheapest) and loading it with books in their computer [...] (the
‘my consultants just bought some random ereader (the cheapest one) and [...],’ (@ 280)

The affirmative sentence *Es un N_[animate] cualquiera* can appear with a comparative expression which expresses similarity between the referent to which the property UN N_[animate] *cualquiera* applies (here: *Juan*) and other individuals of the same comparison class (here: ‘everyone else like you and me’):

- (19) Juan es un hombre *cualquiera*, cargado de errores. Como tú, o
Juan is a man CUALQUIERA loaded with errors like you, or
como yo.
like I
‘Juan is a human being like everyone else, full of flaws. Like you, or like me.’
(@ 46)

The similarity construction is expressed by the comparison term *como* ‘like’, which expresses similarity between the referent and a high number of individuals that share some (basic or prototypical)³ properties or at least one prototypical

³The assumption that *common* properties must be basic follows from the similarity of all individuals denoted by N *cualquiera*. For instance, *un trabajo cualquiera* ‘a job CUALQUIERA’ is a job that shares with other jobs the most basic properties, whatever it is that defines a job as a job, such as getting up early, working for eight hours, going back home, etc.

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property with the subject. It is impossible to find a comparison to a set of individuals that contains only one individual or none:

- (20) Juan_j es un hombre *cualquiera*, cargado de errores. # No hay
 Juan is a man CUALQUIERA loaded with errors. # NEG there.is
 otro hombre que tenga errores como él_j.
 another man who has errors like he
 ‘Juan is a human being like everyone else, full of flaws. #There is no one else like him.’

In the following example, the morning the speaker refers to is a (kind of) morning that is similar to all or many other mornings.

- (21) Fue una mañana *cualquiera*, como cada mañana. Había estado
 was a morning CUALQUIERA like every morning had been
 leyendo y llamó uno de los muchachos de la cantina.
 reading and called one of the boys from the bar
 ‘It was a morning like any other mornings. I had been reading and one of the guys from the canteen called.’
 (@ 46)

Indeed, native speakers deem it possible for (22) to have the same interpretation as in (21). This shows that even though the comparison is not overtly or explicitly expressed by *como* ‘like’, speakers can infer an implicit comparison from UN N *cualquiera* (see Section 3.3.3):

- (22) Fue una mañana *cualquiera*. Había estado leyendo y llamó uno de
 was a morning CUALQUIERA had been reading and called one of
 los muchachos de la cantina.
 the boys from the bar
 ‘It was a morning like any other. I had been reading and one of the guys from the canteen called.’
 (@ 47)

There are also appositives that describe N *cualquiera* as N *corriente* ‘normal/regular/frequent N’ as in (23) or N *cualquiera* itself can appear as an appositive clause that describes N *normal* ‘normal N’ as in (24).

- (23) Hoy es un día *cualquiera*, un día corriente, [...]
 today is a day CUALQUIERA a day common
 ‘Today is a day like many other days, a regular day, ...’
 (@ 48)

3.2 Interpretations of postnominal *cualquiera*

- (24) Yo soy una persona normal, un tipo *cualquiera*.
I am a person normal a guy CUALQUIERA
'I am a normal person, a guy like other guys.'
(@ 49, @ 50)

Finally, some appositives clearly indicate that UN N *cualquiera* can have a derogatory meaning (DER). In these contexts, N *cualquiera* is described as not worth mentioning:

- (25) era un tipo *cualquiera*, sin ninguna particularidad digna de
was a guy CUALQUIERA without any particularity worthy of
mención.
mention
'he was an ordinary guy, without any particular quality worth
mentioning.'
(@ 51)

In the following example, the derogatory reading is expressed by the use of the adverb *simplemente* 'just' or *nada más* 'nothing but', which expresses that the person described by N *cualquiera* has no properties other than that described by N *cualquiera*:

- (26) Era simplemente un tipo *cualquiera*.
was simply a guy CUALQUIERA
'It was just an ordinary guy.'
(@ 52)
- (27) No soy nada más que un chico *cualquiera*, que pasaría
NEG am nothing more than a boy CUALQUIERA, who would pass
desapercibido, sin más, normal, que se diría.
unnoticed, without more normal than REFL said
'I am nothing but an ordinary boy, that would go unnoticed, nothing
more, normal, that one would say.'
(@ 53)

The meanings identified in affirmative contexts under indicative verbal mood are related to each other. 'Being similar to anyone else' implies 'to be normal'. The derogatory reading expresses a negative judgment of 'being normal' or 'similar to anyone else', which can be paraphrased as 'being just normal' and 'not special'. I will investigate this semantic relation more closely in Section 3.3.2.

To summarise the interpretations of UN N *cualquiera* in affirmative contexts, *cualquiera* means ‘any’ (FCI) under non-indicative verbal mood. It has the meaning ‘similar like any other’, ‘common’, ‘typical’ (COM) or a derogatory interpretation as ‘not special’, ‘just common’, ‘just like any other’ (EVAL1) under indicative verbal mood under predicative verbs like ‘be’ and ‘appear’. In affirmative contexts, the derogatory interpretation is less common than the neutral interpretation of ‘common’, ‘similar like any other’ (1 %, i.e. 2 out of 188 examples). In predicative contexts, UN N *cualquiera* refers to entities or individuals that share common properties or properties that everyone else has. Thus, *es un día cualquiera* expresses ‘it’s a day like any other day’ or ‘it’s a common day’. A formal analysis of N *cualquiera* as a type/property of individuals will be proposed in Section 3.3.1.

3.2.2 Readings under explicit and implicit negation

In all examples in the corpus that occur in negative contexts with the search algorithm [no Verb DET N *cualquiera*] (288 examples in total, see Section 3.1), postnominal N *cualquiera* expresses a contrast between *no Verb DET N cualquiera* and an alternative with a property of being special (e.g., *no es un día cualquiera, es un día especial*. ‘It’s not a normal day, it’s a special day’).

The first ten most frequent instances of the search algorithm are: *no es un día cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary day’, *no es un libro cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary book’, *no es un momento cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary moment’, *no es un país cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary country’, *no es un partido cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary party’, *no es una historia cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary story’, *no es un ejército cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary army’, *no es un circo cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary circus’, *no es un jugador cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary player’, *no es un regalo cualquiera* ‘not an ordinary gift’.

Under implicit negation, for example with the counterfactual interpretation of the verb *sería* in (28) or the question context in (29), UN N *cualquiera* has an evaluative interpretation:

- (28) Pensaron que sería un día *cualquiera*. Pero no. La basura en
 thought that be.COND.3SG a day CUALQUIERA but NEG the trash in
 el mar hizo que ese viernes sea diferente.
 the sea made that that Friday be different
 ‘They thought that it would have been a normal day. But no. The rubbish
 in the sea turned this Friday into a special day.’
 (@ 54, @ 55)

- (29) ¿Pensabas que este sábado sería un sábado *cualquiera*?
 thought that this Saturday be.COND.3SG a Saturday CUALQUIERA
 ‘You thought that this Saturday would be a normal Saturday?’
 (@ 56, @ 57)

N cualquiera under (explicit or implicit) negation is used to express a contrast to a (proper) noun or some other DP that contains a reference to a single individual or type of individual. This individual/entity has the property of being ‘particular’, ‘distinguished’, ‘uncommon’, or having ‘higher value’ than *N cualquiera*, such as Messi (who is known to be an extraordinary football player) in (30) or the author John Dashner⁴ in (31).

- (30) Sin Messi, el Barcelona sería un equipo *cualquiera*.
 without Messi the Barcelona be.COND.3SG a team CUALQUIERA
 ‘Without Messi, the team Barcelona would be some unimportant football team.’
 (@ 58)
- (31) [...] que esto no es un libro *cualquiera*, esto es un libro de James
 [...] that this NEG is a book CUALQUIERA this is a book by James
 Dashner.
 Dashner
 ‘[...] that this is no ordinary book, this is a book by James Dashner.’
 (@ 41)

To sum up, the negation triggers a contrastive clause expressed by a proper noun (e.g. Messi) or some DP (*un libro de James Dashner*) which singles out one and only one alternative that has the property of being particular, uncommon, or outstanding. This alternative is opposed to the individuals described by UN *N cualquiera*.

As I will suggest in my analysis, predicative verbs represent a special linguistic context that gives rise to reanalysis of *N cualquiera* into a property type and thus a shift from a quantifier *cualquiera* into a property *cualquiera* (see 3.3.1).

3.2.3 The semantic/pragmatic status of meanings

The question arises as to which of the readings identified in Section 3.2.1 and Section 3.2.2, namely the readings ‘any’, ‘common’ or ‘low value’ is a lexical

⁴The further context of (31) (from a book review) reveals that this author is particularly distinguished for writing books full of suspense and action.

meaning of *cualquiera* and which one is just an implicature and then, whether one can cancel this implicature and thus can cancel the meaning of postnominal *cualquiera* (see Aloni 2021, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018 on different views).

As has been argued by Grice (1975), conversational implicatures are usually cancellable, because they highly depend on contextual factors. Conventional implicatures usually resist cancellation because they convey a side comment by the speaker and do not contribute to the at-issue meaning of the sentence (Potts 2005, Simons et al. 2010). I assume that the neutral meaning of postnominal *cualquiera* as ‘common’ (COM) is the lexical meaning, whereas the derogatory meaning as ‘low value’ (DER) is a contextual or pragmatic interpretation of ‘common’ (i.e. having common properties or properties like anyone or anything else is judged contextually as having unextraordinary properties). The empirical evidence for this assumption is the observation that the derogatory meaning requires contextual information in which some negative attitude is expressed, such as ‘mediocre’. To confirm this assumption, I informally asked several speakers to see which reading could be canceled. The judgments seem to confirm that the derogatory meaning is cancellable. The word *cualquiera* is not translated into English because it was up to the native speakers to decide which meaning best fits the context introduced by the *pero* ‘but’ clause:

- (32) a. #Juan es un hombre *cualquiera*, pero no es como los demás.
 Juan is a man CUALQUIERA but NEG is like the others
 ‘Juan is a man, but he is not ordinary.’
 b. Juan es un hombre *cualquiera*, pero no es un hombre sin
 Juan is a man CUALQUIERA but NEG is a man without
 nivel.
 level.
 ‘Juan is a man, but he is not a man without class.’

None of the speakers accepted the sentence in (32). The first clause in (32) expresses that Juan is a man like any other, while the second clause in (32) expresses the opposite, namely that Juan is not like others, resulting in a contradiction. I assume that it is this contradiction that triggered the negative judgments in (32). The sentence in (32b) does not lead to a contradiction, because it expresses that Juan is like many others, but he is not a man without class or a simple man. I take these results to mean that the meaning ‘common’ is the lexical meaning of *cualquiera* and that the derogatory meaning is a contextual meaning derived pragmatically. The frequency distribution of the derogatory meaning confirms

this assumption because the derogatory meaning is less frequent in the corpus data than the meaning of *cualquiera* as ‘common’ (see Chapter 3.2.1). However, a controlled experimental study is needed to confirm these results.

Assuming that the lexical meaning of *cualquiera* is its free choice meaning that triggers alternatives (see Chapter 2), a reasonable assumption would be that the meaning ‘common’ (COM) is semantically related to the free choice ‘any’. I will suggest such an analysis in Section 3.5, where I will show that the meaning ‘like anyone else/anything else’ or ‘common’ is a special case of ‘any’. Having common properties is judged contextually as having unremarkable properties.

In the following section, I will investigate further semantic properties of UN *N cualquiera* that will help define and characterise its meanings more precisely.

3.2.4 +/- evaluative *cualquiera*

Evaluative *cualquiera* with the readings ‘common’ or ‘normal’ should be distinguished from FC *cualquiera* ‘any’. Both interpretations can be made explicit in the following example:

- (33) la existencia de un delito *cualquiera*
 the existence of a crime CUALQUIERA
 ‘the existence of any criminal act’ *cualquiera* (FCI)
 ‘the existence of a common criminal act’ (EVAL)
 (@ 69)

Under the FCI reading, the probability of any sort of criminal act is calculated as a mean of every single criminal act (including a very infrequent and unusual one such as a murder), whereas the probability of a common criminal act is not the probability of any kind of criminal act but the probability of the occurrence of a certain type of criminal act that can be described as a prototypical, usual, or common criminal act (e.g. robbery). The same observation applies to other readings as well. A criminal act that is similar to many other criminal acts is a certain type of criminal act, namely the one that shares properties with many other criminal acts. An unremarkable criminal act is also a certain type of criminal act. Only in the FCI case can *cualquiera* be modified by a subjunctive relative clause:

- (34) la existencia de un delito *cualquiera* que sea
 the existence of a crime CUALQUIERA that is.SBJV
 ‘the existence of any criminal act that there might be’ FCI only
 #‘the existence of a common criminal act that there might be’
 (@ 70)

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Assuming that there are only three kinds of crimes – A, B, and C – and assuming further that A and B are common, whereas C is very infrequent, *un delito cualquiera* under the reading ‘common’ denotes a more restricted set of crimes, namely the set {A, B}. FCI *cualquiera* does not add this information about the distribution, whereas *cualquiera* on the ‘common/frequent’ reading does. Set-theoretically, ‘common’ is thus a subset of a set denoted by FCI *cualquiera*. The extension of criminal acts is thus distinct under the FCI and ‘common’ readings, with the ‘common/frequent’ reading denoting a subset of the FCI denotation with respect to its extension.

- (35) The set denotation of *cualquiera* as EVAL is a subset of the FCI ‘any’.
- a. *cualquiera* (FCI) = {A,B,C}
 - b. *cualquiera* (EVAL ‘COM/EVAL1’) = {A,B}

What does *cualquiera* denote by its intension? I suggest analysing the postnominal *cualquiera* in a way similar to adjectives or nominal compounds that modify nouns and describe a property of a property. I call them predicate modifiers (see Section 3.3):

- (36) Juan es un hombre *cualquiera* / ordinario / simplón.
Juan is a man CUALQUIERA / ordinary / simple
‘Juan is an ordinary/simple man.’
(@ 3)

I will show later that this predicate modifier analysis of *cualquiera* can serve us as a basis for explaining some aspects of diatopic variation of Spanish *cualquiera*, in particular some striking differences between European and Argentinian Spanish (see Section 3.3 and Chapter 4 for details).

3.3 Postnominal *cualquiera* as a predicate (modifier)

I assume that postnominal *cualquiera* should be analysed as a postnominal modifier like the postnominal adjective *común*, *ordinario* ‘common, ordinary’:

- (37) Un hombre [_{Modifier} *cualquiera*] = Un hombre [_{Modifier} *común/ordinario*].

On this analysis, we should expect that postnominal *cualquiera*, can be coordinated, just like postnominal adjectives. And indeed, we find coordination of *cualquiera* with adjectives such as *mediocre* ‘mediocre’, *ordinario* ‘ordinary’, and *normal* ‘normal’.

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- (38) para un día *cualquiera* y normal en el Ciaam.
for a day CUALQUIERA and normal in the Ciaam
'for a common and normal day in Ciaam'
(@ 79)
- (39) y no es para llenar un currículum para una hoja de vida ordinaria y
and NEG is for filling a resume for a sheet of life ordinary and
cualquiera.
CUALQUIERA
'and it is not to fill in the CV with a page of an ordinary and normal life.'
(@ 80)
- (40) comprendí que no era más que un ser mediocre y *cualquiera*
understood that NEG was more than a being mediocre and CUALQUIERA
'I understood that I was just a mediocre and normal being'
(@ 81)

However, this kind of coordination is not very frequent in European Spanish (3 total occurrences out of 357 examples), which suggests that the use of postnominal *cualquiera* as an adjective-like category is not very common in this variety of Spanish. The occurrence of definite/quantified nouns with postnominal *cualquiera* as observed in Section 3.1 finds a straight-forward explanation in my analysis of *cualquiera*. It is because *cualquiera* acts in a way similar to adjectives like 'common, unremarkable, worthless', and adjectives can modify different types of noun phrases, including definite noun phrases, demonstrative and quantified noun phrases.

I will now present a detailed formal analysis of the postnominal *cualquiera* as a predicate (modifier).

3.3.1 Formalisation of *cualquiera* as a predicate (modifier)

The idea in a nutshell is that postnominal *cualquiera* as a predicate belongs to different types of predicates, which is why it triggers different interpretations such as 'common' (COM) and 'low value' or 'not special' (DER) observed in Section 3.2. In what follows, I will formalise the different meanings of the predicate *cualquiera*.

Postnominal *cualquiera* with the meaning *común* 'common' as 'usual' or 'frequent' should be analysed as a frequency adjective that modifies nouns with a reference to kinds, as in (41) (see Carlson 1977, Chierchia 1998, Gehrke & McNally 2015). They do not modify proper nouns, as shown in (42).

(41) Cats are common in Europe.

(42) *Angela Merkel is common in Germany.

The function of a postnominal frequency adjective such as English *common* as in *a common example/student* is to turn kinds into subkinds. It takes a kind as an argument and returns a subkind as an output.

At this point, I need to give a short introduction into kind nouns (see Gehrke & McNally 2015 for this introduction). Nouns denote properties of kinds or individuals, as shown in the representation in (43) (see Carlson 1977, Chierchia 1998, Gehrke & McNally 2015). I use a subscript α_k to indicate a variable that ranges over kinds (see Gehrke & McNally 2015). No subscript α indicates a variable that ranges over atomic individuals:

(43) $\llbracket [\text{NP } [\text{N } \text{car}]] \rrbracket : \lambda . x_k [\text{car}(x_k)]$

These nouns realise a syntactic Num(ber) projection, which semantically is interpreted as properties of token entities (see Gehrke & McNally 2015, and references therein). *R* is Carlson's (1977) realisation relation. The kind variable is bound off by the existential quantifier in the noun representation in (44). The numberless noun *car* denotes the set of all kinds of cars (station wagons, sedans, etc.), the (phonologically identical) singular NumP *car* denotes the set of atomic individuals that realise some kind of car, and the plural NumP *cars* denotes the set of token pluralities of some kind of car.

(44) $\llbracket [\text{NumP } [\text{NP } \text{car}]] \rrbracket : \lambda y \exists x_k [\text{car}(x_k) \ \& \ R(y, x_k)]$

I assume that postnominal *cualquiera* can denote a property of kinds, whereas *cualquiera* modifying a noun denotes a property of a property of kinds:

(45) a. $\llbracket [\text{postnominal } \text{cualquiera}] \rrbracket : \lambda P \lambda x_k [(\text{cualquiera } (P))(x_k)]$
 b. $\llbracket [\text{estudiante } \text{cualquiera}] \rrbracket : \lambda x_k [(\text{cualquiera } (\text{student}))(x_k)]$
 'kind of a student.'

The experiencer/evaluator function of *cualquiera*, which can be made salient by *para x* 'for x' and is represented as a subscript *E* on the predicate modifier *cualquiera*, which predicates over types of individuals according to some evaluator/experiencer *E* in a given context *C*:

(46) $\llbracket [\text{estudiante } \text{cualquiera}]^c \rrbracket : \lambda x_k [(\text{cualquiera}_E (\text{student}))(x_k)]$
 'kind of student for the experiencer/evaluator *E*'

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The following satisfaction condition in (47) expresses that the kind property represented by N *cualquiera* describing a set of elements denoted by the kind is very frequent. Thus, *a common student* denotes a kind of a student such that all students that represent this kind occur very frequently. What it means to be *un estudiante cualquiera* ‘a common student’ is established pragmatically. Thus, *un estudiante cualquiera* denotes a kind of a student that has usual or frequently occurring grades, say Section 2.7 (= average grade) in the German system. I adopt the condition of use of the English frequency adjective *common* from Gehrke & McNally (2015) and adapt it for *cualquiera* on the assumption that it has the same use as the Spanish frequency adjectives *común* ‘common’ or *corriente* ‘frequent’. “(Frequency) distribution in the representation is a function that yields the distribution of a set of entities at the given index, with high values” (see Gehrke & McNally 2015, my addition of the bracket).

- (47) Condition of use in a context for *cualquiera* with the meaning ‘common/frequent’:

$$\forall P, x_k, i[(\text{cualquiera}(P))(x_k) \text{ at } i \leftrightarrow [P(x_k) \ \& \ \text{distribution}(\{y : R(y, x_k) \text{ at } i\}) = \text{high}]]$$
- (48) a. $\llbracket \text{estudiante cualquiera} \rrbracket : \lambda x_k [(\text{cualquiera}(\text{student}))(x_k)]$
 b. $\forall x_k, i[(\text{cualquiera}(\text{student}))(x_k) \text{ at } i \leftrightarrow [\text{student}(x_k) \ \& \ \text{distribution}(\{y : R(y, x_k) \text{ at } i\}) = \text{high}]]$

The type N *cualquiera* implies a contrast to another type, which denotes a singleton and has a low (frequency) distribution. The satisfaction condition for the meaning N non-*cualquiera* or N *distinguido/especial* ‘special/particular N’ are the same as for N *cualquiera* besides the low frequency:

- (49) $\forall P, x_k, i[(\text{distinguido}(P))(x_k) \text{ at } i \leftrightarrow [P(x_k) \ \& \ \text{distribution}(\{y : R(y, x_k) \text{ at } i\}) = \text{low}]]$
- (50) a. $\llbracket \text{estudiante distinguido} \rrbracket : \lambda x_k [(\text{distinguished}(\text{student}))(x_k)]$
 b. $\forall x_k, i[(\text{distinguished}(\text{student}))(x_k) \text{ at } i \leftrightarrow [\text{student}(x_k) \ \& \ \text{distribution}(\{y : R(y, x_k) \text{ at } i\}) = \text{low}]]$

Under this approach, the contribution of *cualquiera* is to restrict the kind denoted by the noun N, that is, to turn a kind into a subkind. For instance, the noun *estudiante* denotes a kind of a student and the NP *estudiante cualquiera* denotes a common kind of student as opposed to a non-common one. On the extension, N denotes a set of students that belong to the kind ‘student’ and *estudiante*

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cualquiera denotes a restricted set of students, namely a set that is described as a ‘common student’, rather than as a ‘distinguished student’.

In case N denotes an event noun (indicated by the subscript α_e), *cualquiera* denotes a property of a property of an event (see Gehrke & McNally 2015 for predicate modifiers of event nouns):

- (51) a. $\llbracket \text{cualquiera} \rrbracket: \lambda P \lambda x_e [(\text{cualquiera}(P))(x_e)]$
 b. $\llbracket \text{evento/historia cualquiera} \rrbracket: \lambda x_e [(\text{cualquiera}(\text{event/story}))(x_e)]$
 ‘frequent event/story, a story/event that frequently occurs’
 Satisfaction condition:
 c. $\forall x_e, i [(\text{cualquiera}(\text{story}))(x_e) \text{ at } i \leftrightarrow [\text{story}(x_e) \ \& \ \text{distribution}(\{y : R(y, x_e) \text{ at } i\}) = \text{high}]]$

To sum up, *cualquiera* in DET [+/- def.] N *cualquiera*, which can be coordinated with adjectives, is not a determiner, but a nominal predicate that describes the distribution of properties among animate entities (non-temporal frequency) or the distribution of properties of events in time (temporal frequency with the meaning *common* and *frequent in time*).

On this analysis, N *cualquiera* in its COM meaning can be used with determiners and quantifiers as is expected from an adjectival use of *cualquiera* (see (9), (10), and (53)–(55) for data):

- (52) a. $\llbracket \text{ese/el estudiante cualquiera} \rrbracket: \iota x [(\text{cualquiera}(\text{student}))(x)]$
 b. $\llbracket \text{algún/otro/un estudiante cualquiera} \rrbracket: \text{some } x [(\text{cualquiera}(\text{student}))(x)]$
 c. $\llbracket \text{mucha gente cualquiera} \rrbracket: \text{many } x [(\text{cualquiera}(\text{people}))(x)]$

As *cualquiera* modifies an NP, which denotes a kind of entity or individual, the predicative N *cualquiera* can refer to some specific type/kind of individual, such as the common type. This is indeed what we find in the data: *el hombre cualquiera*, *la mujer cualquiera* ‘the common type of men or women’ as opposed to *el hombre distinguido/particular* ‘the distinguished type of men’ (see 3.3.1).

In the following example, repeated from (53), the definite noun refers to a certain kind of man, namely to the common man as a type. One could also describe this type as *el hombre de la calle* lit. ‘the man from the street’ or ‘common/normal man’:

- (53) El tipo de el C1, que antes fue el de el [sic] C2, es un timo. Es el prototipo de pícaro español. Un personaje que nuestros más célebres escritores de

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el [sic] Siglo de Oro describieron con crudo realismo – cómo olvidar el Lazarillo de Lázaro de Tormes –.

El hombre *cualquiera* del autobús no siente vergüenza alguna,
 the man CUALQUIERA of the bus NEG feels shame any
 aunque debería, por tratar de engañar a otras personas que están
 although should for trying to deceive to other people that are
 dispuestas a ayudar a aquellos extraños que lo pasan mal.
 willing to help to those strangers that it pass badly
 ‘[...] The common man from the bus does not feel any shame, although
 he should,...’

(@ 82)

The same analysis applies to *el día cualquiera*, namely the most prototypical day of the week:

- (54) diría que es el día más indeterminado, el día *cualquiera* de
 would say that is the day most indeterminate, the day CUALQUIERA of
 la semana, un día metido en la selva de los días
 the week, a day stuck in the jungle of the days
 ‘I would say that it is the most undistinguished day, just some day of the
 week, a day put in the jungle of the days.’

(@ 100)

The definite article can thus refer to a specific type of individual, namely a common one, and not some other type, a non-common one.

We also find demonstratives, which refer to a specific type of a man of speaker’s reference that has prototypical properties of a man. The example is embedded in a philosophical context, which contains a statement about a certain type of a man:

- (55) Las armas de este hombre *cualquiera*, de aspecto normal, se
 the weapons of this man CUALQUIERA, of appearance normal, REFL
 resumen en: prudencia
 summarised in: prudence.
 ‘The weapons of this common, normal-looking man are summarised in:
 caution.’

(@ 83)

Another consequence of the kind analysis of postnominal *cualquiera* is that it explains the lack of occurrence with degree modifiers or adverbs like *muy* ‘very’ as

in *un hombre* *(*muy*) *cualquiera* ‘a common man’. Degree adverbs like *muy* ‘very’ combine with gradable adjectives, not with kind predicates (Kennedy 1999).

To recap, postnominal *cualquiera* has been analysed as a frequency adjective ‘common’ in line with Gehrke & McNally (2015). Its lexical meaning is to describe kinds of individuals or entities that have a high frequency, that is, considering all individuals or entities denoted by N, we would observe very often a set of individuals or entities that are described by N *cualquiera*.

3.3.2 Formalisation of the derogatory meaning of N *cualquiera*

The idea is that the derogatory meaning of postnominal *cualquiera* has an additional satisfaction condition on top of describing individuals or types of individuals with a high-frequency distribution. Namely, the second satisfaction condition in (56) expresses that N *cualquiera* in its DER reading, such as *equipo cualquiera* ‘ordinary team’ denotes a type of individuals that is ranked lower on some qualitative scale according to the experiencer E expressed in *para* x ‘for x’ than a team that is not described as *cualquiera* or a distinguished team (e.g. *equipo con Messi* ‘team with Messi’):

- (56) $\llbracket \text{equipo cualquiera}_{\text{derogatory}} \rrbracket^c: \lambda x_k [(\text{cualquiera}_E(\text{team}))(x_k)]$
- a. $\forall x_k, i [(\text{cualquiera}(\text{team}))(x_k) \text{ at } i \leftrightarrow [\text{team}(x_k) \ \& \ \text{distribution}(\{y : R(y, x_k) \text{ at } i\}) = \text{high}]]$
 - b. $\forall y_k, \forall x_k, i [(\text{cualquiera}'(y_k) \ \& \ \text{distinguished}'(y_k) \text{ at } i \leftrightarrow [\text{team}(x_k)(y_k) \ \& \ (x_k) <_{\text{lower on some pragmatic scale according to E}} (y_k) \text{ at } i]]]$

On this analysis, UN N *cualquiera* cannot have an evaluative meaning in contexts that do not include any evaluation on a pragmatic scale according to an experiencer, such as mathematical contexts. This prediction is borne out empirically:

- (57) Es un cuerpo geométrico *cualquiera*. # Sin nivel.
 is a body geometric CUALQUIERA. # without level.
 ‘It’s an unremarkable geometric body. # Without class.’
 (@ 101)

I will show in Chapter 4 that in some languages or language varieties DER is only felicitous under the condition (56b); that is, the requirement that the set of individuals or entities must be described as usual/frequent without the condition b is not given. French *n’importe quoi* (see 58a) and Argentinian Spanish

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cualquiera (see 58b) are such a case. They necessarily have a derogatory meaning. According to the derogatory meaning of *n'importe quoi/cualquiera*, the evaluator considers that saying something undistinguished is worse than saying something distinguished (see Chapter 4 for a detailed analysis):

- (58) a. Marie a dit (du grand) *n'importe quoi*. (French)
Marie has said (of.the big) anything.
'Marie said a big bullshit.'
(@ 30)
- b. Me mandaste *cualquiera*. (ArgSp)
to.me sent CUALQUIERA
'You told me bullshit.'
(@ 102)

3.3.3 The FCI analysis of postnominal *cualquiera* in predicative contexts

The goal of this section is to adapt the FCI analysis of postnominal *cualquiera* in predicative contexts as in *es un día cualquiera* and to show the connection between FCI 'anyone' or 'anything' and the evaluative reading 'common' (COM).

Consider the following two examples:

- (59) Juan es un estudiante *cualquiera* de mi clase.
Juan is a student CUALQUIERA of my class.
'Juan is an ordinary student in my class.'
(@ 74)
- (60) Juan es un estudiante como *cualquiera* de mi clase.
Juan is a student like CUALQUIERA of my class.
'Juan is a student like everyone in my class.'
(@ 75)

One possible analysis of the two aforementioned examples is to interpret them as semantically equivalent. Comparative constructions are known to license FCIs (see Aloni 2021 and Section 2.2). In this view, *un hombre cualquiera* would be interpreted as 'a man like anyone [=any man]'. The function of postnominal *cualquiera* in (59) is thus to express a predicate that has a similar semantic interpretation as the pronoun *cualquiera* in an overt comparative construction as

in (60) (for comparative clause analyses of cases like in (60), see Bresnan 1973, Napoli & Nespor 1986, Sáez 1992, Kennedy 1999, among many others).

Different analyses have been suggested in the literature on comparative clauses (see Bresnan 1973, Napoli & Nespor 1986, Sáez 1992, Kennedy 1999, among many others). I will follow the coordination hypothesis of comparatives suggested by Napoli & Nespor (1986) and Sáez (1992), among others, who assume that comparatives represent coordinations (on either the phrasal or sentence level); that is, *como cualquiera de mi clase* is represented as a coordinated phrase or clause (Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009). I assume that the comparative phrase in (60) is clausal because it can be paraphrased as a clause. In order to represent the clausal analysis, I mark the predicate as deleted as shown in the English translation (see Bresnan 1973):

- (61) Juan es un estudiante como lo es *cualquiera* de mi clase.
 Juan is a student like it is CUALQUIERA of my class
 'Juan is a student like everyone in my class is-a student.'
 (@ 76)

Let me suggest a simple syntactic analysis of (61). I analyse *cualquiera de mi clase* as a subject of a copulative clause, which is inside the comparison clause introduced by *como*. Assuming that *como* conjoins two sentences (see Napoli & Nespor 1986, Sáez 1992), (60) can be interpreted as a coordination of two conjoined copulative sentences on the semantic level:

- (62) '[Juan is a student] and [[_{subj.} everyone in my class] is a student].'

The syntax of *cualquiera* that expresses a comparison is that of a comparison clause. This comparison clause is conjoined with the main clause (TP) due to the presence of the comparative particle *como*. In (63), the first clause has *Juan* as a subject and a predicative DP *un estudiante*. The comparative clause contains *cualquiera* as a subject and a clitic pronoun *lo* which is coreferent with the predicative complement inside the matrix clause:

- (63) [TP Juan es [DP un estudiante]_j] [& P como lo_j es cualquiera de mi clase]
 'Juan is a student, and everyone (else) is a student in my class.'

(63) expresses similarity with respect to some (prototypical) property P* of a student, such as with respect to Juan's qualifications or grades, which can be made salient in the context as will be demonstrated in more detail in (64). In a less strict interpretation, the sentence in (63) with the assumption that the comparative clause represents a conjoined sentence as suggested here could simply mean

that Juan and everyone in the speaker's class are students or have the property of being a student (as opposed to teachers, for example). But this interpretation is too weak and makes false predictions for the use of sentences such as (63) in the following context. Imagine a scenario where the speaker wants to say that Juan is a certain type of a student, namely an average student. In this scenario, the meaning 'Juan is a student and everyone else in my class is a student' is underinformative. The solution to this problem is pragmatics. What it means to be a student and to be similar to other students is established pragmatically by some property P^* ; that is, the comparison of students is a comparison with respect to some (prototypical) property P^* that holds for students. Thus, the sentence in (63) states that Juan and other students in the class of speaker's reference have the same prototypical property P^* as students, which can be usual grades, for instance. From this analysis, we can already pragmatically infer that Juan is an average or unremarkable student. If Juan were a brilliant student, he probably would not be like every other student in the speaker's class, because it is very unlikely that the whole class consists of brilliant students.

I will now formalise the semantic analysis of postnominal *cualquiera* as the pronoun *cualquiera* in a comparative clause analysis.

Given the syntax in (63), the semantic representation entails a universal quantifier *cualquiera* inside the comparative clause & P. In this case, *cualquiera* is interpreted as a universal quantifier with the meaning 'everyone', ranging over individuals in the speaker's class, and these individuals represent a comparison class of students to whom the subject of the main clause (here: Juan) is compared:

(64) *cualquiera* in a comparison clause

- a. Juan es un estudiante [_{ModifP} *cualquiera*]. Tiene calificaciones normales.
'Juan is a student like any other. He has normal grades.'
- b. Semantic interpretation: Juan has property $P^* \wedge \forall x [x \in \text{my class} \rightarrow x \text{ has property } P^*]$
- c. Prose of b: Juan is a student with property P^* and for each student x in my class, x has *it* [= P^*].⁵

⁵Another way to interpret the conjoined clause with *cualquiera* as a subject is to assume that it implies a covert modal or attitude verb that links the expression of similarity to the speaker's evaluation. In this case, we would have universal quantification over a modal verb that describes speaker's attitude (see Section 2.2.2). *Juan es un hombre cualquiera* 'Juan is a man CUALQUIERA' would be interpreted similar to *Juan es un hombre cualquiera para mí* 'According to me, Juan is a man CUALQUIERA.'

- i. It seems to me that Juan is a man with P^* and for each student, he/she has P^* too.

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The positive outcome of a comparison clause analysis is that it explains the licensing of postnominal *cualquiera* in affirmative predicative contexts. Recall from the puzzle described in Section 2.3 that affirmative predicative and episodic contexts were considered problematic for FCIs such as *cualquiera*. However, in my analysis, the licensing of postnominal *cualquiera* under indicative predicative verbs is explained by its predicate that refers to similarity with all other students from my class. Recall that FCIs are generally licensed in universal contexts in Spanish and other languages (see Section 2.1 and Section 2.2).

Moreover, the suggested analysis explains why the ‘common’ reading cannot be cancelled (see Section 3.2.3). The ‘common’ reading is the result of analysing postnominal *cualquiera* as a modifier that contains a universal quantifier that licenses *cualquiera* in predicative contexts.

The suggested analysis also explains why N *cualquiera* is not gradable in European Spanish, as shown in (65). Postnominal *cualquiera* is a predicate with quantificational force of the same type as ‘every(one), any(one)’ and not a gradable adjective like ‘ordinary’, which is why it cannot be modified by degree adverbs like *muy* ‘very’ (see Chapter 2):

- (65) Es un estudiante (*muy) *cualquiera*.
is a student (very) CUALQUIERA
‘He is a student (*very) like anyone else.’
(@ 77)

Another prediction of the comparative clause analysis is that it should be possible to modify postnominal *cualquiera* by adverbs like *casi* ‘almost’ that restrict the domain of quantification of *cualquiera de mi clase* to ‘almost everyone in my class’ (see Section 2.1 for such adverbial modification of *cualquiera*). However, the judgements from native speakers of European Spanish and the absence of *un N casi cualquiera* in the corpus data in European Spanish (despite some occurrences in Latin American Spanish), seem to suggest that the postnominal *cualquiera* is not modifiable by the modifier *casi* in European Spanish. However, this result needs to be tested in a large experimental study in future research.

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- (66) Fue un día *(casi) *cualquiera*.
 was a day (almost) CUALQUIERA
 #‘It was a day like almost any other day.’^{6,7}

The lack of frequent modification by *casi* in (66) suggests that the postnominal modifier *cualquiera* is not syntactically a free choice pronoun like the pronoun *cualquiera*, which is modifiable by *casi* very frequently. Consequently, the postnominal *cualquiera* needs to be analysed as a predicate modifier that is semantically related to the pronoun *cualquiera* in the description of the property as ‘like anyone else’.

The following example shows that once the postnominal *cualquiera* cooccurs with an overt comparative clause like *como cualquier mañana* ‘like any other morning’, the interpretation of postnominal *cualquiera* changes into the meaning ‘ordinary’ or ‘just normal’, which corresponds to the derogatory reading DER. This suggests that the expression of similarity between the actual referent and a comparison class is not part of the lexical semantic meaning as suggested in the discussion of (32), because otherwise the following sentence would express the same information twice and it would be redundant.

- (67) Era una mañana *cualquiera*, como *cualquier* mañana.
 was a morning CUALQUIERA like CUALQUIER morning
 ‘It was an ordinary morning, like any other morning.’⁸

⁶There are other cases of adverbial modification of the free choice item *cualquiera*, which shows that *cualquiera* is a quantifier with the meaning ‘any’. However, *cualquiera* appears in these examples prenominal as a determiner and not as a postnominal modifier (see Section 4 for further examples of the determiner *cualquiera* in predicative position):

- a. No tiene nada de particular; pero por eso mismo parece Tamayo, porque no tiene
 NEG has nothing of particular; but for that same seems Tamayo, because NEG has
 nada de particular. *Parece cualquier cosa menos un gran poeta*.
 nothing of particular seems CUALQUIER thing except a great poet
 ‘He does not have any particular properties. But for the same reason he resembles Tamayo,
 because he does not have any particular property. He resembles *anything but a great poet*.’
 (Solos de Clarín, Leopoldo Alas)

⁷According to two native speakers of European Spanish, acceptable according to a Colombian Instagram user and a Mexican Spanish writer Edmée Pardo (<https://www.instagram.com/piaguzmanv/> and <https://edmeepardo.com/bibliomemoria-fichas/rfn6txw4j6pg3l2-6kdbj-2e74j-d9r63-zmw5n-az8dg-4e5j4-bamwc-d3fda-c6ygp-efe6w-nr8wf-tnmwk-mwjcd-4wp56>) and also acceptable for Michael Robinson, see *Prólogo* in Pérez Gellida, *Memento mori*.

⁸I thank Josep Quer for this data point.

The issue of what kind of status the similarity has (lexical semantic or pragmatic implicature) (Aloni 2021, Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018) needs to be analysed in future research.

3.4 Summary and discussion of the predicate modifier analysis

In Section 3.3, I suggested a predicate modifier analysis of postnominal *cualquiera* with the meaning COM that can explain a certain type of data such as [Determiner/Quantifier N *cualquiera*] and coordination with adjectives. There are several issues that need to be addressed here.

First, recall from Section 2.1.4 that there is the standard assumption in the literature that postnominal *cualquiera* occurs only with indefinite nouns and is hence accompanied by the indefinite article, but not by strong determiners (see, in particular, Lapesa 1964, Rivero 2011). Linguists have suggested different explanations for this restriction. According to one explanation, postnominal *cualquiera* is itself a strong (quantificational) determiner, and this is why it is incompatible with other strong determiners (Lapesa 1964). Another semantic explanation is that N *cualquiera* has an anti-singleton restriction (see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010), making it incompatible with definite determiners or demonstratives, as these elements presuppose a uniquely identified referent (singleton restriction) and thus do not co-occur with *cualquiera* as an FCI. However, contrary to these predictions, I was able to find examples in which postnominal *cualquiera* is preceded by definite determiners, and which my predicate modifier analysis is able to explain.

Second, there are indeed a lot more data with UN N *cualquiera* than with D_{def} N *cualquiera* in the corpus (6,938 indefinite occurrences vs. 171 definite occ.). A simple explanation for this preference under copular verbs is that N *cualquiera* is used predicatively. It is a common observation in the literature that predicative NPs are expressed by NPs that are indefinite rather than definite (see van Geenhoven & McNally 2005, among others):

- (68) Era un / *el día normal (para mí).
 was a / the day normal (for me)
 ‘It was a/*the usual day (for me).’
 (@ 103)

Third, my analysis predicts that it should be possible to find cross-linguistic evidence for quantifiers reanalysed as nominal predicates. We actually find few

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cases in Italian and German, where certain quantifiers can be used as nominal predicates in predicative position similar to *un/una cualquiera* in Spanish (see Section 2.1). The only difference to UN N *cualquiera* is that the quantifiers in [indefinite + quantifier], such as in *un cualquiera* in Spanish, *un niente* in Italian, and *ein Jedermann* in German, have the syntactic status of a noun rather than of a predicate modifier. However, the semantic analysis is the same; that is, the quantifier is interpreted not as a quantifier but as a noun with a property interpretation that describes certain kinds of people. *Ein Jedermann* is a kind of man, as is *un niente* and *un cualquiera*.

- (69) Gianni è un niente. (Italian)
 Gianni is a nothing
 ‘Gianni is a nobody.’
 (@ 104)

- (70) Ein Jedermann. (Title of a book by an Austrian author)
 a everyone
 ‘Everyman.’

Fourth, my analysis allows us to better approach some aspects of the diatopic variation of *cualquiera* in Spanish. The element *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish can appear as a (degree) predicate over nouns that refer to atomic individuals such as *Juan* or that refer, for instance, to a certain movie (see Section 2.4):

- (71) La peli /Juan es (muy) *cualquiera*. (ArgSp/*EurSp)
 the movie /Juan is (very) CUALQUIERA
 ‘This movie/Juan is (very) ordinary/bad.’
 (@ 5 / @ 105)

The difference between Argentinian Spanish and its European counterpart is that *cualquiera* is used as a predicate modifier in European Spanish, but not as a predicate (i.e. a predicative adjective). I will explain this difference by the assumption that the analysis of *cualquiera* as an adjective in Argentinian Spanish is at a more advanced stage than in European Spanish (for details, see Chapter 4). Syntactically, it can form a regular copula structure, which can be sketched as follows:

- (72) [_{TP} Juan_j T° es [_{PrP} t_j [_{PrP} Pr° cualquiera]]].
 ‘Juan is ordinary/unremarkable.’

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I assume that in European Spanish *cualquiera* is not used as a predicate that describes properties of individuals. Let me briefly outline the syntax of *cualquiera* in its COM reading in European Spanish. In European Spanish, postnominal *cualquiera* is a nominal modifier similar to adjectives like ‘common/unremarkable’. I use the labels Modif(ier) for all kinds of modifiers (adjectives, relative clauses, etc.). This type of postnominal *cualquiera* modifies nouns that denote kinds and, as such, N *cualquiera* can be represented as a KindP (see Zamparelli 2000 for KindPs):

- (73) [DP un [KindP Kind° hombre [ModifP *cualquiera/cumún/ordinario*]]]
 ‘a common/ordinary man’

The whole DP can appear as a predicative complement of the copula verb *be* in European Spanish, but it cannot appear as a predicative complement by itself as in Argentinian Spanish as will be shown in Section 4):

- (74) [TP Juan_j [T° [T° es [PrP t_j [PrP° Pr° [DP un [KindP hombre [ModifP *cualquiera/cumún/ordinario*]]]]]]]]]
 ‘Juan is an ordinary man.’

It can also appear as a nominal modifier of an NP that is the subject of a clause:

- (75) [DP El [KindP hombre [ModifP *cualquiera*]]] del autobús no siente vergüenza alguna.
 ‘The common man from the bus does not feel any shame.’

As we will see in Chapter 4, the Argentinian Spanish *cualquiera* is not restricted to the use of a nominal modifier as in European Spanish.

3.5 Chapter summary and outlook for subsequent chapters

I started with different observations about UN N *cualquiera* in the corpus (see Section 3.1–3.4) and showed that in affirmative predicative contexts under indicative verbal mood, it has usually an evaluative meaning that manifests itself in various readings, namely ‘similar to anyone/anything else’ or ‘common’ (COM), and ‘of low value’ (DER) (Section 3.2).

I showed in Section 3.3 that ‘similar to anyone/anything else’ or ‘common’ (COM) is a special case of interpreting *cualquiera* as a predicate with quantificational force similar to the quantifier pronoun *cualquiera* that occurs in a comparison clause and that the DER reading can be derived pragmatically from the neutral reading of ‘common’ or ‘similar to anyone/anything else’.

In the following chapters, I will examine the diatopic and diachronic variation of *cualquiera* in more detail. Chapter 4 will deal with diatopic variation. Chapters 5 will deal with diachronic variation.

The question that will guide my analysis in subsequent sections is why a generalised quantifier with the free choice meaning ‘any’ changes into a predicate modifier as demonstrated in Section 3 for European Spanish or a gradable predicate as demonstrated for Argentinian Spanish. My short answer to this question is that it is the predicative context, the negation, and the adjectival appositives that trigger the reanalysis of postnominal *cualquiera* as an FCI into a predicate modifier or predicate of an adjective type. Adjectival appositives can elicit different readings of FCIs in predicative position such as ‘similar to everybody else’, ‘common’, and ‘of low value’, and by doing this, they can turn generalised quantifiers of type $\langle\langle e, t \rangle, t \rangle$ into predicate modifiers of type $\langle\langle et \rangle, \langle e, t \rangle \rangle$ and can thus turn the interpretation of ‘any’ into the adjectival interpretation of ‘any’ or ‘common/frequent/normal’. This is how postnominal *cualquiera* gets its adjectival or kind flavour. The adjectival interpretation can be contextually elicited by appositives that specify the property as ‘average/frequent’. The derogatory flavour of ‘nothing special’ is just a negative interpretation of ‘any’ or of ‘average’.

It is a common observation in the literature that semantic change is often triggered by pragmatic enrichment (see Section 2.7 and Traugott & Dasher 2002, Eckardt 2006, among others). In the case of *cualquiera*, the most crucial trigger for semantic change is syntax, in particular the predicative context and negation, which triggers a contrastive reading between the property described by N *cualquiera* and another contrasting property like *Nextraordinario*. The function of adjectival appositives that describe the property of postnominal *cualquiera* as ‘common, frequent, low value’ elicits the adjectival interpretation. The diachronic path of *cualquiera* can be sketched as follows:

(76) Diachronic development of *cualquiera*

1. Use of *cualquiera* as FCI in modal constructions.
2. Use of *cualquiera* in predicative position (under negation) with the reading ‘common’ or the derogatory reading.
3. Reanalysis of FCI *cualquiera* as a property of kind nouns in predicative contexts.
4. Reanalysis of *cualquiera* as a gradable property of proper nouns.

I argued that a small set of data of postnominal *cualquiera* in European Spanish shows that it has reached step 3. In Chapter 4, I will show that Argentinian Spanish has reached step 4. In Chapter 5, I will look at the diachronic conditions

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that have enabled step 3 in European Spanish, namely the change of *cualquiera* from a relative clause into a compound which at some point was possible not only under modal verbs, but also under affirmative predicative verbs.

In the following chapters, I will study the diatopic and diachronic variation in more detail. According to my analysis, *cualquiera* as FCI should be diachronically prior to readings in affirmative predicative sentences. The evaluative readings in some varieties of Spanish or other Romance or Non-Romance languages are expected to occur later than the reading ‘any’ (FCI). Moreover, I will also look into the development of EVAL ‘nonsense’ in Argentinian Spanish *cualquiera* in Chapter 4.

4 Postnominal and pronominal *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish

This chapter analyses *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish and accounts for the differences from its counterpart in European Spanish.¹ I will suggest that *cualquiera* embedded under certain transitive verbs such as ArgSp *mandar/decir cualquiera* ‘talk nonsense’ has its origin in *mandar/decir cualquier cosa* ‘say anything possible’ or ‘say something random’. *Cualquiera* under predicative verbs such as *parecer* will be analysed as a degree adjective that has its origin in the FCI *cualquiera* with the interpretation ‘any’.

The basic data in this section is extracted from the *Corpus del Español web dialects* (CdE_web dialects, already introduced in Section 1.5 and used in Chapter 3). The present study thus mainly focuses on diastatic variation and very little on social or diaphasic variation.² The quantitative analysis of the corpus results is represented as the ratio (in percentage) of various linguistic contexts and meanings of *cualquiera*. The focus of my analysis is the distribution of EVAL and FCI of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish in the corpus data.

¹Aspects of this topic were presented in my talk “*Cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish”, at II Encuentro de Dialectos del Español (Ciudad Real, Universidad de Castilla-La Mancha, 17–18 May 2018). I’m very thankful to the audience of this workshop, especially to Carlos Muñoz.

²I asked about the use of *cualquiera* in predicative position and under transitive verbs with the possibility of degree modification (e.g. *es muy/re cualquiera*) in the online forum on Facebook *Lingüística Argentina*, see Chapter 1. 18 native speakers responded to my questions. The informal questions asked are as follows: “How do you find the following sentences? Do they have the interpretation as represented in the brackets?” The following examples were provided: i) *Me parece cualquier cosa.* (para decir: me parece mal.) ‘I think *cualquier cosa* (to say: I think it’s wrong.)’ ii) *Hizo/Dijo cualquier cosa.* (para decir: hizo/dijo algo malo) ‘He did/said *cualquier cosa* (to say: he did/said something bad).’ iii) *La peli es cualquier cosa.* (para decir: la peli es mala). ‘The movie is *cualquier cosa* (to say: the movie is bad).’ iv) *Es tan/medio cualquier cosa.* (para decir: Es tan/medio malo). It’s so/half anything (to say: It’s so/somewhat bad). v) *Juan es más cualquiera que Marc.* (para decir: Juan es peor que Marc.). ‘Juan is more *cualquiera* than Marc (to say: Juan is worse than Marc).’ vi) *Esta peli es más cualquiera que la otra.* (para decir: esta peli es peor que la otra.). ‘This movie is more *cualquiera* than the other one (to say: this movie is worse than the other one).’ Most speakers accepted *cualquiera* in predicative position and under transitive verbs. However, not all degree adverbs can modify *cualquiera*, as noted by native speakers. Most speakers accept *re cualquiera*, in contrast to *muy cualquiera*. A systematic experimental study of speaker judgments will be performed in the future.

This section has the following structure. I will briefly recall the current state of research on *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish from Chapter 2 in Section 4.1. In Section 4.2 I will show that the description in the literature is incomplete and very informal and will object to the suggestion that the source for the special use of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish should be derived from an analogy with the Italianism *cualunque* ‘whichever’ (Rizzo Salierno 2013). I will present new data on *cualquiera* in Section 4.3 that will serve my synchronic analysis in Section 4.4. And in Section 4.5, I will suggest that *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish has lexicalised the speaker’s evaluation of the modal component denoted by *cualquiera* as an FCI, which has triggered a reanalysis into an evaluative adjective or an evaluative noun. I will show further evidence for the analysis in Section 4.6.

4.1 Current state of research on *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish

The item *cualquiera* can have a pejorative or derogatory use (DER, a subtype of the evaluative use or function, EVAL) in Argentinian Spanish with copular predicates such as *parecer* ‘to look like’ and *ser* ‘to be’, similar to European Spanish, but, in addition, can be used predicatively and can have degree modification by degree adverbs (Rizzo Salierno 2013: example (2), Section 3.1, Chapter 2). The following examples show degree modification of *cualquiera* by the degree adverb *completamente* ‘totally/completely’, and they are interpreted as ‘(very) bad’ or as ‘(complete) nonsense’. As I will argue in this chapter, the meaning ‘nonsense’ is a pejorative interpretation of ‘anything’ and thus another instance of DER:

- (1) Es totalmente *cualquiera* eso de haber puesto a Roger con la voz
is totally CUALQUIERA that of having put to Roger with the voice
de Syd.
of Syd
‘Putting Roger with Syd’s voice is total(ly) bullshit/nonsense/out of
place/bad.’
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 28)
- (2) Eso de la tanga es completamente *cualquiera*.
that of the thong is completely CUALQUIERA
‘That thong thing is complete(ly) bullshit/nonsense/out of place/bad.’
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 28)

According to Rizzo Salierno (2013), the potential linguistic precedent of *cualquiera* is possibly related to the Italianism *cualunque*, which seems to have its origin in Lunfardo slang. *Cualunque* in Argentinian Spanish (unlike Italian *qualunque*, Kellert 2021) can also be used predicatively or attributively in a postnominal position and allows degree modification with *muy* ‘very’ and other degree adverbs such as *completamente*, as happens with ArgSp *cualquiera* (Kellert & Francia 2024 for a historical overview and analysis of *cualunque*).

- (3) Washizu se asustó porque sus zapatos estaban sucios y su ropa
Washizu him scared because his shoes were dirty and his clothing
era muy *cualunque*.
was very CUALUNQUE
‘Washizu was scared because his shoes were dirty and his clothes were
very bad/out of place.’
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 29)
- (4) Es una flaca *cualunque* que se cree que es Marilyn Monroe.
is a woman CUALUNQUE that her believes that is Marilyn Monroe
‘She’s an ordinary woman who thinks she’s Marilyn Monroe.’
(Rizzo Salierno 2013: 29)

Rizzo Salierno does not discuss cases of *cualquiera* under transitive verbs, and he does not analyse the meaning ‘nonsense’, probably because he believes that *cualquiera* has its origin in *cualunque* and because he observed *cualunque* only in predicative contexts. As Kellert & Francia (in press) show *cualunque* is indeed used mostly in predicative contexts or as a nominal modifier. They conclude that the transitive use of *cualquiera* with the meaning ‘nonsense’ cannot have its origin in *cualunque*. The transitive use of *cualquiera* had been previously noted in the literature (see Section 2.1.5). Conde (2011a) assumes that the transitive use of *cualquiera* as ‘nonsense’ is specific to Lunfardo. However, as of yet this use has not been investigated in depth.

4.2 Open questions and main hypothesis

The main question of this section is to determine the origin of the semantic and syntactic change of *cualquiera* and to account for different meanings of *cualquiera* as ‘ordinary’ and ‘nonsense’ and for their different syntactic functions as arguments of transitive verbs and as predicative elements.

Rizzo Salierno suggests that some analogy with *cualunque* might be the cause of change. However, despite some similarities between *cualunque* and *cualquiera* in predicative contexts, they have a different distribution under transitive verbs (Kellert & Francia 2024). Whereas *cualquiera* occurs as a complement of verbs of saying, *cualunque* does not:

- (5) Me contestó / dijo *cualquiera* / **cualunque*.
 me answered / said CUALQUIERA / CUALUNQUE
 ‘(S)he answered me with some bullshit/nonsense.’
 (Rizzo Salierno 2013: 26)

Even if Rizzo Salierno was right about the assumption that *cualquiera* has acquired its evaluative meaning from *cualunque*, this assumption does not explain the origin of the evaluative meaning, which is absent from the Italian source item *qualunque*. It just shifts the issue of how an indefinite can develop this type of evaluative meaning to *cualunque*, but does not resolve it. Rizzo Salierno does not try to explain the origin of the evaluative use of ArgSp *cualquiera* either historically or in the semantic structure of this item, and thus does not try to relate the evaluative function of *cualquiera/cualunque* to the FCI meaning of these items.

I will fill this gap. Moreover, I will test Rizzo Salierno’s description of *cualquiera* as a gradable adjective and investigate whether it behaves like a regular gradable adjective that can be modified by different degree modifiers (also including, e.g., items meaning ‘a bit’) and be used in comparative constructions (e.g. *más cualquiera que* ‘worse than’). I will test this hypothesis with other degree modifiers and comparative constructions that are usually possible with degree adjectives.

As stated previously, my main hypothesis about the diachronic origin of the different readings of *cualquiera* is that both the evaluative meaning ‘ordinary, bad’ (EVAL1) and the meaning ‘nonsense’ (EVAL2 or DER) have their origin in the free choice indefinite meaning ‘any’. I already showed in Chapter 3 how this hypothesis applies to EVAL1, and I now show this for the special EVAL2 meaning found in Argentinian Spanish.

- (6) Free Choice *cualquiera* ‘any’ > Adj *cualquiera* ‘unremarkable/bad’
 (EVAL1) or Noun *cualquiera* ‘nonsense’ (EVAL2)

In order to test this hypothesis for EVAL2, I will look at the distribution of *cualquiera* in synchrony and diachrony in Argentinian Spanish in this section and offer an analysis that explains the change in (44).

4.3 New data on *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish

This section presents new data on *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, which will then be analysed in Section 4.4.

4.3.1 General distribution of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish

The postverbal pronoun *cualquiera* occurs 1.155 times in the corpus (per mil = 9.47). The special meaning/use of the pronoun *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish ‘bullshit, nonsense’ occurs in object position as a bare pronoun under predicative verbs *ser* (177 occurrences)/*parecer* (37 occurrences) and transitive verbs of *hacer* (2 occurrences), *entender* (6 occurrences), *hablar* (4 occurrences), *mandar* (23 occurrences), *decir* (9 occurrences) out of 1.155 occurrences in total. The remainder of the occurrences has the FCI interpretation as in *eliminar cualquiera de las opciones* ‘to eliminate any of the options’ (867 occurrences=75 percent out of 1.155 in total) (Table 4.1). The subject function of the pronoun *cualquiera* and the object function with a prepositional phrase inside the construction [*cualquiera de N*] (e.g. *eliminar cualquiera de las opciones* ‘to eliminate any of the options’) always has the interpretation of FCI.

Table 4.1: Distribution of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish

Linguistic context	EVAL	FCI ‘any’
subject	–	+
<i>cualquiera de N</i>	–	+
bare object pronoun	+ (predicative verbs and verbs of saying in present and past tense)	+ (non-indicative verb mood)
frequency	25 percent (288 occ. out of 1.155)	75 percent (867 occ. out of 1.155)

Here are some examples of the pronoun *cualquiera* in the object position under indicative verbal mood of predicative verbs with the senses EVAL1 ‘bad’ and EVAL2 ‘bullshit, nonsense’.

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- (7) En resumen, la película es *cualquiera*, si no fuera almodovar el
in summary, the movie is CUALQUIERA, if NEG were Almodóvar the
que la dirige, diríamos que es una peli de cine clase b malísima.
that it directs, would.say that is a movie of cinema class b very.bad
'In short, the movie is bad, if it were not Almodóvar who directed it, we
would say that it's a really bad B movie.'
(@ 276)
- (8) es raro, es decir, ellos te piden que seas previsor pero después
is strange is to.say they you ask that be cautious but afterwards
te piden hotel y fecha de viaje, es medio *cualquiera* eso.
you ask hotel and date of trip is kind.of CUALQUIERA that
'It's strange, that is, they ask you to be cautious but then they ask you to
provide the hotel name and the date, that doesn't make much sense.'
(@277)
- (9) pero se nota que entendí *cualquiera* jajaja
but REFL noticeable that understand CUALQUIERA jajaja
'but it's obvious that I understood nonsense hahaha.'
(@ 282)
- (10) Le mandé *cualquiera* jajajaja.
to.them sent CUALQUIERA jajajaja
'I told her nonsense hahaha.'
(@ 281)
- (11) Quiero que seas feliz. Estas haciendo *cualquiera*.
want.1SG that be.2SG happy be.SG doing CUALQUIERA
'I want you to be happy. You are doing nonsense.'
(@ 275)

4.3.2 Distribution of special uses of *cualquiera* across Latin American varieties

In this subsection we will see that predicative *cualquiera* and *cualquiera* under transitive verbs such as *mandar* 'say' are more frequent in Argentinian Spanish than in other varieties of Spanish.

The predicative *cualquiera* as in *es cualquiera* (Table 4.2) and *parece cualquiera* (Table 4.3) is most frequent in Argentinian Spanish in contrast to other varieties

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(decimal numbers represent relative frequency in per million, i.e. how often a word or a word phrase occurs per one million words). The number 0.32 represents the mean of how many times *es cualquiera* appears in all varieties per million words. The crucial observation is that the number of times *es cualquiera* appears in Argentinian Spanish is three times higher than the mean. The number 1.05 represents the average number of instances of *es cualquiera* per million in the Argentinian subcorpus, i.e. a set of one million words in the Argentinian subcorpus contains an average of 1.05 instances of *es cualquiera*.

Table 4.2: Distribution of *es cualquiera* in CdE_web dialects (highlighting my own).

Country	Absolute	Per million	Country	Absolute	Per million
Argentina	178	1.05	Honduras	0.43	15
Bolivia	8	0.20	Mexico	45	0.18
Chile	7	0.11	Nicaragua	8	0.25
Colombia	33	0.20	Panama	13	0.58
Costa Rica	23	0.78	Peru	26	0.24
Cuba	24	0.38	Puerto Rico	13	0.40
Dom. Rep	9	0.27	Paraguay	8	0.27
Ecuador	11	0.21	El Salvador	11	0.30
Spain	77	0.18	USA	59	0.36
Guatemala	13	0.24	Uruguay	28	0.72
			Venezuela	24	0.24
total				633	0.32

As we can see, the construction does not seem to be excluded in European Spanish, but seems to be extremely marginal there, as it also is in Chile, Bolivia, Colombia, and Mexico (with values ≤ 0.2 per million). It is more frequent in most other Latin American countries, but the value rises to more than 0.5 per million only in a small part of Central America (Panama, 0.58, and Costa Rica, 0.78) and in South America (in Uruguay, 0.72), whereas in Argentina it rises to 1.05 per million.

The same observation holds for *parece cualquiera*, which is even more marginal than *es cualquiera*, whose frequency is shown in Table 4.4. In most Latin American varieties in CdE, *parece cualquiera* is not used at all. It is only used in Argentina, Spain, Mexico, and Peru. In Argentina, it is used with a strikingly higher

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frequency than in other countries (12 times higher than the average in the three other countries).

Table 4.3: Distribution of *parece cualquiera* in CdE_web dialects (highlighting my own)

Country	Absolute	Per million	Country	Absolute	Per million
Argentina	25	0.15	Honduras	0	0
Bolivia	0	0	Mexico	1	0.01
Chile	0	0	Nicaragua	0	0
Colombia	0	0	Panama	0	0
Costa Rica	0	0	Peru	1	0.01
Cuba	0	0	Puerto Rico	0	0
Dom. Rep	0	0	Paraguay	0	0
Ecuador	0	0	El Salvador	0	0
*Spain	3	0.01	USA	0	0
Guatemala	0	0	Uruguay	0	0
	0	0	Venezuela	0	0
total				30	0.02

The use of *cualquiera* under the verb *mandar* ‘say’ is also more frequent in Argentinian Spanish than in the other varieties as shown by the difference in percentages (75% in Argentinian Spanish vs 25% in all the other varieties).

Of the 44 occurrences of this construction in the corpus, 33 (= 75%) are found for Argentina, as the Table 4.4 shows. Moreover, the most frequent verb forms are the indicative present and past tense forms, which refer to some past or present speech events, i.e. someone said or is presently saying something *wrong/nonsense* (Table 4.4).

Degree modification as in *re/tan/muy/medio/totalmente/demasiado cualquiera* (‘very/a bit/fully/too non-sensical’) shows higher relative frequency in Argentina than in other countries.

The difference in frequencies across Latin American varieties suggests that *cualquiera* has undergone a change in Argentinian Spanish. Despite the clear difference in frequencies of the special uses between Argentinian and other Latin American varieties, the frequency of the special uses is very low in Argentinian Spanish compared to other phrases (e.g. *decir algo* ‘say something’, with 408 occurrences, or *es común* ‘it is common’, with 1,447 occurrences). One reasonable explanation of the low frequency of these uses is that they represent informal spoken speech (see also Rizzo Salierno 2013, Conde 2011a, among others).

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Table 4.4: Distribution of lemma *mandar cualquiera* in CdE_web dialects

Context	All Argentina	Other countries	Indicative Present Imperfect Perfect	Subjunctive/ Imperative	Gerund Infinitive
<i>mandan cq.</i>	8	6	2	+	-
<i>mandaste cq.</i>	5	3	2	+	-
<i>mandaron cq.</i>	5	5	0	+	-
<i>mandé cq.</i>	4	4	0	+	-
<i>mandar cq.</i>	3	2	1	-	+
<i>mandando cq.</i>	3	2	1	-	+
<i>mando cq.</i>	3	3	0	+	-
<i>manda cq.</i>	3	2	1	+	-
<i>mande cq.</i>	3	1	2	-	+
<i>mandó cq.</i>	2	2	0	+	-
<i>mandaba cq.</i>	2	1	1	+	-
<i>mandaban cq.</i>	2	1	1	+	-
<i>mandamos cq.</i>	1	1	1	+	-
total	100% (44)	75% (33)	25% (11)		

The other Latin Spanish varieties will not be considered here, nor the question whether Argentinian Spanish has influenced the use of *cualquiera* in other varieties.

4.3.3 Predicative *cualquiera*

In this section, I will look into the predicative Argentinian Spanish *cualquiera* in detail and see whether it behaves as a gradable adjective in any respect and whether it allows any kind of syntactic combination like usual gradable adjectives do (e.g. different combinations with adverbs, comparatives, etc.).

As already observed in Table 2.6 and in Section 4.1, Argentinian Spanish predicative *cualquiera* can be modified by degree adverbs that denote high degrees (i.e. adverbs meaning ‘very’ and the like). The most frequent modifying item is *re*³ (25 occurrences in the corpus). The most important observation is that the

³The detailed linguistic status of *re*, as well as its origin, needs to be addressed in future research. In this book, I assume in line with Rizzo Salierno (2013) and Kanwit & Terán (2020) that it is a

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Table 4.5: Distribution of degree modification of *cualquiera*

Country	Abs. frequency	Per million
Argentina	24	0.13
Bolivia	2	0.05
Chile	2	0.03
Colombia	3	0.02
Costa Rica	0	0.00
Cuba	0	0.00
Dominican Republic	0	0.00
Ecuador	2	0.04
Spain	8	0.02
Guatemala	3	0.05
Honduras	0	0.00
Mexico	7	0.03
Nicaragua	0	0.00
Panama	0	0.00
Peru	1	0.01
Puerto Rico	1	0.03
Paraguay	1	0.03
El Salvador	1	0.03
United States	4	0.02
Uruguay	2	0.05
Venezuela	0	0.00
total	61	0.03

predicative *cualquiera* has the meaning ‘nonsense’ if the subject of the predicative complement is a proposition or an event:

- (12) *ademas me parece re cualquiera eso de q se encajo una*
 moreover to.me seems very CUALQUIERA that of that (s)he received a

degree adverb similar to *muy* ‘very’ that denotes a high degree. The form *re* has been described as a derivative prefix from Latin that has grammaticalised as an intensifier (Kanwit & Terán 2020: 257 and references therein). The intensifier *re* has developed from a locative or spatial marker to a marker of repetition or iteration, and finally to an intensifier adverb (see Kanwit & Terán 2020: 257 and references therein).

piña sola para hecharle la culpa a Mar
 punch alone for throw.her the blame to Mar
 ‘Moreover, that receiving a punch simply to blame Mar seems complete
 nonsense to me.’
 (@ 106)

All occurrences of predicative *cualquiera* in the Argentinian data of CdE_web dialects co-occur with adverbial or verbal phrases that express whose negative evaluation it is that *cualquiera* denotes (see the concept of “judge” in Lasersohn 2005, among others; and Chapter 3 on the judge parameter of *tasty*-predicates). In almost all cases that I found in CdE_web dialects, the evaluation is linked to the speaker, e.g. *para mí* ‘for me’, *me parece que* ‘It seems to me that...’. Of the 25 occurrences of *parece cualquiera*, 17 are *me parece*, two are *te parece*, and one is *parece*. All cases represent informal speech/dialogue:

- (13) No lo terminé de leer porque me pareció *cualquiera*.
 NEG it finish of read because me seemed CUALQUIERA
 ‘I did not finish reading it because it seemed *nonsense* to me.’
 (@ 107)
- (14) Para mí, me parece *cualquiera*.
 for me me seems CUALQUIERA
 ‘As for me, I find it *nonsense*.’
 (@ 108)
- (15) eso es *cualquiera*, al menos para mí.
 that is CUALQUIERA at least for me
 ‘That is *nonsense*, at least for me.’
 (@ 109)

However, I also found a few cases of evaluative *cualquiera* with a 3rd person opinion holder (see also Lasersohn 2005 for the same observation with *tasty*-predicates):

- (16) haría lo mismo pero si hay gente que no le gusta porque
 would.do the same but if there.are people that NEG it like because
 piensa que es *cualquiera* (yo no pienso eso)....
 think that is CUALQUIERA (I NEG think that)
 ‘I would do the same but there are people that don’t like it because they
 think it is *nonsense* (I don’t think that)....’
 (@ 110)

In Section 4.3.4, we will see that *cualquiera* with the meaning ‘nonsense’ also occurs under transitive verbs.

The meaning of *cualquiera* as ‘nonsense’ can be reinforced by degree adverbs that denote high degrees such as *muy* ‘very’, *demasiado* ‘too much, very’, *tan* ‘such’, *re* ‘very’. Degree modification of *cualquiera* as ‘nonsense’ is unexpected under the assumption that *cualquiera* is a noun when it means ‘nonsense’. I will return to this puzzle in my analysis in Section 4.4. I translate in this case the modified *cualquiera* as ‘quite nonsensical’, ‘such utter nonsense’, or as ‘completely out of place’:

- (17) Me parece todo tan *cualquiera*.
 to.me seems everything so CUALQUIERA
 ‘Everything seems such utter nonsense to me.’
 (@ 111)

If the subject of the predicative *cualquiera* refers to a person or an entity, the meaning of *cualquiera* can take on different flavours already discussed in Chapter 3, such as ‘ordinary, unremarkable’ and the pejorative meaning of ‘bad’.

- (18) Yo, que soy tan *cualquiera* como *cualquiera*.
 I that am so CUALQUIERA as CUALQUIERA
 ‘I who am as ordinary as anyone else.’⁴
 (@ 112)

Argentinian Spanish also has UN N *cualquiera* in predicative position just as in European Spanish (e.g. *una fiesta re cualquiera* ‘a very bad party’). The big difference to European Spanish is that *cualquiera* can also be modified by a degree adjective and be used as a predicative adjective as in (51).

Note that *cualquiera* can predicate over plural entities as well, as shown in (19). In the following context, *cualquiera* expresses an evaluative property of entities such as pictures according to a judge (here: B). In the following context, the evaluation concerns what the pictures represent (i.e. namely that they show a bad example):

- (19) a. A: Esas fotos que publican parece que dan mal ejemplo.
 those pics that publish seem that give bad example
 A: ‘It seems that these pics that they publish give the wrong idea.’

⁴This *cualquiera* is a pronoun (see Chapter 2).

- b. B: Sí, son re *cualquiera*.
yes are very CUALQUIERA

B: 'Yes, they [these photos] are completely out of place. The idea that these pictures represent does not make sense.'
(@ 113)

The following data show that *cualquiera* need not necessarily combine with adverbs that denote high degrees (against Rizzo Salierno's 2013 observation). Actually, we find two occurrences with modification by the adverb *medio*, which literally denotes 'half' and means 'a bit/almost' when combined with gradable adjectives as in (20) and (21) and *cualquiera* as in (22) and (23):

- (20) *Es medio complicado* este asunto.
is half complicated this case
'It's a bit complicated, this case.'
(@ 114)
- (21) matemáticamente *es medio imposible* que todas las personas puedan
mathematically is half impossible that all the people can
pasar por esa situación
go through that situation
'Mathematically it's almost impossible for all the people to go through that situation.'
(@ 115)
- (22) es que la defensa del rugby por los valores que entraña *es medio cualquiera*. O sea, a mí es un deporte que no me atrae.
CUALQUIERA that is to me is a sport that not me attracts
'Defending rugby for the values it involves is a bit nonsensical/out of place. That is, it's a sport that does not appeal me.'
(@ 116)
- (23) *es medio cualquiera* eso
is half CUALQUIERA that
'That is a bit nonsensical.'
(@ 117)

I even found that the diminutive suffix *-ita* can combine with *cualquiera*, and in this case the speaker attenuates the bad quality 'a bit nonsensical':

- (24) Bueno, cerramos este post que *es cualquierita*.
 well close this post that is CUALQUIERA.DIM
 ‘Well, let’s close this post because it’s a bit nonsensical.’
 (@ 118)

If *cualquiera* has been reanalysed as a gradable adjective, as such data suggest, it should be possible to find it in comparative clauses such as ‘he is worse than anyone else’. Surprisingly, the comparative with *más que* was not found in CdE_ web dialects. However, the following case from the corpus might be interpreted as an elliptical comparative clause:

- (25) el reggae es *cualquiera*. Mas [cualquiera] el reggae nacional.
 the reggae is CUALQUIERA more [CUALQUIERA] the reggae national
 ‘Reggae is *bad*. National reggae is (even) worse.’
 (@ 119, interpolation my own)

There are some examples of comparatives with *cualquiera* on the Internet:

- (26) Más *cualquiera* que el otro.
 more CUALQUIERA than the other
 ‘worse than the other one.’
 (@ 120)
- (27) Y con los libros me pasó más o menos lo mismo aunque
 and with the books me happened more or less the same although
 no los pienso seguir porque son más *cualquiera* que la serie
 NEG them think follow because are more CUALQUIERA than the series
 por ahí.
 for there
 ‘And with the books more or less the same thing happened to me,
 although I will definitely not follow them because they are worse than
 the series that is out there.’
 (@ 121)
- (28) me parece mas *cualquiera* que la cumbia
 to.me seems more CUALQUIERA than the cumbia
 ‘It seems worse to me than the cumbia.’
 (@ 122)

It thus seems that *cualquiera* does occur in comparative structures, although very rarely, so the corpus is probably too small to detect it or *cualquiera* is still on its way of being reanalysed as a gradable adjective. Another argument that *cualquiera* has been already reanalysed as a gradable adjective is shown by the difference in interpretation of *cualquiera* under negation. Recall from Chapter 2 that, when it is used as an FCI, *cualquiera* has a ‘not just any’ interpretation under negation. However, *cualquiera* has a different interpretation when it occurs in predicative position as an adjective in (29), in contrast to the indefinite pronoun in (30).

- (29) No es tan *cualquiera* pero sí medio *cualquiera*.
 NEG is so CUALQUIERA but yes half CUALQUIERA
 ‘It’s not that *bad* but it is a bit *bad*.’
 (@ 123)

- (30) es un portal, y no es *cualquiera* es el mejor portal de autos
 is a platform and NEG is CUALQUIERA is the best platform of cars
 del país
 in.the country
 ‘It’s a platform and not just any platform. It’s the best car platform in this country.’
 (@ 124)

This section has shown that *cualquiera* is used as a gradable category with evaluative meanings such as ‘nothing special’, ‘bad’, ‘unremarkable’, ‘nonsensical’, or ‘out of place’ in predicative contexts in Argentinian Spanish. It can be modified with adverbs *re/muy/tan/medio* ‘very/a bit’ and to a lesser extent with comparative adverbs such as *más* ‘more’.

4.3.4 Pronominal *cualquiera* under transitive verbs

Until now in this chapter, I have presented data from Argentinian Spanish on predicative *cualquiera* in which the item at issue has a series of evaluative meanings such as ‘bad’ or ‘nonsensical’.

In sentences with imperative mood, which I also analyse as a modalised constructions (see Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018 and Section 3.2.3), ArgSp *cualquiera* is interpreted as an indefinite pronoun ‘anything’ (which would correspond to *cualquier cosa* in European Spanish). Recall from Section 2.1.5 that *cualquiera* can be used as a substitute for *cualquier cosa* in European Spanish:

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- (31) *¡Hagamos cualquiera!* (hacer algo, hacer lo que sea, o como que do CUALQUIERA do something do it what is or as that da lo mismo hacer una cosa u otra).
give the same do one thing or another
'Let's do something! (do something, do anything, or it doesn't matter whether it's this thing or the other).'
- (@ 125)

In the following two examples *digo cualquiera* and *hace cualquiera* can be interpreted as 'I say anything possible' and 'she does anything possible', respectively, i.e. *cualquiera* can be interpreted as a Free Choice Indefinite pronoun 'anything' under covert subtrigging. But another possible interpretation is that the speaker uses *cualquiera* to qualify or evaluate the result state of the verbs 'say' and 'do' as 'nonsense' (EVAL2):

- (32) al rato volvió porque sabe que yo dormida *digo cualquiera*
after while came.back because know that I asleep say CUALQUIERA
a. 'She came back because she knows that when I sleep, I say anything possible.' (FCI)
b. 'She came back because she knows that when I sleep, I talk nonsense/rubbish.' (EVAL2)
- (@ 126)

- (33) se va cuando quiere, *hace cualquiera*.
her/him goes.out when wants does CUALQUIERA
a. '(S)he goes out when (s)he wants to do so, (s)he does anything she wants.' (FCI)
b. '(S)he goes out when (s)he wants to do so, (s)he does nonsense.' (EVAL2)
- (@ 127)

It thus seems that the interpretation of *cualquiera* under certain transitive verbs in the indicative as 'anything' (FCI) or 'nonsense' (EVAL2) is context-dependent in Argentinian Spanish. In contrast, if *cualquiera* occurs under the verb *mandar* 'to say', it has only the evaluative meaning 'to talk nonsense', as has already been observed in Section 2.1.5. An example is given in (34).

- (34) No supe qué decirle, así que le mandé *cualquiera*.
not knew what say.her so that her told CUALQUIERA
'I did not know what to tell her, so I told her nonsense.'
- (@ 128)

A crucial observation is that ArgSp *cualquiera* also has an evaluative meaning like ‘nonsense’ when *mandar* appears under a modal verb:⁵

- (35) y les pueden mandar *cualquiera* total
 and that her sent CUALQUIERA TOTAL
 ‘and you can tell them complete bullshit.’
 (@ 129a)

The evaluative reading here is reinforced by the degree adverb *total* ‘complete’. This observation suggests that *cualquiera* under *mandar* ‘to say’, no matter what mood *mandar* has, always has the meaning of ‘to talk nonsense/bullshit’ in contrast to other verbs that have different interpretations depending on the verbal mood. The only thinkable explanation is that the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* as ‘nonsense’ has been lexicalised in the construction of *mandar cualquiera*, whereas with other verbs, the interpretation of *cualquiera* depends on the verbal mood.

4.3.5 Summary of the data

Under modal verbs or in modalised constructions such as subjunctives and imperatives, ArgSp *cualquiera* has an FCI function in the sense of ‘anything’. Non-modal contexts such as transitive verbs in the indicative past and present tense may also trigger FCI if *cualquiera* is licensed under subtriggering. *Cualquiera* under transitive verbs is something typical for Argentinian Spanish but not for other varieties of Spanish. However, in certain contexts that express evaluation and with certain verbs such as *mandar*, *cualquiera* has an evaluative interpretation of ‘nonsense/bullshit’. In predicative contexts such as with copular verbs, *cualquiera* has only the evaluative interpretation in Argentinian Spanish. It is in this context that it can be modified by different degree adverbs and occur in degree comparatives, although modification with degree comparative adverbs occurs less frequently than modification with simple degree adverbs such as ‘very/a bit’. The interpretation of *cualquiera* as ‘ordinary’, ‘nonsense’, or ‘anything’ depends strongly on the grammatical category. If it is a pronoun, it has the interpretation of ‘anything’.

⁵The context of the example is: *Aca el problema es que estos tipos, como los chantas KK, se abusan porque hay fanáticos como este Juan emilio que no ven la realidad, viven en otro mundo y les pueden mandar cualquiera total no les da la cabeza para darse cuenta que lo estan verseyendo.* ‘The problem here is that these guys, like the KK charlatans, hurt themselves because they are fanatics like this Julio Emilio who do not see reality, they live in a different world and you can tell them complete bullshit, they don’t have the intelligence to realise that people are mocking them.’

If it is a noun, it has the interpretation of ‘nonsense’, and if it is an adjective, it has the interpretation of ‘ordinary’ or ‘nonsensical’.

Table 4.6: Different interpretations in relation with verbal mood and verb type (+/- predicative verb)

	Indicative present or past tense	Modal	<i>mandar</i> ‘say’	Predicative
FCI	+	+	–	–
EVAL	+	–	+	+

4.4 Analysis of different uses of *cualquiera* in Modern Argentinian Spanish

In this section I will give an analysis of the different syntactic functions of *cualquiera* in Modern Argentinian Spanish and discuss their origin. I will show that the indefinite use of *cualquiera* ‘any’ is the origin of the evaluative functions of *cualquiera* ‘ordinary’ and ‘nonsense’.

The data with degree modification suggests that ArgSp *cualquiera* used in predicative contexts is the result of a reanalysis as a gradable adjective denoting a relation between degrees and individuals. It thus behaves in a way similar to English *tall*: *Juan is very tall* denotes that ‘Juan is tall to degree *d*, and degree *d* denotes a high degree on a scale of tallness’. *Cualquiera* is thus a predicate denoting a scale of ordinary qualities or the pejorative version of it (i.e. bad qualities; see Section 3 on the pejoration of ‘common’, ‘ordinary’). This kind of predicate has a subjective value, i.e. the badness is not objectively measurable in contrast to tallness. The gradable predicate thus takes an additional argument, which is the experiencer of the bad quality (see Section 4.3):

- (36) a. *la peli es re cualquiera.*
 the movie is very CUALQUIERA
 ‘The movie is very ordinary.’
 b. $\text{Adj}^\circ \text{ cualquiera/cualunque}^6 = \lambda d.\lambda x. \text{bad/ordinary}(d)(x)$ for some
 experiencer *E*

⁶However, both *cualquiera* and *cualunque* are invariable adjectives as they do not inflect for person and gender. Number variation is possible in ArgSp *las chicas son cualquieras/cualunque* ‘the girls are nothing special’ (see also Rainer 1993 and Section 2.1).

4.4 Analysis of different uses of *cualquiera* in Modern Argentinian Spanish

This kind of predicate has a subjective value. Thus, *cualquiera* in (36a) would be interpreted as (36b).

- (37) [DegP *re/medio/más/demasiado/tan* [AdjP *cualquiera/cualunque*]]

As I showed in Section 4.3.3, *cualquiera* can also have the meaning of ‘nonsense’ when the object of evaluation is not an entity or person, but a proposition or an event, as in (38):

- (38) Lo que me decís es *cualquiera*.
 the.N that me say is CUALQUIERA
 ‘What you are telling me is nonsense.’
 (@ 130)

The difference in meaning between ‘nonsense’ and ‘ordinary’ or the pejorative version of the latter meaning as ‘bad’ is related to the syntactic and semantic type of the syntactic subject of the predicative *cualquiera*. In case the subject is a sentence or a proposition *p* of semantic type <s,t> (i.e. the characteristic function of a set of possible worlds), *cualquiera* means ‘nonsense’. In the following example, *cualquiera* expresses evaluation with respect to what has been said, i.e. the argument of the verb of *decir* ‘to say’. This argument is a proposition. In this example, *cualquiera* is a bare noun, precisely the same one that occurs as a noun under verbs such as verbs of saying, such as ArgSp *decir/mandar* ‘talk nonsense’, that usually take propositions as their arguments (e.g. *decir/mandar*) (see Section 4.5.2 for details).

- (39) λp . *cualquiera* (*p*) = ‘nonsense’
 decir/mandar cualquiera = ‘talk nonsense’

One important issue that needs to be addressed by this analysis is the fact that in Spanish and Romance languages in general, bare singular nouns are rare in contrast to indefinite singular nouns with an indefinite article (e.g. *decir una tontería* ‘say a stupid thing’). This restriction does not apply to plurals (e.g. *decir tonterías* ‘say stupid things’). I assume that the reason why *cualquiera* appears as a bare noun rather than as an indefinite noun (**decir un/una cualquiera*) or a plural noun (**decir cualesquieras*) is due to its pronominal origin. The pronoun *cualquiera* ‘anything’ is invariable for plural or singular. Moreover, *cualquiera* that takes a proposition as its argument is described as a kind property; that is, it describes the kind of things that one can say (see Section 4.5.2 for details). Recall that *cualquiera* that predicates over propositions can also appear with adverbs

that reinforce the evaluative property as ‘utter nonsense’ or ‘very nonsensical’. In this case the usual modification is a nominal modifier *total* ‘complete’ as repeated here:

- (40) y les pueden mandar *cualquiera* total
 and that her sent CUALQUIERA total
 ‘and you can tell them complete bullshit.’
 (@ 129b)

However, there are also cases of *cualquiera* with the meaning ‘nonsense’ and degree modification with (*tan, re* ‘very’) when *cualquiera* is used in a predicative position, as already shown in (50) and repeated here.

- (41) Me parece todo tan *cualquiera* escribirlo casi me da
 to.me seems everything so CUALQUIERA write.it almost to.me gives
 vergüenza.
 shame
 ‘Everything seems such utter nonsense to me writing it down. It’s almost embarrassing to me.’
 (@ 111)

This shows that *cualquiera* can change its syntactic status as an adjective or a bare noun depending on the syntactic context. This flexibility in word categorisation is expected under my semantic analysis, as *cualquiera* denotes a property and whether this property is represented as a noun or as an adjective depends on the syntax.

The suggested analysis can account for the difference between *cualquiera* and *cualunque* in Argentinian Spanish. The element *cualunque* does not have the meaning of ‘nonsense’, as it cannot be used to predicate over propositions and thus be used under transitive verbs such as verbs of saying (see Section 4.2). The difference in meanings between ‘bad/ordinary’ and ‘nonsense’ is a further argument against deriving *cualquiera* from the analogy of *cualunque* (against Rizzo Salierno 2013). I believe that both items *cualquiera* and *cualunque* have developed the gradable property in a parallel way as a result of reanalysis of FCIs as (gradable) predicates.

4.5 From FC use to evaluative meanings in Argentinian Spanish

In this section, I will provide an analysis of it *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish and show how it changed to the evaluative *cualquiera* analysed in Section 4.5.1. I will suggest different diachronic paths of *cualquiera* as ‘ordinary’ and as ‘non-sense’. This suggestion will be tested on diachronic data of Argentinian Spanish in Section 4.6.3.

4.5.1 The change from the postnominal modifier to the adjective *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish

I assume that the element *cualquiera* with the meaning ‘ordinary’ or ‘bad’ (EVAL1) is diachronically derived from *cualquiera* in UN N *cualquiera* by lexicalising the evaluative property of ‘ordinary, bad’ and by being used as a predicative adjective without a noun:

- (42) Juan es un hombre *cualquiera*. (EurSp and ArgSp)
 Juan is a man CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan is a man like any other man’ SIM
 ‘Juan is an ordinary man’ COM
 STAGE 1 = evaluative use of the indefinite *cualquiera*
- (43) Juan es un hombre muy *cualquiera*. (ArgSp)
 Juan is a man very CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan is a (very) ordinary man.’
 Lexicalisation of COM and reanalysis into an adjective
 STAGE 2 A= reanalysis into an adjective that modifies a noun.
- (44) Juan es (muy) *cualquiera* (ArgSp)
 Juan is (very) CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan is (very) ordinary.’
 Separation from the noun
 STAGE 2 B= reanalysis into an adjective without nominal modification.

The diachronic steps can be formalised as follows. *Cualquiera* passed from being analysed as a property of individuals or kinds of individuals into a property of degrees that can be used with or without a noun:

- (45) a. Stage 1
 $\lambda P. \lambda x [(cualquiera(P))(x)]$
 ‘property (of a kind of) individuals’
 b. Stage 2 A
 $\lambda d. \lambda P. \lambda x [(cualquiera(P)(d))(x)]$
 ‘gradable property of individuals realised as a nominal adjective’
 c. Stage 2 B
 $\lambda d. \lambda x [(cualquiera(d))(x)]$
 ‘gradable property of individuals realised as a predicative adjective’

The empirical evidence of these diachronic steps will be discussed in Section 4.6.3 and in Chapter 5. I assume that the noun *cualquiera* took a different diachronic path.

4.5.2 The change from a pronoun into a noun *cualquiera* ‘nonsense’ in Argentinian Spanish

My hypothesis is that *cualquiera* under transitive verbs with the evaluative meaning ‘nonsense’ (EVAL2) (see Section 4.4) has its origin in the indefinite pronoun *cualquiera* with the quantificational force of ‘anything’. Recall from Section 2.1.5 that *cualquiera* can be used as *cualquier cosa* in ArgSp:

- (46) *cualquiera*_{transitive} ‘any’ under ‘say’ = $\lambda P. \lambda Q. \exists x [Q(x) \ \& \ P(x)]$
 ‘anything’
 FC interpretation = everything is a possible option.

Recall from Section 2.1 that in European Spanish, inanimate *cualquiera* requires mentioning the domain in the prior context. As the following example from European Spanish shows, *cualquiera* stands for *cualquier interpretación* (see Section 2.1).

- (47) Aunque puedan admitir un alto número de interpretaciones (pero no although can admit a high number of interpretations but not admiten *cualquiera*). Hay también una tercera posibilidad.
 admit CUALQUIERA there.is too a third possibility
 ‘Even though they can admit a high number of interpretations (not not just any). There is also a third possibility.’
 (@ 131; EurSp)

4.5 From FC use to evaluative meanings in Argentinian Spanish

In Argentinian Spanish, *cualquiera* can be used to refer back to an item of the a preceding context. In the following examples, the preceding context has *cualquier cosa*, and *casi cualquiera* refers to *cualquier cosa*. Both forms are the argument of the verb *necesitar* ‘to need’ in (48) and of *ocurrir* ‘to happen’. Note also that *casi* usually modifies FCIs (see Chapter 3 for modification with *casi* ‘almost’):

- (48) *Cualquier cosa* que necesiten (bueno, *casi cualquiera*!) nos avisan!
 CUALQUIER thing that need well almost CUALQUIERA us inform
 ‘If you need anything (well, almost anything!) tell us!!’
 (@ 132)
- (49) Hoy en día, uno se imagina que podía estar ocurriendo *casi*
 today in day one her/him imagines that could be happening almost
cualquier cosa. *Casi cualquiera* menos, probablemente, lo que
 CUALQUIER thing almost CUALQUIERA minus probably the that
 ocurría.
 happened
 ‘Nowadays, one imagines that anything could be happening. Anything
 except what was actually happening, probably.’
 (@ 133)

As already noted in Section 2.1.5, *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, but not in European Spanish, can be used as *cualquier cosa* without previous mention of *cualquier cosa*. *Cualquiera* has lexicalised the meaning of *cualquier cosa* in Argentinian Spanish and does not require previous mention of *cualquier cosa*:

- (50) Respondí/Entendí/Hice/Dije [_{DP} *cualquiera*]
 = ‘I answered/understood/did/said anything.’

There is a pragmatic reason why *cualquiera* as a verbal argument has the meaning of *cualquier cosa* and not a more specific meaning, such as *cualquier libro* ‘any book’. *Cualquiera* in object position without any previous discourse can only mean *cualquier cosa*, because *cualquier cosa* is more generic than *cualquier libro*. A similar case can be demonstrated with elliptical nouns that appear without previous mention. For example, *me gusta comer* ‘I like eating’ is interpreted as ‘I like eating food or edible things’ and not as ‘I like eating a specific thing, such as chocolate.’

Two questions arise with respect to (50). The first is what licenses the use of FCI *cualquiera*, or *cualquier cosa* for that matter, under perfective verbs in (49), given that the licensing of FCIs usually happens under modal operators

rather than under perfective verbs (see Chapter 2). The second question is how to account for the evaluative reading of *cualquiera* under transitive verbs, e.g. *decir/mandar cualquiera* ‘to talk nonsense’ or *hacer cualquiera* ‘to do something out of place/nonsense’ (see Section 4.3.4).

To address the first question, I assume that FCI *cualquiera* in episodic contexts such as under transitive perfective verbs (e.g. (85) in Section 2.3 repeated in (51)) can be licensed under subtrigging where the modal is contained inside a covert relative clause, e.g. *que podría responder* ‘that I could possibly answer’ (see Section 2.2 for subtrigging and the formal representation of it):

- (51) Respondí *cualquiera* [que podría decir/responder].
 responded CUALQUIERA [that could say/respond]
 ‘I answered anything (I could answer/say).’

Another way in which the Argentinian Spanish pronominal FCI *cualquiera* ‘anything’ can be licensed in episodic contexts is to assume a covert modal inside the matrix clause, as I represent informally in (52), e.g. an agent’s decision-based modal that triggers the random choice interpretation (see Section 2.2):

- (52) Respondí *cualquiera*.
 responded CUALQUIERA
 ‘I answered something random.’
- a. ‘I said something and this something fulfills my decision to say any possible thing.’ (Agent’s decision-based modality)
 - b. ‘The thing I actually said could have been anything else than what I actually said.’ (Counterfactual modal)
- (@ 33)

The two licensing conditions (modal operator inside a relative clause, i.e. subtrigging, or inside the matrix clause as random choice modality) create two different truth conditions. Under subtrigging in (51), *cualquiera* refers to many speech events in the actual world (I said a, b, c, d...) and under random choice in (52), *cualquiera* refers to a single speech event in the actual world and the actual speech event is contrasted to other speech events that the speaker could have said or that agree with agent’s decision. There is evidence that we need both analyses, i.e. licensing of *cualquiera* under subtrigging and under some modal that triggers random choice. In cases where *cualquiera* can be modified with adverbs like *casi* ‘almost’ or with *except*-phrases (see Section 2.1), *cualquiera* is licensed under subtrigging. But when *cualquiera* has an existential inference in a

particular context, it is licensed under a modal that triggers random choice. I will first derive the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* from FCIs under subtriggering, as shown in (51), and then from random choice modality, as shown in (52).

In order to answer the question as to how to account for the evaluative reading under transitive verbs, I assume that the evaluative reading ‘nonsense’ is a pragmatic implicature on *cualquiera* or *cualquier cosa* under transitive verbs that has been lexicalised under certain verbs such as *mandar cualquiera* ‘talk nonsense’ in Argentinian Spanish. From the sentence in (51), the hearer can infer that what the speaker said can be of the form *p* and not(*p*) at the same time. To utter a contradiction can be evaluated as nonsense. This is the most direct way to account for the meaning ‘nonsense’ of *cualquiera*. Another, indirect, way to account for the meaning ‘nonsense’ is to derive ‘nonsense’ from the random choice meaning of *cualquiera*; that is ‘something random’ can be interpreted as ‘nonsense’ in some pragmatic context. Namely when the agent who said something random did not reflect on what she/he said according to some judge. The result of the lack of reflection can be interpreted as something meaningless or as nonsense according to the judge, such as in a situation when the agent was half-asleep. Thus, in this context the evaluator/judge can infer that the agent said something meaningless. Under this explanation, *to talk nonsense* would be derived from a contextual interpretation or pragmatic strengthening of the meaning of *decir/mandar cualquiera* ‘to say something random’.

Under both analyses, the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* as ‘nonsense’ is a result of a pragmatic reasoning triggered by the use of FCIs under verbs of saying (see Aloni 2007 for indefinites in general, Kellert 2020 on pragmatic reasoning in Mexican Spanish).

I find contexts that support my pragmatic analysis. The following example expresses that what the speaker actually answered does not correspond to what the speaker originally wanted to answer. In other words, the speaker’s intentions do not correspond to his/her actions/speech events. This is why *cualquiera* has the meaning of ‘something unreflected’ in the following example:

- (53) No supe qué decirle, así que le mandé *cualquiera*.
not knew what say.her so that her sent CUALQUIERA
‘I did not know what to tell her, so I told her nonsense.’
(@ 134)

Another example, where the contextual interpretation restricts the interpretation of *cualquiera* is given in the following sentence. Here the speaker has done everything except what she aimed to do, namely to fix the heating system. The exception is expressed through the contrast *pero* ‘but’:

- (54) Intenté arreglar la calefacción, pero hice *cualquiera*.
 tried fixing the heating.system but did CUALQUIERA
 ‘I wanted to fix the heating system, but I did something out of
 place/nonsense (as a result of my attempt to fix the heating system).’
 (@ 135)

In the following example *decir cualquiera* is interpreted negatively, similar to *mandar la cagada* ‘to say bullshit’. It is interpreted as something unreflected or unreasonable.

- (55) Che, ya te mandaste la cagada, dijiste *cualquiera*, tiraste abajo a la
 that ya you said the bullshit said CUALQUIERA pulled down to the
 mitad de los hombres diciendo que tienen que ser capaces de
 half of the men saying that must that be capable of
 embarazar una mujer.
 impregnate a woman
 ‘Hey, you said bullshit, you said nonsense, you are demeaning half of the
 men by saying that they have to be capable of making a woman pregnant.’
 (@ 136)

The inclusion of morally questionable alternatives like saying morally questionable things into the quantification domain of *cualquiera* can result in a negative interpretation of *decir cualquiera* as saying all possible things including morally bad things:

- (56) *decir cualquiera*
 ‘say anything possible including morally bad things’

This negative meaning of *cualquiera* is thus tantamount to FCI *cualquiera* plus the pragmatic characterisation of the quantificational domain. The negative meaning of *cualquiera* is the result of excluding certain alternatives from the domain of quantification which some evaluator considers as being good alternatives or of characterising the domain of quantification as consisting of all possible alternatives including morally questionable alternatives. I will therefore look into the domain quantification of *cualquiera* in more detail in the next subsection.

4.5.3 Formal analysis of *cualquiera* as ‘nonsense’

I assume that the domain of quantification of ArgSp *cualquiera* can be formally represented as a restriction of the quantification by an *except*-phrase as in (57).

Assuming that *except*-phrases contribute to the truth conditions of the sentence by restricting the domain of quantification of *cualquiera* to the domain of predicates besides the predicate expressed by the *except*-phrase (von Fintel 1994),⁷ I must assume that *cualquiera* in (57) triggers universal quantification, which contributes to the truth conditions of the sentence it appears in:

- (57) 'I answered *cualquiera* except what I wanted'
every([[*thing*]] – [[*what I wanted to answer*]])({x: I answered x})

Cualquiera must be interpreted universally at some level of interpretation, because existential quantification does not allow *except*-phrases (see von Fintel 1994, Arregui 2006, Gajewski 2008):

- (58) # I answered something except what I wanted.

Except-phrases of FCIs are a good argument that the universal inference of FCIs must be derived from a wider scope pragmatic operation or on the sentence level and not locally (see Section 2.2 on such an analysis, where the universal interpretation is represented on the propositional level; see also Chierchia 2006, Gajewski 2008, but also Dayal 1998, 2004, who argues that FCIs are in fact universal quantifiers, with the result that *except*-phrases operate locally). *Except*-phrases should thus operate on a wide-scope universal implicature, that is, after the universal implicature of the FCI has been derived on the sentence or pragmatic level (Gajewski 2008):⁸

- (59) Bill may have any flavour of ice cream but coffee.
LF: [LEAST coffee]_X Op_{FC} [may [Bill have any flavour but X]]
(Gajewski 2008, Gajewski 2013: 193)

I assume that in case we have a pragmatically inferred *except*-phrase as in (60), repeated from (85), *cualquiera* is licensed by covert subtrigging (see Quer 2000 and Section 2.1 for overt subtrigging):

⁷The assumption that *except*-phrases contribute to the truth conditions of the sentence they modify follows from the Restrictiveness Condition (von Fintel 1994): If a sentence with an *except*-phrase is true, the same sentence without the *except*-phrase is false (without making the exception, the sentence would be false).

⁸The focus operator LEAST triggers exhaustivity of the alternative denoted by the exceptive; that is, it triggers the interpretation that the quantification domain of *anything* includes all alternatives other than the one alternative subtracted from the domain of quantification.

- (60) a. Respondí *cualquiera*.
 responded CUALQUIERA
 ‘I answered anything that I could possibly answer except what I wanted to answer.’
 b. LF: [what I wanted to answer]_X Op_{FC} [I could possibly answer [I answered anything but X]]
 c. Prose: For every thing that I could possibly answer, I answered it, except what I wanted to answer.

This analysis explains the universal interpretation of *cualquiera* on the one hand and the licensing of *cualquiera* as FCI via subtrigging on the other.

Let me just briefly sketch an alternative analysis of *cualquiera* in episodic contexts that relies on random choice modality and not on subtrigging. The analysis is very similar to the difference that the modal operator that licenses *cualquiera* is some kind of modal, such as a counterfactual modal or a decision-based modal (see Section 2.3):

- (61) a. Respondí *cualquiera*.
 responded CUALQUIERA
 ‘I answered something random.’
 b. Existential component ‘I said something.’
 c. Counterfactual modal component: ‘And I could have said anything other than what I actually said.’
 Decision-Based modal component: ‘And anything else that I did not actually say matches my decision to say something.’

The question now is how the evaluative characterisation of *cualquiera* as ‘non-sense’ comes into play. Recall that this is the second challenge that I mentioned at the beginning of Section 4.5.2.

As already described in Section 4.5.2, I suggested that one could distinguish between contextual and lexicalised evaluative meaning. The contextual evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* is better described as the evaluation of some judge in a given context. This means that (61a) presupposes an attitude holder, the speaker of an utterance, who evaluates an event in which an agent has said something, though the agent could have said something different instead of what they actually chose to say (henceforth: event_{said(agent)(anything possible)}). The attitude holder believes that this event is less preferred than a different event *e*’ in which the agent said something else (henceforth: event_{said(agent)(not(anything possible))}). This

belief state of the attitude holder introduces an ordering scale of worlds that can be informally described as follows. All the worlds in which an agent said anything possible are less preferred than all worlds in which the agent did not say anything possible but said something specific/distinguished. I represent this ordering scale in line with Stalnaker (1984) and Heim's (1982) doxastic modal *want*, which orders worlds according to the attitude holder's preferences. Stalnaker (1984) and Heim (1982) suggest that *want* is treated as a universal quantifier over worlds. 'X wants S' is interpreted as 'X believes that a world *w* in which S is true is more desirable than a world in which S is false.' Thus, *want* is interpreted with respect to a doxastic modal base:

- (62) $\llbracket \text{want} \rrbracket^{g,w} = \lambda p \in D_{\langle s,t \rangle} . \lambda x \in D_e . \text{Dox } x,w \subseteq \{w' : \text{any world } w'' \text{ maximally similar to } w' \text{ such that } w'' \in p \text{ is more desirable to } x \text{ in } w \text{ than any world } w''' \text{ maximally similar to } w' \text{ such that } w''' \notin p\}$
(Heim 1982: 193)

I follow Heim's analysis of attitude predicates such as *want* and apply it to *cualquiera*. On this analysis *cualquiera* takes a proposition *p*, an attitude holder *x*, and a doxastic modal corresponding to a set of worlds that are ordered according to *x*'s preferences in the actual world *w* in such a way as to represent *p*'s worlds being less preferred than non-*p*'s worlds:

- (63) $\llbracket \text{cualquiera} \rrbracket^{g,w} = \lambda p \in D_{\langle s,t \rangle} . \lambda x \in D_e . \text{Dox } \langle x,w \rangle \subseteq \{w' : \text{any world that represent the negation of } p \text{ is preferred to all worlds that represents } p, \text{ i.e. the proposition that is the argument of } \textit{cualquiera}\}$
(my adaptation of Heim's (1982: 193) doxastic modality to *cualquiera*)

If we apply this denotation to (61), the ordered worlds correspond to any world in which the agent said anything possible is less preferred in *w* according to the attitude holder than the worlds in which the agent did not say anything possible, that is, in which the agent said something distinguished or particular.

The evaluative meaning component of *cualquiera* thus corresponds to the attitude holder's preferences in the actual world.

This analysis also captures the observation that the attitude holder does not have to be the speaker as shown in the following example (see also Section 4.3.3), by the fact that the attitude holder is represented as a variable in (63).

- (64) haría lo mismo pero si hay gente que no le gusta
do.COND.3SG it same but if there.is people that NEG to.them likes
porque piensa que es *cualquiera* (yo no pienso eso)...
because thinks that be CUALQUIERA (I NEG think that)
'I would do the same but there are people that don't like it because they
think it is *nonsense* (I don't think that)...'
(@ 110)

I assume that the lexicalisation of *cualquiera* under *mandar* can be represented as type-shifting in diachrony. Free Choice indefinite *cualquiera* 'anything' of type $\langle\langle e,t\rangle,t\rangle$ shifts into a property of type $\langle e,t\rangle$, which corresponds to a noun that is interpreted as a collective thing that comprises all things that one could possibly say including contradictions. When used as an argument of *mandar*, this collective thing can be paraphrased as 'nonsense'.

- (65) $[D^o \langle\langle e,t\rangle,t\rangle \text{ cualquiera 'anything'}] \rightarrow \text{type-shifting } [N^o \langle e,t\rangle \text{ 'a collective thing that comprises all things that one could possibly say including contradictions'}]$

The analysis of *cualquiera* (EVAL2) is thus the same as the one suggested in Section 3.5 for *cualquiera* in European Spanish (EVAL1), with the only difference that *cualquiera* under *mandar* in Argentinian Spanish is a property of things that denote propositions and not a property of kinds of people or entities as in EVAL1.

4.5.4 Summary of my analysis and discussion

The origin of the transitive *cualquiera* as an FCI is analysed in parallel with *cualquier cosa*, which is interpreted in certain pragmatic contexts as 'anything possible except...'. I can now suggest the following diachronic steps that have led to the development of the evaluative meaning of *cualquiera* under transitive verbs:

- (66) Diachronic steps of transitive *cualquiera*
- Step 1: Use of *cualquiera* as 'any' to refer to a domain mentioned in the previous context in European Spanish and Argentinian Spanish. A special case of this use is the use of *cualquiera* to refer back to previously mentioned *cualquier cosa*.
 - Step 2: Use of *cualquiera* in the sense of *cualquier cosa* without previous mentioning of *cualquier cosa* in Argentinian Spanish.

- Step 3: Use of *cualquiera* as *cualquier cosa* in episodic contexts:
 [VP *decir/mandar*[episodic] [DP *cualquiera=cualquier cosa*]]
 [Adjunct NP *except* something specific or something the agent wanted to say]]]
- Step 4: Evaluation of the thing or things that have been said according to preferences of an attitude holder: i.e. to say something randomly implies to say something without thinking they are less preferred according to an attitude holder than to say something distinguished or reflected.
- Step 5: Interpretation of *cualquiera* as ‘nonsense’.
- Step 6: Lexicalisation of the pragmatic evaluation as ‘nonsense’ under *mandar*.
- Step 7: Syntactic shift from indefinite quantifier into a noun.

As the diachronic development of *cualquiera* under transitive verbs shows, the step towards lexicalisation of the evaluative meaning is the pragmatic interpretation of *cualquiera* as something unreflected or something that can include contradictions according to some evaluator or judge. In contrast to Rizzo Salierno (2013), I do not assume that the transitive *cualquiera* has its origin in an analogy to the element *cualunque*, because *cualquiera* does not share the same distribution and frequency with *cualunque*, but with *cualquier cosa*. There is no occurrence with *cualunque* under transitive verbs. However, we do find *cualquier cosa* under transitive verbs.

The reanalysis of *cualquiera* as an adjective in predicative position was already discussed in Chapter 3 for European Spanish. The difference from European Spanish is that Argentinian Spanish allows degree modification of *cualquiera* and the possibility of using *cualquiera* as a predicative adjective without nominal modification, as shown in Step 2 (Table 4.7).

Chapter 5 will offer a detailed diachronic investigation of the evaluative meaning (EVAL1) in diachrony. The diachronic analysis of EVAL2 will be tested in Section 4.6.3.

4.6 Further evidence for the analysis

In this section, further evidence for the analysis will be presented on the basis of synchronic and diachronic data.

Table 4.7: Diachronic steps of predicative *cualquiera*

Step 1:	Use of <i>cualquiera</i> as ‘any’ in postnominal position with the evaluative meaning: <i>Juan es un hombre cualquiera.</i> (EurSp and ArgSp) ‘Juan is an ordinary man.’ COM
Step 2:	Lexicalisation of COM in Argentinian Spanish and reanalysis as an adjective in +/- postnominal position <i>Juan es (un hombre) muy cualquiera.</i> (ArgSp) ‘Juan is a very ordinary man/Juan is very ordinary.’ COM

4.6.1 Evidence from other languages

We find a similar reinterpretation of the free choice indefinite *n’importe quoi* in French. As shown in (67), the indefinite *n’importe quoi* has different interpretations. It can have a random choice interpretation, as in (67a), or an evaluative interpretation, as in (67b) (see Larrivé 2007, Paillard 1997, Pescarini 2009, among others):

(67) French

- a. J’ai dit *n’importe quoi*
I have said INDEFINITE
(qui m’est passé par la tête, et ça s’est trouvé à être la bonne réponse!)
‘I said something random (what came to my mind (first), and it happened to be the right answer).’ (Larrivé 2007: 4)
- b. Tu dis *n’importe quoi*. Tu sais pas ce que tu dis.
you say anything you know NEG what you say
‘You’re talking nonsense. You don’t know what you’re saying.’
‘You’re talking bullshit/nonsense.’ (@ 137)
- c. Tu dis du grand *n’importe quoi*.
you say of.the big anything
‘You’re talking bullshit/nonsense.’
(@ 138)

If *n’importe quoi* is used with a definite article and adjectival modification as in (67c), it is no longer ambiguous. It is then used as a noun with the evaluative interpretation of ‘nonsense’. *N’importe quoi* shows similarities to *cualquiera* under

transitive verbs, as it can also be used as a noun with an evaluative interpretation. The difference between *cualquiera* and *n'importe quoi* is that *n'importe quoi* cannot appear as a gradual adjective in a predicative position, whereas *cualquiera* can as shown in Section 4.3.3 (*me parece re cualquiera* 'it seems a complete bullshit to me'):

- (68) * C'est très n'importe quoi. (French)
 it.is very anything
 'This is very bullshit.'

In contrast to *n'importe quoi*, French FCI *quelconque* can be modified with degree adverbs (see Vlachou 2007). It has the meaning of 'ordinary':

- (69) Ce livre est assez *quelconque*. (French)
 this book is very ordinary
 'This book is rather ordinary.'
 (@ 139)

The analysis of *cualquiera* as a degree adjective applies to *quelconque* as well.

A similar pattern was observed in Mexican Spanish for the lexical item *equis* (originally meaning 'the letter x'), which can be used as an indefinite with a free choice interpretation 'any' under conditionals as in (70), but can also function as a gradable adjective that expresses EVAL1, as shown in (71) (see Kellert 2020):

- (70) Si por *equis* razón no vas a venir, avísame (MexSp)
 if for some reason NEG go to come let.me.know
 'If you cannot come for some reason, let me know.'
 'If for whatever reason you cannot come, let me know.'
 (Kellert 2020: 137)
- (71) un hombre bastante / demasiado / muy *equis* (MexSp)
 a man quite / too / very average
 'a very ordinary man (with no special qualities)'
 (Kellert 2020: 138)

More research needs to be done in order to testify the change of indefinites into evaluative nouns or adjectives in other languages (see Šimík 2008 for Czech). In the future, I will also compare my results with more recent studies on the Mayan

language Chuj (spoken in Guatemala and Mexico) that shows interesting parallels with the contact induced meaning variation of *komon* ‘common, ordinary’ (Alonso-Ovalle & Royer 2021).

Another topic that needs further investigation is the licensing of indefinites in episodic contexts without overt subtriggering such as ArgSp *respondí cualquiera* ‘I answered anything possible’ in other languages. Dayal (1998) shows that *any* can be licensed under perfective verbs without overt subtriggering in some English varieties (see Dayal 1998 for English varieties):

- (72) a. Mary confidently answered any objections.
b. After the dinner, I threw away any leftovers. (Dayal 1998: 446)

In contrast to English, which rarely allows FCI *any* in episodic contexts, Romance indefinites such as *cualquiera* do allow FCIs in episodic contexts (see Section 2.3). One possible explanation why *cualquiera* appears more often in episodic contexts than English *any* is that *cualquiera* lexically encodes modality due to its relative clause origin from free choice relative *qual quier* ‘whatever you want’ (see Rivero 2011 and Section 2.2). This explanation also holds for French as *n’importe quoi* lexically encodes a modal meaning ‘it is not important what’. It seems that English *any* does not encode modality lexically and thus does not allow *any* to appear in episodic contexts as in Spanish and French.

4.6.2 Evidence from comparison with *cualquier cosa*

My analysis of ArgSp *cualquiera* is based on the FCI *cualquiera*. It is thus possible that *cualquier cosa* has undergone a similar change. I will therefore compare the two items and their uses. All data is taken from CdE_web dialects. As I will show *cualquier cosa* is on its way to reanalysis as a degree adjective ‘bad/out of place’.

Cualquier cosa can be used predicatively on par with *cualquiera* and have the same evaluative meaning of ‘bad, incorrect, out of place’. This is shown by the use of *cualquier cosa* and *cualquiera* under predicative verbs such as *ser/parecer* ‘be’/‘behave’.

- (73) Ese estudio es *cualquier cosa*, realmente *cualquier cosa*.
that study is CUALQUIER thing really CUALQUIER thing
‘This study is bad/out of place, really bad/out of place.’
(@ 140)

As with *cualquiera*, *parece cualquier cosa* is often accompanied by some evaluator (e.g. ‘I find’):

- (74) Me *parece cualquier cosa* la designacion de este día, francamente.
 me seems CUALQUIER thing the appointment of this day frankly
 ‘Today’s appointment seems out of place to me, frankly.’
 (@ 141)
- (75) Me *parece cualquier cosa* lo que planean hacer con la línea H.
 to.me seems CUALQUIER thing the that plan to.do with the line H
 No hay estudios que demuestren la factibilidad del nuevo recorrido.
 NEG have studies that show the feasibility of.the new route
 ‘I find it nonsense what they are planning to do with the H line.’
 (@ 142)

A new finding is that *cualquier cosa* can even be used as a degree adjective (only one occurrence has been identified in CdE_web dialects with degree adverb *muy*):

- (76) No la soporto en ninguna. Verónica Coincido con Maid en esa
 NEG her tolerate in no-one Verónica Coincido with Maid in that
 pareja es *muy cualquier cosa*!
 couple is very CUALQUIER thing
 ‘I can’t stand any of them. Verónica Coincido with Maid in that couple is completely out of place.’
 (@ 143)

Web research has turned up more examples with degree modification by *re/-muy* from young bloggers or Facebook users:

- (77) Mi pose es *re cualquier cosa* pero la edit es preciosa!
 my pose is very CUALQUIER thing but the edit is gorgeous
 ‘My pose is completely out of place, but the edit is gorgeous!’
 (@ 144)
- (78) Ya es *muy cualquier cosa* ya.
 now is very CUALQUIER thing now
 ‘It is completely out of place, it definitely is.’
 (@ 145)
- (79) Julio Ponce suena *muy cualquier cosa*,
 Julio Ponce plays very CUALQUIER thing
 ‘Julio Ponce plays completely out of place.’
 (@ 146)

I also found *medio* with *cualquier cosa* by young forum users and bloggers:

- (80) Creo que te podés presentar de la nada, pero conviene
believe that you can appear from the nothing but is.advisable
mandarle un mail. Es *medio cualquier cosa* el sistema (y mejor
send.him a email is half CUALQUIER thing the system (and better
ni hablar del adelanto de la segunda fecha todavía estoy
not.even talk of.the forwarding of the second date still am
con la vena).
with the mood)
'I think that you can go there directly, but it is advisable to send her/him
an email. The system is somewhat out of place (and it's better if I don't
even talk about moving the second date forward, I am still in a bad
mood).'
(@ 147)
- (81) Sí, es cierto, la actuación de Cecilia Dopazo es *medio cualquier*
yes is true the performance of Cecilia Dopazo is half CUALQUIER
cosa [...] y fue pésima la elección de ella para el papel.
thing and was awful the decision of her for the role
'Yes, it's true, Cecilia Dopazo's performance was somewhat out of place
[...] and choosing her for the role was an awful decision.'
(@ 148)

These data show that *cualquiera* and *cualquier cosa* can function as gradable adjectives and be modified by different degree modifiers (*muy*, *re*, *medio*) that denote +/- high degrees for some speakers. However, more research is needed to identify the sociolinguistic parameters in the acceptability of degree modification of *cualquier cosa*.

With respect to degree suffixes, I also found a difference in interpretation between *cualquiera* and *cualquier cosa*. The diminutive suffix *-ita* can combine with *cualquiera*, and in this case the speaker attenuates the bad quality 'a bit bad' (see Section 2.1):

- (82) Bueno, cerramos este post que es *cualquierita*.
well close this post that is CUALQUIER.DIM
'Well, let's close this post because it's a bit nonsensical.'
(@ 118)

The noun *cosa* can be modified by a diminutive *-ita* to denote a little tiny thing (a *minimiser*, see Krifka et al. 1995), and the combination *cualquier cosita* denotes an FCI ‘any little tiny thing’:

- (83) Dando educación de calidad y no *cualquier cosita*.
 offering education of quality and NEG CUALQUIER thing.DIM
 ‘Offering quality education and not just any little thing.’
 (@ 149)
- (84) de *cualquier cosita* llora peor que un chico
 of CUALQUIER thing.DIM weeps worse than a boy
 ‘He weeps over any little thing, worse than a little boy.’
 (@ 150)

Whereas *cualquier* in *cualquier cosa* is originally a quantificational determiner D° with an FC meaning ‘anything’ (both in European and in Latin American Spanish), as shown in (85), in Argentinian Spanish the whole string *cualquier cosa* has additionally developed a special evaluative meaning and has also been recategorised as an Adj° , see (86):

- (85) a. D° *cualquier cosa* = ‘anything’
 b. $\lambda P.\exists x.$ thing(x) & $P(x)$ + Free Choice Implicature (ArgSp and EurSp)
- (86) Adj° *cualquier cosa* = $\lambda d.\lambda x.$ bad(d)(x)
 (ArgSp)

The observation that *cualquiera* but not *cualquier cosa* has been found with comparatives and the observation that *cualquier cosa* is less frequent with gradable adjectives seems to suggest that the process of recategorisation into a gradable adjective is more advanced with *cualquiera* than with *cualquier cosa*. If the difference between *cualquiera* and *cualquier cosa* lies in the difference in the ongoing process of lexicalisation, we should observe differences in age distribution or geographical distribution. I will test this hypothesis with native speaker judgements in future research.

4.6.3 Diachronic evidence

For diachronic research of *cualquiera* and *cualquier cosa* in Argentinian Spanish, I first used the diachronic corpus CORDIAM (Corpus Diacrónico y Diatópico del Español, CORDIAM, www.cordiam.org, which contains a total of 10,889,176

words from 19 Latin-American countries from 1494 to 1905, with documents from archives, journals, and literature. It is annotated for geographical origins. The corpus CORDIAM contains only 104 instances of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, only one instance of N *cualquiera*, and zero instances of *cualquier cosa* and *cualquiera* with the meaning of *cualquier cosa*. The remaining instances use *cualquier* NP and *cualquiera* as ‘any NP’ or ‘anyone’:

- (87) Ella [...], á este le dirige un cumplimento, á ese una
 she [...] to this.one to.him directs a greeting to that.one a
 mirada simpática, á aquel un apóstrofe *cualquiera*,
 look friendly to that.one a apostrophe CUALQUIERA
 ‘She sends this one a compliment, to the other one a nice smile, and to
 that one a random insult.’
 (19th, anonymous, journal: *La Camelia*; ArgSp)

I also used a larger diachronic corpus, CORDE (Corpus Diacrónico del Español), which is a diachronic corpus with written texts spanning from Old Spanish to 1974. It contains 250 million written words from different genres, types, and geographical origins. *Cualquiera* appears 535 times in Argentinian Spanish starting from the 18th century. Before that, the form *qualquiera* appeared nine times from the 16th to the 18th century (see Chapter 5 on different forms). There is no case of gradable *cualquiera* in predicative position (e.g. *es muy cualquiera*). However, there is one occurrence of predicative *cualquiera* without nominal modification with the meaning ‘nothing important’ or ‘ordinary’:

- (88) *Cualquiera* as a predicative complement
 Su ocupación era *cualquiera*.
 his position was CUALQUIERA
 ‘He had an ordinary position./His position was nothing important.’
 (1926, Güiraldes, *Don Segundo Sombra*; ArgSp)

One interesting observation is that UN N *cualquiera*, such as in (88), appears more often in affirmative contexts in Argentinian Spanish than it does in European Spanish (56% in Argentinian Spanish vs 18% in EurSp). This observation of the relatively high frequency of UN N *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish can be interpreted as an indicator that *cualquiera* is undergoing the process of lexicalisation of the meaning ‘ordinary’ and ‘bad’. In Chapter 5, we will look at the development of *cualquiera* in European Spanish and investigate the appearance of the evaluative reading (EVAL1).

There is no diachronic data that could confirm Step 2 in Section 4.5.3. CORDE does not contain *cualquiera* as a substitute for *cualquier cosa*. CORDE contains 167 examples of *cualquier cosa* in Argentinian Spanish among which five examples of *cualquier cosa* are embedded in episodic contexts under verbs of saying (*decir, hablar de, murmurar, conversar de*). Note that *cualquier cosa* does not mean ‘nonsense’ in these contexts, but rather has a weaker reading of ‘nothing in particular’ or ‘something unimportant’; that is, the speaker does not care to specify the reference of the object of conversation, as in (89a), or the speaker has no plan in mind of what he was going to do, as in (89b) (see the indifference or indiscriminative reading in 2.4).

(89) *Cualquier cosa* in Argentinian Spanish

- a. Y el público, formado por la gente de huella y de
and the audience, formed by the people of footprint and of
estancia, conversaba de *cualquier cosa*.
stay, conversed about CUALQUIER thing
‘The general public, herders and ranchers, hummed with talk about
everything and nothing.’
(1926, Güiraldes, *Don Segundo Sombra*; ArgSp)
- b. Yo salí muy decidido a *cualquier cosa*, pero a nada en
I went.out very determined to CUALQUIER thing, but to nothing in
particular.
particular
‘I was not sure what I was going to do.’
(1940, Bioy Casares, *La invención de Morel*; ArgSp)
- c. Y de pronto, para romper el intolerable silencio, yo decía
and of suddenly to break the intolerable silence I said
cualquier cosa que en otro tiempo podía haber tenido interés
CUALQUIER thing that in another time could have had interest
para el tipógrafo. - La fora ha declarado una huelga de
for the typographer. - the union has declared a strike of
estibadores.
stevedores
‘And suddenly, in order to break the unbearable silence, I said just
something or other that in another time would have had some
interest for the typographer.’
(1961, Sábato, *Héroes y tumbas*; ArgSp)

- d. Estábamos tendidos de espaldas, uno al lado del otro, y ella
 were lying on backs, one to the side of the other and she
 me acariciaba maquinalmente, yo tenía frío y ella me hablaba
 me caressed mechanically, I had cold and she me spoke
 de *cualquier cosa*, de la pelea que acababa de ocurrir en
 about CUALQUIER thing, about the fight that had just occurred in
 el bar, de las tormentas de marzo, [...]
 the bar, of the storms of March
 ‘We were close together, one against the other, and she caressed
 automatically, I was cold and she talked to me about something or
 other, about the fight that had just taken place in the bar, about the
 storms in March, [...]’
 (1963, Cortazár, *Rayuela*; ArgSp)
- e. Suspirando, Traveler se volvió a la cama. A una pregunta
 sighing Traveler REFL turned to the bed to a question
 soñolienta de Talita, le acarició el pelo y murmuró
 sleepy of Talita to her caressed the hair and murmured
cualquier cosa. Talita besó el aire, manoteó un poco, se
 CUALQUIER thing. Talita kissed the air, waved a little, REFL
 tranquilizó.
 calmed down
 ‘Sighing, Traveler went back to his room. After Talita asked him a
 question in a sleepy state, he caressed her hair and whispered
 something. [...]’
 (1963, Cortazár, *Rayuela*; ArgSp)

The ratio of meanings per century is summarised in Table 4.8.

To sum up, the diachronic corpora contain only one example of a predicative adjectival use of *cualquiera* and no adjectival use of *cualquier cosa*. They do not show the special ‘nonsense’ reading under verbs of saying. The first examples that appear with degree modification are examples from the modern use of Argentinian Spanish in CdE_web dialects in the 21st century, as reported in Section 4.3. The earliest occurrences that I could find of *decir/mandar cualquiera* originate from the 21st century, although according to Conde (2011a) *decir/mandar cualquiera* is apparently from Lunfardo, which must be older than the 21st century. One possible explanation why there is no diachronic data of special uses of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish is that diachronic data is mostly taken from

Table 4.8: Diachronic distribution of *cualquiera* and *cualquier cosa* in CORDIAM and CORDE

Linguistic context	CORDIAM	CORDE
bare <i>cualquiera</i>	0	1 (EVAL)
<i>cualquier cosa</i>	0	167 (162 with FCI, 5 with EVAL under verbs of saying in 20th c.)
other context	103 (FCI)	367 (FCI)
total	103	535

written language, whereas the special uses of *cualquiera* represent spoken language. Another explanation is that the use of *cualquiera* as a gradable adjective with the meaning ‘ordinary’ and ‘bad’ is a recent innovation of native speakers of Argentinian Spanish. Describing diachronic change of spoken language is thus extremely difficult with corpus methods due to the scarcity of corpus data.

In the future, single texts representing a higher degree of communicative immediacy, “Nähesprache” in the sense of Koch & Oesterreicher (2011), such as letters or personal journals and drama will be considered.

5 Diachrony of QUALQUIER revisited

The Old Spanish forms of *cualquiera* were rather *qualquier*, *-e*, *-a* or *qual quier*, *-e*, *-a* (see Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, Pato 2012, Mackenzie 2019, among others). I will use the notation QUALQUIER in reference to both Old and Modern Spanish. By contrast, the notation *qualquier*, *-e*, *-a* refers exclusively to Old Spanish, and *cualquier*, *-a* only to Modern Spanish. In this chapter, I will look at the syntactic and semantic change of the synthetic form of QUALQUIER, the form that has been already reanalysed as a compound word, which has its origin in a free relative clause (see Palomo 1934, Lombard 1938–39/1947–48, Meier 1950, Rivero 1988, Espinosa Elorza & Lancis 2006, Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, among others), illustrated again schematically as follows:

- (1) a. [MainClauseV_{main}... [CP-Rel. **qualquier** [C° **que**] [TP V_[subj.]]]] or
 b. [MainClause [CP-Rel. **qualquier** [C° **que**] [TP V_[subj.]]]] ...V_{main} ...]
- (2) a. Sepan quantos esta carta viren como yo [...] *quito* *e* *escuso*
 know how.many this letter see how I remove and excuse
el su portero de la iglesia, qual quier que sea, por todo
 the their usher of the church whatever may that be for all
 tiempo de todo pecho [...]
 time of all payment
 ‘May all that see this letter know how I [...] I exempt and discharge
 the usher of the church, *whoever (one wants that) it might be*, from all
 feudal taxes [...]’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Doc. Cast.-León*)
- b. E tan grandes eran las bozes delos hombres & del ganado que
 and so great were the voices of.the men & of.the cattle that
qualquier que lo viesse hauria ende gran dolor & muy gran
 whoever who it saw would.have from.it great sorrow & very great
 piedad...,
 pity
 ‘and the voices of the men and of the cattle were so great that

whoever (one wants that) s/he sees it would have great pain and very great pity...,
(13th c., Anonymous, *Gran Conquista*)

(1) and (2), respectively, show two kinds of embedding of the relative clause in the 13th century. In (1a), the relative clause introduced by *qualquier* modifies an element of the main clause (the DP *el su portero de la iglesia*), whereas in (1b) the relative clause itself is the subject of the main clause. As will be shown in 5.2, these are the most frequent types in the 13th century. Other types will be discussed in 5.3. The separated form *qual quier* (the prior stage of the synthetic form QUALQUIER) will not be the focus in this section and the statistical analysis in Section 5.1 and Section 5.2. The separated form *qual quier* and the interposition form *qual NP quier* was mostly used in the 13th century and disappeared from that period on (see Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, Pato 2012), which is why I do not include this form in this study.

I will show in this section that the frequency of the use of the synthetic forms represented by QUALQUIER in sentence types other than relative clauses as illustrated in (3) rose over time. For instance, the frequency of QUALQUIER in main declarative clauses with indicative verbal mood as exemplified in a (schematically analysed in 3) rises significantly (for other instances of sentence types, see Section 5.2):

- (3) a. [Main Declarative Clause ... Verb[Indic.] ... [QUALQUIER NP]]_{subj} (postverbal subject) or
- b. [Main Declarative Clause ... [QUALQUIER]]_{subj} Verb[Indic.] (preverbal subject)
- (4) a. Por ende bien *se* advise desto *qualquier* varón.
for this well REFL advise of.this QUALQUIER man
'For this reason every man needs to get informed about this.'
(14th c., López de Ayala, *Libro rimado*)
- b. [...], esto *qualquier* sabría,[...]
'[...], anybody would know it, [...]'
(14th c., López de Ayala, *Libro rimado*)

As will be shown in this section, the sentence type and the verbal mood as well as other syntactic factors correlate with differences in the interpretation of QUALQUIER (+/- EVAL). I will test the frequency changes of the type described in (2) vs. (3) and other changes quantitatively. The results of these tests will show

how *QUALQUIER* developed further on in time after it changed from a relative clause [*Rel.Cl.* = *D qual V quier ...*]¹, as discussed in Section 5.2.1, into an indefinite determiner [*D qualquier/cualquier*] as in *cualquier persona* ‘any person’ (see Section 5.2.1 on this grammaticalisation process).

The ultimate goal of investigating the diachronic change of *QUALQUIER* is to see how it developed different meanings across time, such as the evaluative meanings ‘ordinary’, ‘common’, and ‘unremarkable’ and whether this development of meanings is related to the (morpho)syntactic structure and change of *QUALQUIER*.

This chapter is organised as follows. Section 5.1 introduces into the methodology and data selection chosen. The changes will be first described quantitatively in Section 5.2 and verified statistically. Section 5.3 suggests a syntactic and semantic analysis of the changes described in Section 5.2. A summary will be presented in Section 5.4.

5.1 Methodology and data

This section introduces into the methodology of this chapter.

5.1.1 Data selection

In order to investigate the development of *QUALQUIER*, I used the diachronic subcorpus, *Genre/Historical* of Mark Davies’ Corpus del Español (CdE_G/H): <https://www.corpusdelespanol.org/hist-gen/>. This subcorpus contains more than 20,000 Spanish texts from the 1200s to the 1900s.²

Different research questions formulated in Chapter 5 have been answered using different data sets of the diachronic corpus CdE_G/H. The research question concerning the development of *QUALQUIER* and the correlation between parameters such as time and linguistic features (e.g. verbal position and sentence type) requires manual tagging of every example. For this research question a set of 150 examples per century was created, except for the 14th century, for which only 142 examples could be gathered due to the low number of data in this century in the

¹Rel.Cl. stands for relative clause.

²There is another historical corpus, CORDE. This corpus is not annotated in any way and thus does not allow one to search for syntactic configurations. It is only useful for searching for exact phrases. Its main advantage, though, is that CORDE offers the possibility to limit the search to specific countries and registers across periods and varieties. CORDE contains 240 million words from 950 to 1974 and does not contain any oral data, relying exclusively on written texts from books and the press. It does not provide the relative frequency, which must be calculated manually. For these reasons I decided not to use it.

diachronic corpus CdE_G/H, which contains only 216 examples of *QUALQUIER* in total, and except for the 19th century, for which 149 examples were used for reasons that will be explained below.

I searched the corpus for the string **ualqu**. The asterisks serve as a wild card character for any letter or sequence of letters. The search was thus sensitive to forms such as: *cualquier*, *cualquiera*, *qualquier*, *qualquiera*, *qualquiere* (see Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009, Pato 2012 for graphical variants). The corpus data for answering the aforementioned research question does not include the separated form *qual quier* and thus also excludes cases of interposition such as *qual NP quier* (see Pato 2012 on interposition). As I already explained, I use the generic notation *QUALQUIER* to refer to all these variants.

The diachronic corpus contains data from the 13th to the 20th century. The corpus represents the centuries as follows: 1200s (1200–1300), 1300s (1300–1400), 1400s (1400–1500), 1500s (1500–1600), 1600s (1600–1700), 1700s (1700–1800), 1800s (1800–1900), 1900s (1900–2000) (Figure 5.1).³

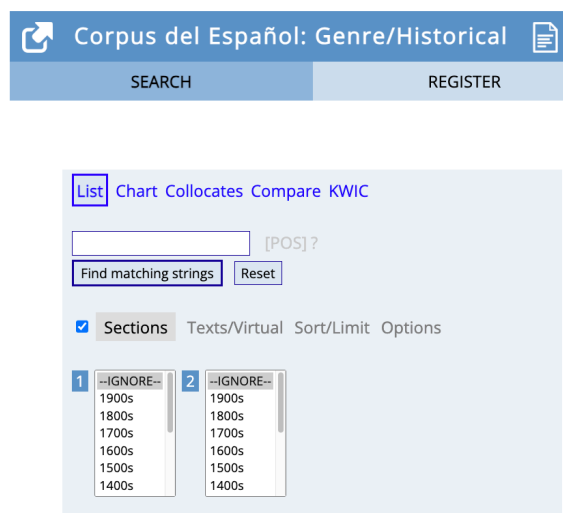


Figure 5.1: Screenshot of the corpus search_CdE_G/H.

³In Section 5.1 and Section 5.2 of this chapter, I use screenshots from the output of the CdE search. In these screenshots, frequencies are indicated either as per million words as absolute numbers or both values are displayed. The information about the relative frequency is especially necessary where I compared frequencies of the whole corpus CdE, because the sub-corpora used to represent every century or time period are not equal in CdE and the relative frequency allows us to compare the data between periods (see Kellert 2018 on relative frequency measurements in the CdE in Old Spanish).

For each century, at least 500 examples (with the exception of the 14th century) were selected for classification. I annotated the centuries in my data with ordinal numbers (e.g. 13th c.). For the first three centuries (i.e. 13th, 14th, and 15th centuries), I excluded some texts whose edition cannot be considered philologically reliable (see Octavio de Toledo & Rodríguez Molina 2017 and Chapter 1). Moreover, I excluded cases of coordination and ellipsis (see examples of coordination and ellipsis in Old Spanish in Section 5.2) so as to be able to annotate verbal properties of the examples with *QUALQUIER* (see below, Section 5.1.2). After the exclusion of such occurrences of *QUALQUIER*, I chose at least 150 random examples for each century (142 examples for the 14th c., as I have explained earlier), which is a sufficient number for a quantitative analysis. Due to the exclusion of coordination and ellipsis in the 19th c. (=1800s.), my sample comprised 149 examples.⁴ I call the data set acquired with this methodology “my data”. The data as well as the information about the selected texts (represented in percentages) and the cases that have been filtered out (e.g. coordination and ellipsis) can be found in the respective Excel file on GitHub: <https://github.com/olga-kel/Historical-Linguistics>.

The choice of the sample size of 500 examples per century represents a balance between the linguistic analysis and reliability of the philological work. The examples have been first checked for philological accuracy and around 150 examples have been selected for linguistic analysis. 150 examples per century provide a sufficiently large sample size to capture linguistic patterns and variations.

In addition, I performed a supplementary corpus-wide analysis, where possible. I indicated the relative frequencies per mil of the occurrences in the entire corpus. This method includes texts that are not necessarily philologically reliable, but it provides an overview of existing patterns across the entire corpus. As the corpus is only tagged for part-of-speech (POS), not for dependency relations such as subject and object, some linguistic variables like subject or object function of *QUALQUIER* could not be identified automatically in the whole corpus.

I use examples from the whole corpus CdE_G/H in order to make suggestions about previous diachronic stages of the grammaticalisation before *QUALQUIER* was reanalysed as a compound word (see Section 5.3). The distribution of words and texts per century and the division of text genre in the 20th c. (= 1900s) is shown in Table 5.1.

⁴In order to make sure that my corpus is big enough to run statistical tests, I contacted Alexander Silbersdorff, Chair of Statistics at the University of Göttingen and Thomas Weskott (Germanistik, University of Göttingen). I especially thank Thomas Weskott for his advice on how to implement the model of logistic regression on “my data”.

Table 5.1: Distribution of words per century in the Historical Subcorpus of the Corpus del Español

Century	Words	# Texts
1200s	7,079,164	71
1300s	2,667,810	50
1400s	8,747,963	160
1500s	17,774,762	323
1600s	13,355,483	498
1700s	10,324,328	176
1800s	20,822,142	392
1900s-News	5,144,631	6810 news articles
1900s-Lit	5,144,073	850 novels + short stories
1900s-Oral	5,113,249	2040 interviews
1900s-Acad	5,138,077	2931 articles
Total	101,311,682	13,926

5.1.2 Classification of the examples

As a result of the method described above, my data contain 150 examples with *QUALQUIER* per century (except the 14th century and the 19th century). I classified these examples using different syntactic and semantic variables that were chosen based on my research questions. These variables can be clustered according to different groups represented as A–F. The graphic variation represents group A; *QUALQUIER* as the modifier of an adjacent noun vs. *QUALQUIER* alone (i.e. as bare Q without noun modification, or QN/NQ as nominal modification) is Group B; the syntactic function of *QUALQUIER* (subject, direct object, indirect object, predicative noun, adverb) represents Group C; the position of *QUALQUIER* with respect to the verb of which *QUALQUIER* is an argument or which *QUALQUIER* modifies if it is an adverbial (QV/VQ) represents Group D; the mood, tense, aspect, and finiteness of the verb of which *QUALQUIER* is an argument or which *QUALQUIER* modifies if it is an adverbial (indicative/subjunctive, infinitive/gerund/participle, perfective aspect⁵) constitutes Group E; and the sentence type and sentence mood of the sentence in which *QUALQUIER* appears represent Group F. The latter group contains the clause type (main clause, subordinated clause) and the sentence mood: declarative or *QUALQUIER* as antecedent of a relative or complement clause⁶ intro-

⁵Perfective aspect was chosen to determine whether *cualquiera* can be used under perfective verbs in diachrony (see Chapter 2 for the role of perfective verbs in synchrony).

⁶In the descriptive part, I describe a clause introduced by *que* pretheoretically as a relative or complement clause. The distinction depends strongly on the analysis of *quier* in *qualquier*.

duced by *que* (QUALQUIER (XP) *que* or *Q que*), which I analysed as (free) relatives (FRel) or other type.

Before I present the data, it is important to distinguish between QUALQUIER that appears in a main clause and QUALQUIER that appears in a relative clause or other subordinate clauses, because this difference influences the classification of QUALQUIER. As my interest is to understand the relation of QUALQUIER to the elements that QUALQUIER structurally depends on, I only classified the relation between QUALQUIER and the structurally dependent verb. When QUALQUIER introduced a relative clause, as in (1), I classified QUALQUIER with respect to the variables described above and used in Table 5.5–Table 5.7 below (e.g. its syntactic function or its position to the verb) *inside the relative clause* rather than inside the matrix clause. This classification is a logical consequence of my analysis of relative clauses, that is, QUALQUIER is analysed as part of a relative clause (i.e. as a specifier of a relative clause) and that as such it is structurally connected to the elements inside the relative clause, such as the verb in subjunctive (see for instance Quer 2000 on the importance of the subjunctive in relative clauses).

I now proceed to go through the overall results concerning the different variables and to illustrate them with examples from the corpus.

Table 5.2 shows the absolute frequencies for the variables of group A to D from the total of around 150 examples per century:

In (5), I provide examples for the variables of groups from B to D:

- (5) a. Bare Q
 Et mando a *qualquier* que touiere estas salinas que les
 and order to QUALQUIER that has these salterns that to.them
 de cadanno estos ocho caffizes de sal bien [...] *de*
 gives each.year these eight measures of salt well
 ‘And I order anyone who has these salterns, that he should give them
 every year eight *cahices* [measuring unit] of salt [...]’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Doc. Cast. - Castilla la Nueva*)
- b. QN
 Si puede tomar armas *qualquier persona*, sea la quistión
 if can take weapons QUALQUIER person be the question
 primera.
 first
 ‘[The issue of] whether any person can take weapons, should be the
 first question.’
 (15th c., Rodríguez del Padrón, *Triunfo de las donas*)

c. NQ

y no parecería muy duro que hubiera quien ayudase a
 and NEG would.seem very hard that would.be someone helped to
 llenarle de un *modo cualquiera*.

fill.it of a way CUALQUIERA

‘and it would not seem difficult [to find] that there would be someone
 who would help to fill it [i.e. the remaining space of an area on a
 newspaper page] *in any (whichever) way*.’

(19th c., Arenal, *Beneficencia*)

Table 5.2: CdE_cualquiera_150 occ. per century, my data from A to D
 (1)

	13th	14th	15th	16th	17th	18th	19th	20th
Orthography (A)								
qual-	149	139	141	13	12	18	0	0
cual-	1	3	9	137	138	131	150	150
± noun modifier (B)								
bare Q	102	62	33	37	38	41	55	23
QN	43	78	116	113	111	106	81	123
NQ	5	2	1	0	1	2	14	4
Syntactic function (C)								
Subj	94	70	27	35	32	29	24	25
DO	15	15	26	26	42	32	37	38
IO	25	34	65	62	52	66	65	54
Copula predicate	5	16	11	13	12	11	14	7
ADV	11	7	21	14	12	11	10	26
VQ (D)								
QV	134	118	102	98	83	91	71	54
VQ	16	24	48	52	67	58	79	96
total	150	142	150	150	150	149	150	150

d. S=Subject

somos del todo enfermos e con mucha amargura; *qualquier*
 are completely sick and with much bitterness *QUALQUIER*
 tentación nos vence, aunque non sea muy dura.
 temptation us overcomes even.if NEG is very hard
 ‘we are totally weak and with much bitterness: any temptation wins
 over us, even if it is not hard [to resist].’
 (14th c., López de Ayala, *Libro rimado*)

e. DO

Si puedo *cualquier* sustancia doctamente definir, y accidentes
 if can *CUALQUIER* substance scholarly define and accidents
 describir en la mayor importancia, ...
 describe in the highest importance
 ‘if I can define any kind of substance with erudition and describe any
 contingent property in its highest importance, ...’
 (17th c., Villamediana, *Poesía*)

f. IO

[...] E a *qualquier* delos sobre dichos que mostrare alguna
 and to *QUALQUIER* of.the aforementioned that show some
 destas escusas bien lo deuen oyr desde el casamiento sea
 of.these excuses well it should hear once the marriage is
 hecho.
 made
 ‘and *from anyone* of the aforementioned that will *show* some of these
 excuses, they well need to hear it before the marriage is made...’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete partidas*)

g. QV

Sin dubda Dios perdona el pecado llorado; enpero
 without doubt God forgives the sin cried however
qualquier se tema, si puede aver ganado tal graçia; [...] *QUALQUIER* REFL
 fears if can have obtain such grace
 ‘Without any doubt, God forgives the regretted sin; but anyone who
 may be frightened may have obtained such grace...’
 (14th c., López de Ayala, *Libro rimado*)

5 Diachrony of *QUALQUIER* revisited

h. VQ

Mi mamá política hacía trampas sin escrúpulos para *ganar*
 my mom political did tricks without scruples to win
cualquier juego en que participara.
QUALQUIER game in that participated

‘My mother-in-law cheated in an unscrupulous way to win any game she was part of.’

(20th c., Pisabarro, *Del agua nacieron los sedientos*)

Table 5.3 shows all numerical values for the variables from Group E.

Table 5.3: CdE_cualquiera_150 occ. per century from my data (E)

	13th	14th	15th	16th	17th	18th	19th	20th
Mood (E)								
Indicative	26	61	60	89	99	64	74	102
Subjunctive	120	74	66	45	33	49	51	17
Inf								
Imperative	3	0	0	1	2	1	2	0
Infinitive	1	5	16	12	12	29	18	27
Gerund	0	1	1	3	3	3	1	0
Tense/Aspect								
Participle	0	1	7	0	1	3	4	4
Perfective	2	1	2	5	3	2	3	13
Total	150	142	150	150	150	149	150	150

In (6), I provide examples for the variables of Group E. Recall here again that I only considered the mood of the main verb, only if *QUALQUIER* was embedded inside a main clause. Otherwise, I considered the mood of the verb inside the relative clause, as in (1).

(6) a. Mood: indicative

Los actores le restaron elegancia al juego y *desdeñaron*
 the actors to.him reduced elegance to.the game and disregarded

cualquier posibilidad de gol.

CUALQUIER possibility of goal

‘The actors downplayed the elegance of the game and discounted any possibility for a goal’

(20th c., CR:PrLibre:98May4)

b. Mood: subjunctive

E tan grandes eran las bozes delos hombres & del ganado que
and so great were the voices of.the men & of.the cattle that
qualquier que lo viesse hauria ende gran dolor & muy gran
QUALQUIER who it saw would.have from.it great pain & very great
piedad.

pity

‘and the voices of the men and of the cattle were so great loud
whoever (one wants that) would see it would have great pain and
very great pity...’

(13th c., Anonymous, *Gran Conquista*)

c. Imperative

Y Él respondióle: -*Demanda qualquier* cosa que todo lo
and he answered.him ask QUALQUIER thing that everything it
otorgaré.

will.grant

‘And He answered him: Ask anything and I will give it to you.’

(13th c., Anonymous, *Siete sabios*)

d. Infinitive

... y que hemos dicho poderse *hallar en cualquiera* de los tres
y that have said can find in CUALQUIERA of the three
estilos.

styles

‘... and of which we have said that it is possible to *find* it in *any* of
three styles’

(18th c., Luzán, *La poética*)

e. Gerund

[...] o en Yahaurpampa, donde hubo la victoria de los Chancas,
or in Yahaurpampa where was the victory of the Chancas
siendo cualquiera de aquellos dos puestos más a propósito que
being CUALQUIERA of those two sites more to appropriate than

el de Cacha [...]

the of Cacha

‘or in Yahaurpampa, where there was the victory of the Chancas, any of those two (building) sites being more appropriate than the one in Cacha...’

(16th c., Garcilaso de la Vega, *Comentarios reales*)

f. Participle

Y si de *qualquiera* passion *enpedidos* se hallan no sentencian
and if of QUALQUIERA passion hindered REFL find NEG judge
en nada fasta ver se libres.

in nothing until see REFL free

‘And if they find themselves hindered by any passion, they do not judge until they are free (from this passion).’

(15th c., Diego de San Pedro, *Cárcel*)

g. Perfect

Han triturado cualquier intento de libertad intelectual de forma
have crushed CUALQUIER attempt of freedom intellectual of form
totalmente despiadada.

totally ruthless

‘They have destroyed any attempt of intellectual liberty in a totally ruthless way.’

(20th c., Mortimer, *Entrevista (ABC)*)

The results for group F are as given in Table 5.4.

Table 5.4: CDE_cualquiera_150 occ. per century, my data

	13th	14th	15th	16th	17th	18th	19th	20th
Sentence type/mood (F)								
Subord.	146	111	122	109	96	115	98	89
Main	4	31	28	41	54	34	52	61
Decl	4	37	37	48	59	39	56	80
Q <i>que</i>	127	75	67	63	33	53	37	15
Other types	19	30	46	39	58	57	57	55
Total	150	142	150	150	150	149	150	150

In (7), I provide examples for the variables of Group F:

(7) a. Subordinate (Subord.)

& diz que pero que eran tan grandes principes *que qualquier*
 & says that but that were so great princes that QUALQUIER
 dellos manternie una huerste yl darie
 of.them would.maintain a army and=to.him would.give
 recabdo que en aquella batalla murieron daquella guisa.
 provision that in that battle died in=that manner
 ‘and it is said that because they were such important princes that *any*
 of them could maintain an army, and he would inform (them) that in
 that battle they died in that manner.’

(13th c., Afonso X, *General Estoria IV*)

b. Main

El término pájaro se aplica a *cualquier* ave con capacidad
 the term bird REFL applies to CUALQUIER bird with ability
 para volar y de pequeño tamaño.
 to fly and of small size
 ‘The term bird can be applied to *any bird* that is able to fly and small
 in size.’

(20th c., *Enc: Ave*)

c. Declarative (Decl)

El término pájaro se aplica a *cualquier* ave con capacidad
 the term bird REFL applies to CUALQUIER bird with ability
 para volar y de pequeño tamaño.
 to fly and of small size
 ‘The term bird can be applied to *any bird* that is able to fly and small
 in size.’

(20th c., *Enc: Ave*)

d. Q que

assi como que pechen omezillo / o otra pena *qualquier*
 just.as as that pay fine / or other punishment QUALQUIER
que viere el alcalde que sera guisado.
 that sees the mayor that will.be appropriate
 ‘just as they pay for homicide/ or (receive) some other punishment
 whatever the mayor sees as appropriate.’

(14th c., Anonymous, *Leyes de estilo*)

e. other types

... pero quería ser rogado, *para que* no se le imputase
 but wanted be asked for that NEG REFL to.him attributed
 jamás por traición *cualquier* siniestro acaecimiento, sino por
 ever for treason *QUALQUIER* unfortunate event but for
 desgracia
 misfortune
 ‘but he wanted to be asked (to do it), so that any unfortunate
 occurrence would ever be attributed to him for treason, but for
 misfortune.’
 (18th c., Bacallar y Sanna, *Comentarios*)

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

We can observe major quantitative differences in time with variables in almost every group in my sample, especially if we look at the frequency differences between the 13th century (1200–1300) and the 20th century (1900–2000). The following table contains variables that show a decrease in time:

- The subject function of *QUALQUIER* decreases.
- The use of bare *QUALQUIER* (bare Q) without nominal modification decreases.
- The preverbal position (QV) decreases.
- The use of *QUALQUIER* in clauses with subjunctive (Sbjv) decreases.
- The use of *QUALQUIER* in subordinated clauses decreases.
- The use of *QUALQUIER que* (Q *que*) decreases.

Figure 5.2 shows the decrease in the frequency of these variables across time visually.

Although the decrease is not linear as the frequency of some variables increases in the 15th and 17th centuries (e.g. QV decreases until 17th c., increases in the 18th c., and decreases again from the 19th c. onwards), we can see an overall decrease from the 13th to the 20th century. This overall decrease is the focus of my statistical and linguistic analysis (see Section 5.2.1 and 5.3). It should be noted at this point that the interruption of the decrease in the data in the

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

Table 5.5: Decrease of frequency in my data with respect to variables: subject, bare Q without nominal modification, preverbal, subjunctive, subordinate clause, Q *que*

Century	Occ.	Subject	bare Q	QV	Sbjv	Subord. clause	Q <i>que</i>
13th	150	94	102	134	120	146	127
	100%	62.67%	68.00%	89.33%	80.00%	97.33%	84.67%
14th	142	70	62	118	74	111	75
	100%	49.30%	43.66%	83.10%	52.11%	78.17%	52.82%
15th	150	27	33	102	66	122	67
	100%	18.00%	22.00%	68.00%	44.00%	81.33%	44.67%
16th	150	35	37	98	45	109	63
	100%	23.33%	24.67%	65.33%	30.00%	72.67%	42.00%
17th	150	32	38	83	33	96	33
	100%	21.33%	25.33%	55.33%	22.00%	64.00%	22.00%
18th	150	29	41	91	49	115	53
	100%	19.46%	27.52%	61.07%	32.89%	77.18%	35.57%
19th	149	24	55	71	51	98	37
	100%	16.00%	36.67%	47.33%	34.00%	65.33%	24.67%
20th	150	25	23	54	17	89	15
	100%	16.67%	15.33%	36.00%	11.33%	59.33%	10.00%

15th and 17th centuries coincides with the importance of the 15th and 17th centuries in the history of Spanish language, which is subdivided into the 13th, 15th, 17th, and 19th centuries (see Section 5.2.3). The changes in frequencies in these centuries in Figure 5.2 may reflect the grammatical changes in these centuries. The separated form *qual quier*, *-e*, *-a* disappears from the 16th century onwards (Pato 2012, Section 2.6) and that the 15th century can be considered the peak century when *qualquier*, *-e*, *-a* grammaticalises completely. The changes in frequency around this peak century might also reflect the grammaticalisation of *qualquier*, *-e*, *-a*. I will return to this hypothesis below when I discuss the different variables.

Let us look at some prototypical sentence from the 13th century that contains variables that decrease in their frequency in subsequent centuries.

- (8) E tan grandes eran las bozes delos hombres & del ganado que
and so great were the voice of.the men & of.the cattle that

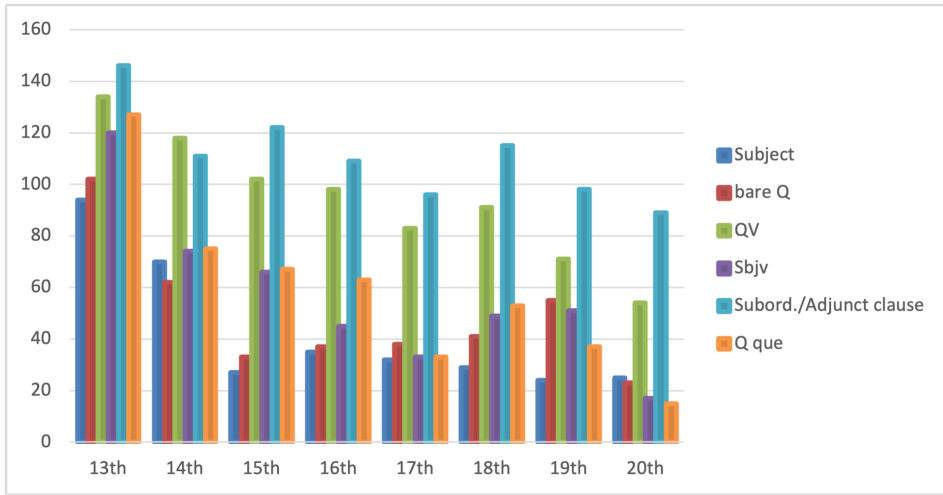


Figure 5.2: Decrease of frequency in my data with respect to the frequency of the variables: subject, bare Q without modification, preverbal, subjunctive, subordinate clause, Q *que*

qualquier que lo viesse hauria ende gran dolor & muy gran
QUALQUIER who it saw would.have hereof great pain & very great
 piedad.

pity

‘and the voices of the men and of the cattle were so great that whoever
 (one wants that) s/he sees it would have great pain and very great pity.’
 (13th c., Anonymous, *Gran Conquista*)

The example in (8) has the following structure. The relative clause *qualquier que lo viesse* is the subject of the main verbal phrase *hauria ende gran dolor & muy gran piedad* and, inside the relative clause headed by the complementiser *que*, *qualquier* is the subject of the verb *viesse*. *Qualquier* does not modify any overt noun, and it is used as a pronoun that introduces free relative clauses similar to *quien* ‘who’ or *el que* ‘(the one) who’; thus, the word order is QV. The verb *viesse* inside the relative clause is used in the subjunctive. The subjunctive has a non-veridical interpretation, that is, one that lacks the presupposition that the proposition of the sentence with subjunctive is true (see Quer 1998, 2000, Becker 2014, and Chapter 2). The subjunctive does not allow a reference to a certain event, but it includes all possible situations in which someone has seen it.

The following example is similar, with *qualquier* being used as a subject of the complement clause *que le demandaua*. The main difference between (8) and

(9) is that the verb of the complement clause is not in the subjunctive but in the indicative. The verb aspect of the complement clause is a durative aspect represented by imperfective form *demandaua*, which has a generic interpretation in this example, due not only to the imperfective but also to the generic adverb *siempre* ‘always’ (see Quer 2000, and Chapter 2 on the generic interpretation of imperfective aspect):

- (9) *siempre daua a cualquier que le demandaua.*
 always gave to CUALQUIER that him asked
 ‘He always gave it to whoever asked him. = Every time someone asked him, he gave it to him.’
 (15th c., Fernando del Pulgar, *Claros varones*)

The imperfective verb expressed in the embedded sentence in (9) has a function similar to that in (8); that is, there is no reference to a particular event of someone giving something to someone. Instead, the imperfective verb together with the generic adverb *siempre* ‘always’ expresses all possible events in the past of someone giving something to someone else when asked (see Becker 2014).

I will argue in Section 5.3 that the decrease of the subjunctive inside the relative clause is related to the degree of grammaticalisation of *QUALQUIER*. The more transparent *QUALQUIER* is as a compound containing a wh-word *qual* and the verb *querer*, the more cases we find with *QUALQUIER* *que* + *V*_[subj]. The less transparent *quier* is as a verb, the fewer cases we find of the type *cualquiera que* and for that matter, the more cases we find without the subjunctive. The abrupt fall of the subjunctive in the 14th century coincides with the decrease of the separated form *qual quier* in the 14th century and its disappearance in the 15th.

Let us now discuss other changes. *QUALQUIER* in relative clauses such as *QUALQUIER que* can only be realised in a preverbal position with respect to the embedded verb [Main clause ... (*V*_{main}) ... [*QUALQUIER que* ... *V*_{embed}] ... (*V*_{main}) ...]. This follows from the analysis of *QUALQUIER* as a specifier of a relative clause (see, e.g., (1) in this section).

Another prediction of the Grammaticalisation Hypothesis is that once the string *qual quier* is no longer analysed compositionally as a wh-word and a verb, we should observe an increase of *QUALQUIER* in sentence types other than relative clauses and the use of *QUALQUIER* with a verbal mood other than the subjunctive. This is indeed what can be observed in the data in Table 5.6, which shows that all variables (i.e. postverbal position (VQ), indicative mood and infinitives, perfective aspect, main clause, declaratives, other sentence types, QN) tend to increase in time, especially if we compare the 13th century with the 20th.

Table 5.6: Increase of frequency in my data with respect to variables: VQ, ind, inf, perf, main, decl, other sentence types, QN.

Century	Occ.	VQ	Ind	Inf	Perf	Main	Decl	Other	QN
13th	150	16	26	1	2	4	4	19	43
		10.7%	17.3%	0.7%	1.3%	2.7%	2.7%	12.7%	28.7%
14th	142	24	61	5	1	31	37	30	78
		16.9%	43.0%	3.5%	0.7%	21.8%	26.1%	21.1%	54.9%
15th	150	48	60	16	2	28	37	46	116
		32.0%	40.0%	10.7%	1.3%	18.7%	24.7%	30.7%	77.3%
16th	150	52	89	12	5	41	48	39	113
		34.7%	59.3%	8.0%	3.3%	27.3%	32.0%	26.0%	75.3%
17th	150	67	99	12	3	54	59	58	111
		44.7%	66.0%	8.0%	2.0%	36.0%	39.3%	38.7%	74.0%
18th	150	58	64	29	2	34	39	57	106
		38.7%	42.7%	19.3%	1.3%	22.7%	26.0%	38.0%	70.7%
19th	149	79	74	18	3	52	56	57	81
		53.0%	49.7%	12.1%	2.0%	34.9%	37.6%	38.3%	54.4%
20th	150	96	102	27	13	61	80	55	123
		64.0%	68.0%	18.0%	8.7%	40.7%	53.3%	36.7%	82.0%

Table 5.6 shows the increase in the frequency of these variables across time visually (Figure 5.3).

As with decreasing frequency (see Figure 5.3), the 15th and 17th centuries also stand out with respect to the increasing frequency. The frequency of QN increases strongly until the 15th century. The strong increase of QN until the 15th century can be correlated with the observation that the separated form *qual quier*, -e, -a disappears after this century (see Section 5.2.1), which can be interpreted as an indication of completed grammaticalisation. The grammaticalisation of *qual quier*, -e, -a until the 15th century correlates with the strong increase of the determiner *qualquier* from the 13th to the 15th centuries.

Other variables (e.g. main clause, VQ, and declarative sentence type) increase until the 17th century, with an interruption in the 18th. The grammaticalisation of *qualquier* correlates with the increase of different sentence types as an indefinite form no longer is a relative clause and thus no longer is restricted to a single sentence type.

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

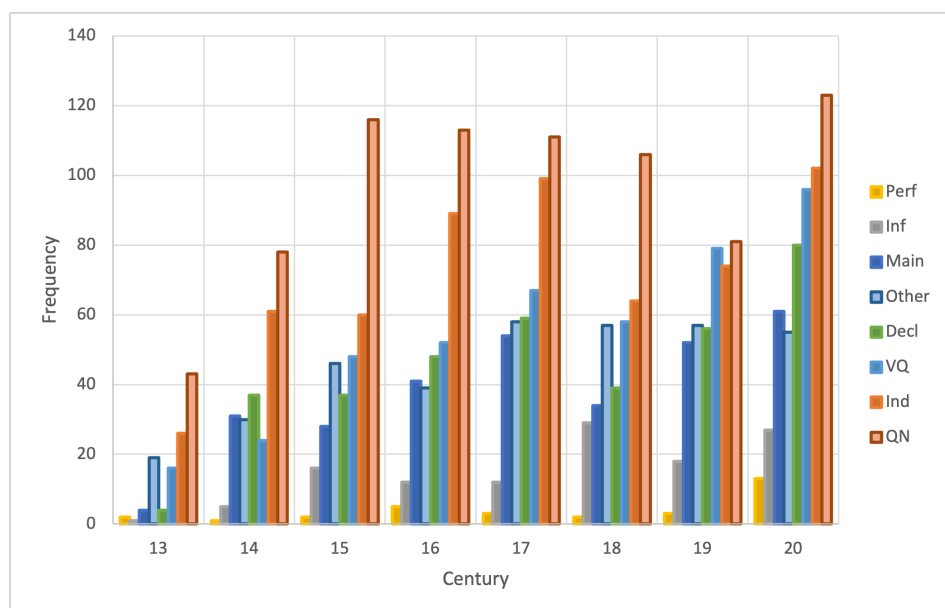


Figure 5.3: Increase of frequency in my data with respect to variables: VQ, ind, inf, perf, main, decl, other sentence types, QN.

Two prototypical examples that illustrate the increased frequency values of these variables are the following sentences with an imperative clause and a declarative clause. In both clauses, *QUALQUIER* is followed by a noun (*cosa* and *varón*, respectively, with which it forms a single constituent). It is used in postverbal position with indicative verbal mood in a main clause and not introducing a relative or complement clause from which *QUALQUIER* would be structurally dependent. Note that *qualquier cosa* in (10a). is not an argument of the verb *otorgaré* in the clause introduced by *que*, but it is the argument of the verb in the main clause:

- (10) a. Y él respondióle: *Demanda qualquier cosa que todo lo*
 and he answered.him ask *QUALQUIER* thing that everything it
 otorgaré.
 I.will.grant
 ‘Ask anything and I will give it to you.’⁷
 (13th c., Anonymous, *Siete sabios*)

⁷This *que* corresponds to what Koch & Oesterreicher (2011: 99) call the ‘polyvalent *que*’, which does not have a clearly subordinating function.

- b. Por ende bien *se* *avise* desto *qualquier* varón.
 therefore well REFL take heed of this QUALQUIER man
 ‘Therefore any man should get well informed about this.’
 (14th c., López de Ayala, *Libro rimado*)

If the frequency change of increasing variables across time in Figure 5.3 is statistically significant, something that needs still to be shown in the next section, we can conclude that the use of *cualquiera* in relative clauses became less frequent, whereas its use in main clauses became more frequent over time:

- (11) [Main Clause ...V... [QUALQUIER *que* V_[subj.]]] (most frequent in Old Sp., 13th c.)
 →[Main Clause Verb_[Indic.] QUALQUIER NP] (most frequent in 20th-century Sp.)

Let us now look at the variables more closely and test the change of frequency statistically.

5.2.1 Statistical analysis of relevant changes in my sample

This section introduces into the statistical analysis of relevant changes in my sample.

5.2.1.1 The decrease of QV order and Q *que*

Table 5.7 shows the frequencies associated with different syntactic positions of *cualquiera*. If we look at the overall frequency, it shows a continuous decrease of the preverbal position and a continuous increase of the postverbal position of QUALQUIER in every century. Looking at the frequencies in every single century, we can observe a bigger decrease between the 14th and 15th centuries. This decrease might be motivated with the overall grammatical change of early Old Spanish into late Old Spanish which is considered to be close to the Modern Spanish (see Ariza Viguera 1998, Penny 1993, among others). In particular, Old Spanish allowed several constructions of object preposing, which are, however, still attested in the 15th century, as in (14), and even in the 17th century, as in (16). By contrast, postverbal subjects have always been possible in Spanish, as in (12). Another change from early Old Spanish to late Old Spanish (Modern Spanish) is the change in the determiner system which is directly related to some of the changes we observe with QUALQUIER. The determiner system changed in

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

this period of change from late Old Spanish to early Old Spanish/Modern Spanish (Mackenzie 2019, Bartra-Kaufman 2007, Ranson 2005, Company-Company 2009b). Latinised forms became less frequent in this period (Mackenzie 2019, Ranson 2005), and bare nouns decrease (Bartra-Kaufman 2007, Company-Company 2009b). As already mentioned, the increase of determiners correlates with the increase of postnominal *QUALQUIER* with articles, which contributes to the increasing use of postnominal *QUALQUIER* as a modifier similar to adjectives.

Table 5.7: Distribution of *cualquiera* NP in preverbal (QV) or postverbal (VQ) position in my data

Century	Total	QV		VQ	
13th	150	134	89.33%	16	10.67%
14th	142	118	83.10%	24	16.90%
15th	150	102	68.00%	48	32.00%
16th	150	98	65.33%	52	34.67%
17th	150	83	55.33%	67	44.67%
18th	149	91	61.07%	58	38.93%
19th	150	71	47.33%	79	52.67%
20th	150	54	36.00%	96	64.00%

The following examples demonstrate minimal pairs (QV and VQ) in my data:

(12) 13th century

a. QV

Et *qualquiere* que les contra esto *fuesse* a el me
 and *QUALQUIERE* that to.them against this would.go to him myself
 tornaria por ello.
 would.turn for it
 ‘And I would go against whoever would be against it.’
 (Alfonso X, *Doc. Cast. – Murcia*)

b. VQ

& por la altura del polo quando *fuere* sabudo *qualquier*
 & by the height of.the pole when will.be known *QUALQUIER*
 dellos.
 of.them
 ‘and for the height of the pole, as soon as any of them is known’
 (Alfonso X, *Albateni*)

5 Diachrony of QUALQUIER revisited

(13) 14th century

a. QV

ca *qualquier* que lo faga, çierto sea de ser mal andante
for QUALQUIER that it does certain will.be of being unfortunate
ante que muera.

before he dies

‘because anyone that would do it, would be certainly unfortunate
before he dies.’

(Anonymous, *Libro del Caballero Zifar*)

b. VQ

& el señor puede a *qualquier* destos mayordomos ante que
& the lord can to QUALQUIER of-these stewards before that
se despidan del prender los & tener los presos:

REFL resign from.the seize the & hold the prisoners

‘and the lord can arrest and imprison any of these stewards before
they resign from their services to him.’

(Anonymous, *Leyes del estilo*)

(14) 15th century

a. QV

Y si de *qualquiera* *pasion* enpedidos se *hallan* no sentencian
and if of QUALQUIERA passion hindered REFL find NEG judge
en nada falta ver se libres.

in nothing lacks see REFL free

‘And if they find themselves hindered by any passion, they do not
judge until they are free (from this passion).’

(Diego de San Pedro, *Cárcel*)

b. VQ

E todos los que en aquellos tiempos vinieron ale *demandar*
and all the who in those times came to=him demand
qualquier cargo.

QUALQUIER cargo

‘and all those who, at that time, came to ask him from any (kind of)
office’

(Fernando del Pulgar, *Claros varones*)

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

(15) 16th century

a. QV

Consideraba *cualquiera* ocupación que la *podía* estorbar, [...] considered CUALQUIERA occupation that it could hinder 'I considered any activity that could bother her, ...' (Villalón, *El Crotalón*)

b. VQ

Un desconfiar de sí y un estar siempre temiendo que *podrá* a distrust of oneself and a being always fearing that could exceder al mío *cualquiera* mérito ajeno. exceed to=the mine CUALQUIERA merit foreign 'A lack of trust in oneself and a constant fear that any merit of someone else will exceed my own.' (Juana Inés de la Cruz, *Inundación Castálida*)

(16) 17th century

a. QV

De don Álvaro, por fe, *cualquier* cosa *creeré*, en razón de of Mr. Álvaro, by faith CUALQUIER cosa will believe in reason of la que vi. the that saw 'From don Álvaro, in faith, I would *believe anything*, based on what I saw.' (Castro, *Malcasados*)

b. VQ

y no *basta* *cualquiera* para mandar and NEG suffices CUALQUIERA for command 'and not anyone is appropriate to be in charge of command' (Mira de Amescua, *Examinarse de rey*)

(17) 18th century

a. QV

pues es sabido y consta a todo el mundo que *qualquier* for is known and is evident to all the world that QUALQUIER diarista es un hombre infalible y no puede engañarse en journalist is a man infallible and NEG can be mistaken in

5 Diachrony of QUALQUIER revisited

materia alguna

matter any

‘because it is known and everybody is aware of the fact that any journalist is an infallible man and cannot be fooled in any subject...’

(Forner, *Gramáticos*)

b. VQ

pues la semilla de que se forma *cualquiera* planta,

since the seed of that REFL forms CUALQUIERA plant

necesariamente vino de otra planta de la especie misma

necessarily came from another plant of the species same

‘because the seed from which any plant grows came necessarily from another plant of the same species’

(Feijoo, *Teatro crítico*)

(18) 19th century

a. QV

Cualquiera me creerá tu hermanito menor.

CUALQUIERA me will.believe your little.brother younger

‘Anybody will believe that I am your younger brother.’

(Tamayo y Baus, *No hay mal*)

b. VQ

Luego, salía, y *dirigíase* lentamente por las calles

then went.out and was.heading slowly through the streets

hacia *cualquier* café, en donde les escribía a su madre

towards CUALQUIER café, in where to.them wrote to his mother

y a la novia.

and to the girlfriend

‘Then he left, and headed slowly through the streets towards any café, where he would write to his mother and his fiancée.’

(Trigo, *En la carrera*)

(19) 20th century

a. QV

Cualquier persona puede disfrutar una biblioteca de ensueño.

CUALQUIER person can enjoy a library of dream

‘Anyone can enjoy a dream library.’

(Boo Juan Vicente, *España:ABC: CONTEXT +*)

b. VQ

Esto lo *puede* hacer *cualquiera*.
 this it can do CUALQUIERA
 ‘Anybody can do this.’
 (@ 1)

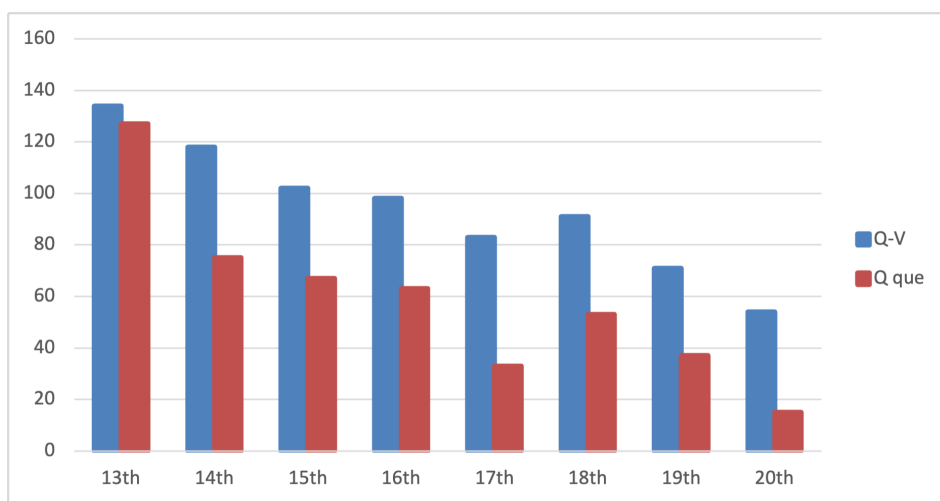
The overall decrease in the order QV is parallel to the overall decrease of the occurrence of *QUALQUIER que* as Table 5.8 shows. Looking more closely into the frequency distribution of different centuries, the decrease is drastic from the 13th to the 15th century, which might again be correlated with the grammatical change of early and late Old Spanish and the grammaticalisation of *qual quier* as discussed with respect to Figure 5.3.

Table 5.8: Distribution of *QUALQUIER que* in my data

Century	Analysed examples/occurrences (occ.)	Nr. of occ.	Rel. frequency
13th	150	127	84.67%
14th	142	75	52.82%
15th	150	67	44.67%
16th	150	63	42.00%
17th	150	33	22.00%
18th	149	53	35.57%
19th	150	37	24.67%
20th	150	15	10.00%

Figure 5.4 visualises the change in the frequency of preverbal *QUALQUIER* (QV) and *QUALQUIER que* (Q QUE) in Table 5.8.

The question is whether the overall change is statistically significant. On the null hypothesis, the differences in frequencies per century are not significant; the difference in observed values could be just a random effect of different samples. If the null hypothesis is correct, the frequencies per century should be the same as or very close to the mean. On the intuitive level, the null hypothesis is not correct due to large differences in the data. We know that the maximal frequency is 127 (13th c.) and the minimal frequency is 15 (20th c.). The mean of all frequencies per century is 59. However, the standard deviation (SD) of *QUALQUIER que* is 32, which is almost half as large as the mean, which is far too high to reflect a normal distribution of the data. The larger the number of the standard deviation, the wider the spread is of the data around the mean. The data in Table 5.8 cannot be distributed normally. This is also shown by the fact that the data in Figure 5.4

Figure 5.4: Decrease of QV and Q *que* (=QUALQUIER *que*) in my data.

does not show a bell curve comparable to that of a normal distribution (Baayen 2008).

The same difference obtains for the QV/VQ Variable. The maximal frequency is 134 (13th c.) and the minimal frequency is 54 (20th c.). The mean of all frequencies per century is 94. However, the standard deviation of QV is 24, which is far too high to reflect a normal distribution of the data. Thus, even from a descriptive level, the difference is high enough to conclude that the time or century matters for the variables *QUALQUIER que* and QV and that these two variables are correlated. The descriptive data is summarised in Table 5.9.

Table 5.9: Descriptive statistics of QV and of Q *que*

Mean		Variation (s ²)		Standard deviation (Std.)	
QV	Q <i>que</i>	QV	Q <i>que</i>	QV	Q <i>que</i>
93.875	58.75	564.375	1011.5	23.756578	31.8040878

In order to test the null hypothesis, namely that time (here: century) has no influence on the frequencies of QV and on *cualquiera* used in relative clauses (i.e. *QUALQUIER que*), I used a linear regression model as shown, in Figure 5.5 and Figure 5.6. These figures show that time plays a role in the frequencies of both constructions; that is, the use of both QV and *QUALQUIER que* changes statistically

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

significantly over time. The regression output below shows that the Century variable has a significant influence on the syntactic structure (QV) due to the t-value, which correlates to a significance value ($t = -4.68$, $p < .01$) in Figure 5.5. This shows that Century has an influence on the syntactic structure *QUALQUIER que* due to the high significance value ($t = -3.940$, $p < .01$).⁸ The output of the linear regression is given in Figure 5.6.

Coefficients :

	Estimate	Std. Error	t value	Pr(> t)	
(Intercept)	2.5804	0.4449	5.800	0.00115	**
Century	-0.4122	0.0881	-4.678	0.00340	**

Figure 5.5: The output of the linear regression from R with respect to QV.

Coefficients :

	Estimate	Std. Error	t value	Pr(> t)	
(Intercept)	2.0768	0.6924	2.999	0.02403	*
Century	-0.5402	0.1371	-3.940	0.00763	**

Figure 5.6: The output of the linear regression from R with respect to *QUALQUIER que*.

I also ran a *chi square* test of independence to examine the relation between verbal position and century. The relation between these variables was significant, χ^2 (degree of freedom = 1, 91.1854), $p < 0.00001$; that is, VQ is more likely to appear later than QV.

My results confirm the general observation about the decrease of *QUALQUIER que* in Old Spanish in the literature (Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009) on the basis of statistical tests. Additionally, I have shown that it is not only *QUALQUIER que* that decreases but also QV; and for that matter, VQ increases. In Section 5.3, we will see what consequences this change in frequency brings for the semantic interpretation of *QUALQUIER* and how this change in frequency follows from grammaticalisation.

⁸To express the result in statistical terminology, I computed a linear regression on the logit-transformed relative frequencies of QV and *QUALQUIER que* to test the null hypothesis that the variable Century has no influence on the frequency of QV and/or *QUALQUIER que*. The linear regression showed that Century has a significant influence on QV ($t = -4.68$, $p < .01$) and *QUALQUIER que* ($t = -3.940$, $p < .01$).

5.2.1.2 Frequency distribution of QN/NQ

My sample has low numbers of postnominal *QUALQUIER* (henceforth NQ) (ranging between 0 and 4 occurrences out of 150 occurrences, in every century). Recall that my data do not contain coordination and ellipsis data. As NQ appears a lot in coordination and elliptical constructions, as will be shown in Section 5.2, NQ is not sufficiently represented in my data. In order to test the change of NQ and QN including elliptical sentences and coordination, I used the whole diachronic corpus.

As we can see just by the observation of the percentage numbers of NQ and QN per every century in the figure and table below, NQ and QN have more or less the same distribution in the 13th century: around 50% (NQ having 52% and QN 48%). This frequency difference changes drastically in the 14th century, as shown in Table 5.10; that is, QN increases, whereas NQ decreases, except in the 18th and 19th centuries, where QN decreases and NQ increases. This difference in frequencies needs an explanation, which will be provided in Section 5.3.

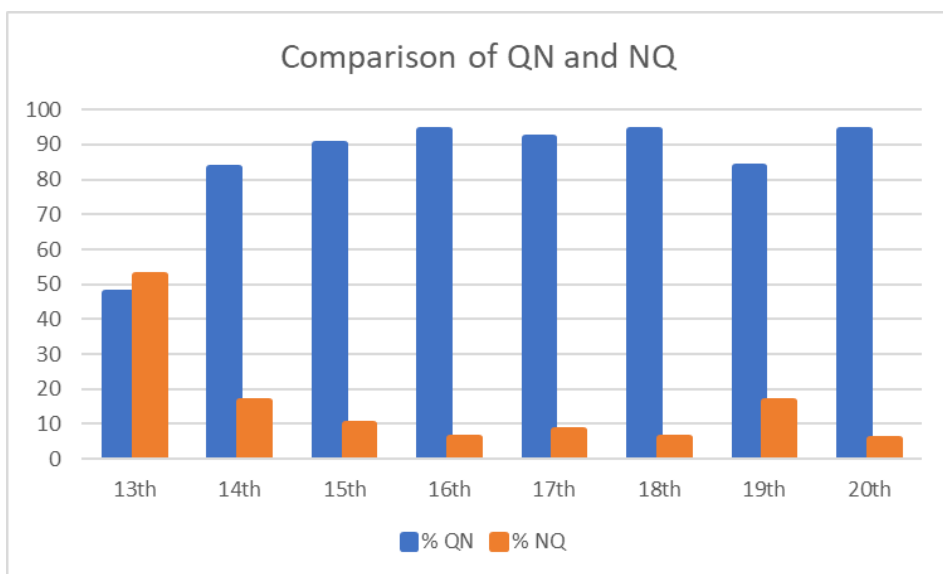


Figure 5.7: Distribution of percentages of QN/NQ per century in CdE

I can thus summarise that, according to the data from CdE, QN increased in time, whereas NQ decreased and there is a big jump in decrease of NQ or increase of QN in the 14th century. This big jump correlates with many other linguistic changes in this time interval of Old Spanish (see Eberenz 2009, among others).

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

Table 5.10: QN (= *ualqu* _N*) and NQ (_N* *ualqu*) in the whole CdE (Mar. 2020).

	13th	14th	15th	16th	17th	18th	19th	20th
QUALQUIER N in %	48	83	90	94	92	94	84	94
QUALQUIER N absolute	168	106	1,090	3,514	2,026	2,435	2,769	5,542
N QUALQUIER in %	52	17	10	6	8	6	16	6
N QUALQUIER absolute	185	21	118	222	177	151	544	337
Total	353	127	1,208	3,736	2,203	2,586	3,313	5,879

- (20) a. N QUALQUIER (the most frequent form in the 13th c., the least frequent in the 19th c.)
b. QUALQUIER N (the less frequent form in the 13th c., the most frequent in the 19th c.)

In Section 5.3, I will explain this change in frequency of QN/NQ in terms of a linguistic change whereby QUALQUIER changes its syntactic status from the specifier of a relative clause to a noun modifier (NQ) similar to an adjective (N Adj) and then to a quantificational determiner (QN) similar to *algún* N.

In the next section, I will look into (*otro*) NQ in the whole corpus in more detail.

5.2.2 The change from (*otro*) NQ to *un* NQ and Def NQ

We will now analyse NQ more closely from the whole corpus (see Section 5.2.1 for the frequency of NQ in total). Until the 14th century, the word order NQ appears very often in coordination with *o* ‘or’ with nouns preceded by the term *otro* ‘other’. The majority of the occurrences of the sequence *o otro* NQ *que* (120 occ. with complement clauses introduced by *que* of a total of 196 occurrences of *o otro* NQ, i.e. 61.22%):

- (21) a. *firiendo en ella con piedra, o con cuchillo o con otra cosa*
wounding in her with stone or with knife or with other thing
qualquier
QUALQUIER
‘damaging it [i.e. the Cross] with a stone, or with a knife or with some other thing whatsoever’
(13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete Partidas*)

Table 5.11: Distribution of [otr* N *ualqu*]

Century	Frequency	Per mil
ALL	291	2.91
1200s	163	24.27
1300s	8	3.00
1400s	16	1.96
1500s	16	0.94
1600s	4	0.32
1700s	20	2.04
1800s	52	2.69
1900s	6	0.26
ACAD	2	0.40
NEWS	1	0.20
FICT	2	0.42
ORAL	1	0.24
ALL	2436	24.36

Table 5.12: Distribution of [o otr* N *ualqu*]

Century	Frequency	Per mil
ALL	60	0.60
1200s	52	7.74
1300s	4	1.50
1400s	2	0.25
1500s	0	0.00
1600s	0	0.00
1700s	2	0.20
1800s	0	0.00
1900s	0	0.00
ACAD	0	0.00
NEWS	0	0.00
FICT	0	0.00
ORAL	0	0.00
ALL	60	0.60

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

- b. o *otra* *manera qualquier* que le diese ayuda asabiendas
 or another way *QUALQUIER* that to.him gave help knowingly
 que fuese semeiante o *otra cosa qualquier* que sea
 that it.was similar or another thing *QUALQUIER* that is
 ‘or [providing help to a thief in] some other way whatsoever that
 would be of help, knowing full well that it is similar [to the
 above-mentioned things] or any other thing whatever it may be’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete Partidas*)
- c. o de *otra razon qualquier* que sea
 or of another reason *QUALQUIER* that is
 ‘or for some other reason whatever it may be’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete Partidas*)

From the 14th century onwards, there are more cases without relative clause modification, which is expected given that relative clause modification decreased in general:

- (22) a. [...] sea debajo de la equinoccial o en *otra parte cualquiera*» A
 is below of the equinoctial or in another part *CUALQUIERA* to
 este propósito, trae Celio Rodiginio lo de Arriano, historiador
 this purpose brings Celio Rodiginio what of Arriano historian
 griego
 Greek
 ‘... be it under the equatorial line or in any other place” On this
 subject, Celio Rodiginio brings up what was said by Arriano, a Greek
 historian’
 (16th c., Torquemada, *Jardín*)
- b. secretamente enlazado en el amor de alguna criatura, sea persona,
 secretly linked in the love of some creature is person
 sea *otra cosa cualquiera*
 is another thing *CUALQUIERA*
 ‘secretely bound in the love of some creature, be it a person, be it any
 other thing’
 (16th c., Fray Luís de Granada, *Guía de pecadores*)

All examples of *otro* N Q, independently of the century, have an FCI interpretation (‘other N whichever one wants’). This observation is not surprising given that *otro* N makes reference to the preceding alternatives that all belong to the

same class of entities denoted by the noun N (compare English ‘fork, knife, or other utensil’), and the function of postnominal QUALQUIER is to express another alternative that can have any identity or be of any type as long as it belongs to the same class of entities or types denoted by N.

Looking into the issue of whether elements other than *otro* can precede the NQ sequence, we find that there are also examples of N QUALQUIER with nouns that occur with a determiner. There are very few examples with the indefinite article, of the form of *un/una N qual quier,-e,-a* with the separated spelling *qual quier,-e,-a* in contrast to *otro N qual quier* in the 14th c. (0.30 per mil vs. 37.67 per mil):

- (23) a. ... Desi dixo domjngujllo que le diese el Rey vn omne qual
since said Domjngujllo than to.him gave the King a man QUAL
quier a que le firiase e quando le oujese
QUIER to whom to.him wounded and when to.him had.heard
ferido que se yrie para el castillo
wounded that he would.go to the castle
‘Then Dominguillo said that the King should give him a man
which(ever) one wants whom he could hurt, and after hurting him, he
would go to the castle.’
(14th c., Anonymous, *Veinte Reyes*)
- b. ...en un logar qual quier dela posada.
in a place QUAL QUIER of.the inn
‘...at any place in the house.’
(13th c., Moamyn, *Animalias*)

The synthetic form QUALQUIER in UN N QUALQUIER appears in the 16th century in its modern spelling with *cu-* (with total of 2 occ. in this century in the whole corpus). There is no synthetic form of UN N QUALQUIER with *qu-* in the whole corpus (only a separated form, as shown in 295). In these examples, *cualquiera* is interpreted as an FCI due to the generic context in which *cualquiera* is used (see Chapter 2 on the licensing of FCIs in generic contexts):

- (24) resulta difícil el destacar en una ciencia cualquiera, cuánto más
results difficult to stand.out in a science CUALQUIERA how.much more
en la filosofía
in the philosophy
‘it turns out to be difficult to stand out in *any science*, even more so in
philosophy’
(16th c., Sepúlveda, *Epistolario*)

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

- (25) que con tanto más entusiasmo nos dedicamos a *un trabajo*
 that with so.much more enthusiasm we dedicate ourselves to a work
cualquiera, cuanto más nos agrada el hacerlo.
 CUALQUIERA how.much more we like it do.it
 ‘We dedicate ourselves to *any kind of job* with the more enthusiasm, the
 more we like to do it.’
 (16th c., Sepúlveda, *Epistolario*)

The use of the construction UN N *cualquiera* increases in time in the whole corpus as shown in Table 5.15, and it has an ambiguous interpretation between the FCI interpretation (‘any’) and the evaluative interpretation (‘an ordinary’) (see Chapter 3 for the ambiguity of different interpretations of *cualquiera* in 20th/21st-century Spanish).

Table 5.13: Distribution of Indefinite Article N **ualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	0	7.9	0.00
1300s	0	3.0	0.00
1400s	1	9.7	0.12
1500s	12	19.7	0.70
1600s	6	14.8	0.49
1700s	9	11.5	0.92
1800s	357	23.1	18.50
1900s	169	22.8	7.41
ACAD	19	5.0	3.80
NEWS	14	5.0	2.82
FICT	106	4.8	22.22
ORAL	30	4.2	7.09
ALL	723	100	7.23

There is a single example of bare N **ualq** under negation in the whole corpus (0 occ. from 13th to 15th c., 1 occ. in 16th c., 0 occ. in 17th, 18thc. and 19th. c.). In this example, N **ualqu** is used under negation with the verb ‘be’ under indicative verbal mood in the present tense with an evaluative interpretation, which is expressed in the context by the contrast between N **ualqu** and *gran caudal*

‘major impact’, which triggers the interpretation of *daño cualquiera* as ‘ordinary damage’ or ‘damage of low impact’.

- (26) a. [...], el cual no es daño *cualquiera*, sino de gran caudal.
the which NEG is damage *CUALQUIERA* but of great amount
‘which is not *an ordinary damage* (EVAL), but one of major impact.’
(16th c., El Crotalón, @ 285)

The construction indefinite article N **ualq** is also infrequent under negation per century with the exception of 19th c. where it gets more frequent (0 occ. from 13th to 16th c., 2 occ. in 17th c. (=0.16 per mil) and 18th c. (=0.10 per mil) and 10 occ. in 19th c. (=0.44 per mil)). In the first example in the 17th c., **ualqu** is used under negation with an indicative present tense verb. The examples in (27) show generic contexts with the indicative present and also have an ambiguous interpretation of ‘any’ or ‘ordinary’:

- (27) a. Para pedir campo a un rey no basta *un hombre*
to ask.for ground from a king NEG is.enough a man
cualquiera, que según la ley del duelo es menester que
CUALQUIERA that according.to the law of.the duel is necessary that
rey sea.
kind be
‘In order to challenge a king, it is not sufficient to be *an ordinary man* (EVAL), as according to the duelling law he has to be a king himself.’
‘In order to challenge a king, it is not sufficient to be *just any man* (FCI), as according to the duelling law he has to be a king himself.’
(17th c., Anonymous, *El rey don Alfonso*)
- b. Quien se huelga de parecerle discreto a *un hombre*
who REFL delights in seeming.to.him discreet to a man
cualquiera, ¿cómo piensa que trata a Dios cuando no se
CUALQUIERA how thinks that treats to God when NEG REFL
le da nada de no parecerle discreto?
to.him is.given nothing of NEG seeming.to.him discreet
‘Someone who likes to be seen as discreet by *any man* (FCI), how does he think he treats God when he doesn’t receive anything for not being seen by him as discreet?’
‘Someone who likes to be seen as discreet by *an ordinary man* (EVAL), how does he think he treats God when he doesn’t receive anything for not being seen by him as discreet?’
(17th c., Zabaleta, *El día de fiesta, primera parte*)

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- c. Para instruirse en el idioma de la medicina y comer sus
to learn in the language of the medicine and eat its
aforismos basta un curso cualquiera.
aphorisms is.enough a course CUALQUIERA
'in order to learn the language of medicine and to eat its aphorisms,
any course (FCI)/an ordinary course (EVAL) is sufficient.' (1732, *Vida*,
Torres Villarroel)
(17th c., Zabaleta, *El día de fiesta, primera parte*)

From this time onwards, UN N *cualquiera* is used as EVAL or FCI depending on the context as in present-day Spanish (see Chapter 3). In the following example, *un alojamiento cualquiera* can be interpreted as FCI 'any accomodation' or as 'a normal accomodation' excluding 'abnormal' or 'unlivable' accomodations:

- (28) En esta perplejidad escribo al administrador del conde de
in this perplexity write to.the administrator of=the count of
Peñalba, encargándole que me busque un alojamiento
Peñalba entrusting=him that to.me find a accomodation
cualquiera de acuerdo con usted,
CUALQUIERA in accordance with you
'I'm writing in this perplexity to the administrator of the Count of
Peñalba, charging him to find me some accomodation in accordance with
you, ...'
(18th c., Jovellanos, *Correspondencia*)

The first examples of UN N *cualquiera* in affirmative predicative contexts appeared in the 19th century:

- (29) Es un contrato cualquiera. vos necesitáis dinero, yo os necesito,
is a contract CUALQUIERA you need money I you need
'It's a usual contract: you need money, I need you, ...'
(19th c., Zorrilla, *Entre clérigos y diablos*)

The use of N *cualquiera* with definite articles or demonstratives such *la, el, esta, este, aquel* N (Def N *cualquiera*) is less frequent than the use of *un/otro* N *cualquiera* (less than 5% of all occurrences) and also appears only in the 19th century (see Chapter 3 for present-day Spanish). An explanation of the late appearance of Def N *cualquiera* will be given in Section 5.3. All examples of Def N *cualquiera* have an evaluative interpretation of 'common/ordinary' (see also Chapter 3 for Modern Spanish):

- (30) La cuestión empezó *ese día cualquiera* del siglo XVI, en que
 the question started that day CUALQUIERA of the century XVI in which
 don Felipe II decretó que los españoles no podrían estudiar en
 Don Felipe II decreed that the Spaniards NEG could study in
 Universidades extranjeras.
 universities foreign
 ‘the problem began on this ordinary day of the 16th century, when Don
 Felipe decreed, that Spaniards could not study at foreign universities.’
 (20th c., Ballester, *Torre Del Aire*)

Given these observations, it is now possible to explain the rise of NQ in the 18th and 19th centuries observed in Section 5.2.1.2. The introduction of the new semantic meaning of UN NQ ‘an ordinary N’ correlates with the introduction of new syntactic constructions: the use of UN NQ under affirmative predicative contexts and the use of NQ under definite articles. These new forms and the new meaning have triggered the increase in frequency of NQ in the 18th and 19th centuries. As the construction (*otro*) NQ practically disappeared in the 19th century and Q(*otro*)N was used instead (Table 5.7), this explains the trend of the general fall of NQ after the 14th century (see Section 5.2.1.2).

As noted above, there is a renewed decrease of postnominal QUALQUIER from the 18th to 19th century, although the relative frequency of postnominal CUALQUIERA in 19th c. is still higher than the relative frequency of postnominal QUALQUIER before the 18th century (see Table 5.2 in my sample and Table 5.15 in the whole corpus). If the renewed decrease were an effect of random sampling in my sample in Table 5.2, we would not see the same effect appearing in the whole corpus (see Table 5.15). This effect might be triggered by the differences in the selection of text genre in 18th and 19th c. The 19th c. has a more nuanced text genre constellation: academic texts, news, fiction and texts representing oral speech. Indeed, Table 5.18 shows that the highest distribution of postnominal QUALQUIER is in the genres fiction and oral texts. I thus expect the decrease to disappear or to be less strong if the genre is more controlled in the diachronic study. How genre affects diachronic change of QUALQUIER will be tested in future research.

To sum up the development of N *cualquiera* (bold letters represent higher frequency). It represents a change in different constructions with N *cualquiera*. It shows that the construction *otro/otra* QUALQUIER (*que* Verb_{Subj.}) was first used in the 13th century until the 15th. The construction UN N *cualquiera* appeared in the 15th century and the older construction disappeared. From the 19th century

onwards, UN N *cualquiera* was used in predicative position. Fewer data of N *cualquiera* contain a definite or demonstrative *la/el/este/esta* N *cualquiera*:

Table 5.14: Historical development of *cualquiera*

13th–15th c.	<i>otro, a</i> QUALQUIER <i>que</i> Verb _{Subj.}
15th c.–today	(Verb _{Ind.}) UN N <i>cualquiera</i> (Verb _{Ind.})
19th c.–today	<i>la, el, este, esta</i> N <i>cualquiera</i> [predicative] Verb _{Ind.} UN N <i>cualquiera</i>

The distribution in Table 5.14 co-occurs with a semantic distribution given the observation that *otro* NQ can only have FCI due to preceding alternatives, whereas *un* NQ is ambiguous between two interpretations (FCI/EVAL) depending on the verbal mood (+/– modal) and Def NQ has only the interpretation of EVAL:

- (31) *otro, a* N QUALQUIER QUE ...FCI (13th–15th c.)
 UN N *cualquiera* FCI/EVAL (from the 16th c. until today)
la, el, este, esta N *cualquiera* EVAL (from the 19th c. until today)

As I will argue in Section 5.3, the preference for UN N *cualquiera* over (*otro*) N *qual quiera* rising and later the appearance of Def N *cualquiera* is the result of the reanalysis of *cualquiera* from an item introducing a relative clause with FCI into a synthetic nominal modifier with different lexical meanings (FCI and EVAL). The relevant diachronic steps of postnominal *cualquiera* in European Spanish that have triggered EVAL are summarised as follows:

1. Use of postnominal *cualquiera* often after *otro* ‘other’ + N with a complement clause after *quier* expressed by *que* ‘that’ and a selected subjunctive (e.g. *qual quier que sea*) with modal interpretation ‘whichever one wants that it may be’ in 13th century Old Spanish:

- (32) *e.g. o de otra razon qualquier que sea*
 or of another reason QUALQUIER that may.be
 ‘or for some other reason whichever one wants that it may be’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete Partidas*)

Use of nouns between *qual* and *quier*, which show that *qual quier* could be analysed compositionally in 13th century (Pato 2012):

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- (33) e.g. [...] en qual manera quier que sean
in which manner wants that be-subj
'in whatever manner'
(13th c., Alfonso X, *Libro de las cruces*)

2. Recategorisation of postnominal *cualquiera* as one word, the compositional meaning of the relative clause ('which one wants') is no longer expressed as a sentence but as a single lexical meaning 'any'. Empirical evidence:
 - a) disappearance of *qual NP quier*,
 - b) orthographic non-separated form *qualquier* increases,
 - c) decrease of complement clause after *quier* and selected subjunctive: *qual quier que*,
 - d) increasing use of postnominal *cualquiera* with an indefinite N as in *UN N cualquiera*.
3. Use of *cualquiera* in predicative and postnominal position under negation (e.g. *no es un día cualquiera, es un día especial* 'it's not an ordinary day, it's a special day') (in 16th c. in European Spanish).
4. Increase of copular predicates without negation in present and past tense (e.g. *es un día cualquiera* 'it's an ordinary day') (from 18th c. in European Spanish).
5. Extension of the use of *UN N+ cualquiera* to definite articles + N *cualquiera* and quantified nouns as in *la/mucha gente cualquiera* 'the/many ordinary people' (in European Spanish in the 20th century).

5.2.3 Summing up and evaluating the results

It has been shown that the frequency of some variables increased, such as postverbal *cualquiera* (VQ), sentence types other than relative clauses, the verb mood indicative and QN. Moreover, UN N CUALQUIER came into existence in later centuries (Table 5.15).

The main results suggest that QUALQUIER has undergone some changes which correlate with syntactic position and verbal mood/type and (in)definiteness of the NP.

As was shown in Section 2.6, no quantitative analysis had been done so far on the variables described in Section 5.2, namely the syntactic function of QUALQUIER, its relation to the verb (position and mood), and its relation to the

Table 5.15: Syntactic and semantic changes related to *QUALQUIER*

In early centuries (12th–13th c.)
NQ is more frequent than QN. Q <i>que</i> is more frequent than other sentence types. Subjunctive is more frequent than indicative. UN N <i>QUALQUIER</i> with indicative did not exist yet. <i>QUALQUIER</i> is only interpretable as FCI.
In later centuries (19th–20th c.)
QN is more frequent than NQ. Q <i>que</i> is less frequent than other sentence types. Indicative is more frequent than subjunctive. UN N <i>QUALQUIER</i> with indicative verbal mood appears. <i>QUALQUIER</i> has different meanings (FCI, EVAL).

sentence mood. I have also shown when exactly new constructions UN/Def N *QUALQUIER* appear for the first time, and I have quantified them. The construction UN N *QUALQUIER* appears already in the 13th century, but it is used very infrequently in contrast to *otro* N *QUALQUIER*. In later centuries, UN N *QUALQUIER* starts being used more frequently (from the 18th c. onwards). The construction Def N *QUALQUIER* is a recent phenomenon (from the 19th c. onwards) which is still less frequent than UN N *QUALQUIER*. I have identified the time interval when the meanings of *QUALQUIER* started to change, namely from the 16th century.

I will use these results to investigate the meaning changes of *QUALQUIER*. Before turning to the semantic side of linguistic changes, I will check whether the described linguistic changes as represented in my sample exist in the whole corpus if we ignore factors like the philological reliability of certain texts and manual tagging of examples.

5.2.4 Quantitative results in the whole corpus

The changes related to *QUALQUIER* as represented in the whole corpus can be summarised as follows.

- The use of the orthographic variant *QUALQUIER* decreases and the use of *CUALQUIER* increases (see Table 5.16 and Table 5.17)

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- Prenominal QUALQUIER (QN) increases (see Table 5.18) and NQ without an article [bare N Q] decreases (see Table 5.19).
- The use of bare QUALQUIER (bare Q) without nominal modification and the use of QUALQUIER *que* (Q *que*) decreases (see Table 5.20).
- the postverbal position increases (VQ) increases (see Table 5.21, Table 5.22 and Table 5.23)
- the use of QUALQUIER under predicative verbs like *be* increases (see Table 5.26)
- the use of QUALQUIER indicative verbal mood increases (see Table 5.24)
- the use of postnominal QUALQUIER in the 20th c. is clearly related to the genre (fictional and oral texts) (see the higher distribution of fictional and oral texts in comparison to other genres in Table 5.21, Table 5.21, Table 5.22, Table 5.23)

Table 5.16: Distribution of *qualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	1008	7.9	150.10
1300s	213	3.0	79.79
1400s	1688	9.7	206.83
1500s	782	19.7	45.91
1600s	234	14.8	18.95
1700s	436	11.5	44.41
1800s	27	23.1	1.40
1900s	2	22.8	0.09
ACAD	0	5.0	0.00
NEWS	0	5.0	0.00
FICT	0	4.8	0.00
ORAL	2	4.2	0.47
ALL	4392	100	43.92

To sum up, the distribution of the linguistic variables considered in the whole corpus matches the distribution of the same variables in my sample.

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

Table 5.17: Distribution of *cualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	2	7.9	0.30
1300s	3	3.0	1.12
1400s	171	9.7	20.95
1500s	4799	19.7	281.73
1600s	2691	14.8	217.93
1700s	3611	11.5	367.84
1800s	5611	23.1	290.77
1900s	7738	22.8	339.05
ACAD	1611	5.0	322.20
NEWS	1787	5.0	360.01
FICT	2176	4.8	456.20
ORAL	2164	4.2	511.21
ALL	32364	100	323.64

Table 5.18: Distribution of N *UALQU* in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	501	7.9	74.60
1300s	40	3.0	14.98
1400s	176	9.7	21.56
1500s	330	19.7	19.37
1600s	175	14.8	14.17
1700s	335	11.5	34.13
1800s	527	23.1	27.31
1900s	176	22.8	7.71
ACAD	30	5.0	6.00
NEWS	48	5.0	9.67
FICT	43	4.8	9.01
ORAL	55	4.2	12.99
ALL	2436	100	24.36

Table 5.19: Distribution of *ualqu* N in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	168	7.9	25.02
1300s	106	3.0	39.71
1400s	1090	9.7	133.56
1500s	3514	19.7	206.29
1600s	2026	14.8	164.07
1700s	2435	11.5	248.05
1800s	2769	23.1	143.49
1900s	5542	22.8	242.83
ACAD	1203	5.0	240.60
NEWS	1386	5.0	279.22
FICT	1412	4.8	296.02
ORAL	1541	4.2	364.04
ALL	23192	100	231.92

Table 5.20: Distribution of *ualqu* que in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	501	7.9	74.60
1300s	40	3.0	14.98
1400s	176	9.7	21.56
1500s	330	19.7	19.37
1600s	175	14.8	14.17
1700s	335	11.5	34.13
1800s	527	23.1	27.31
1900s	176	22.8	7.71
ACAD	30	5.0	6.00
NEWS	48	5.0	9.67
FICT	43	4.8	9.01
ORAL	55	4.2	12.99
ALL	2436	100	24.36

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

Table 5.21: Distribution of Article N **ualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	2	7.9	0.30
1300s	1	3.0	0.37
1400s	18	9.7	2.21
1500s	40	19.7	2.35
1600s	36	14.8	2.92
1700s	29	11.5	2.95
1800s	380	23.1	19.69
1900s	197	22.8	8.63
ACAD	21	5.0	4.20
NEWS	19	5.0	3.83
FICT	119	4.8	24.95
ORAL	38	4.2	8.98
ALL	900	100	9.00

Table 5.22: Distribution of Indefinite Article N **ualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	0	7.9	0.00
1300s	0	3.0	0.12
1400s	1	9.7	0.70
1500s	12	19.7	0.49
1600s	6	14.8	0.92
1700s	9	11.5	18.50
1800s	357	23.1	7.41
1900s	169	22.8	3.80
ACAD	19	5.0	2.82
NEWS	14	5.0	22.22
FICT	106	4.8	7.09
ORAL	30	4.2	7.09
ALL	723	100	7.23

Table 5.23: Distribution of Verb Indefinite Article N **ualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	0	7.9	0.00
1300s	0	3.0	0.00
1400s	0	9.7	0.00
1500s	1	19.7	0.06
1600s	1	14.8	0.08
1700s	2	11.5	0.20
1800s	43	23.1	2.23
1900s	35	22.8	1.53
ACAD	3	5.0	0.60
NEWS	2	5.0	0.40
FICT	22	4.8	4.61
ORAL	8	4.2	1.89
ALL	117	100	1.17

Table 5.24: Distribution of Present Tense Verb Indefinite Article N **ualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	0	7.9	0.00
1300s	0	3.0	0.00
1400s	0	9.7	0.00
1500s	0	19.7	0.00
1600s	1	14.8	0.08
1700s	2	11.5	0.20
1800s	14	23.1	0.73
1900s	12	22.8	0.53
ACAD	1	5.0	0.20
NEWS	2	5.0	0.40
FICT	3	4.8	0.63
ORAL	6	4.2	1.42
ALL	41	100	0.41

5.2 Quantitative description of the results in my sample

Table 5.25: Distribution of *Indefinido* Indefinite Article N **ualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	0	7.9	0.00
1300s	0	3.0	0.00
1400s	0	9.7	0.00
1500s	0	19.7	0.00
1600s	0	14.8	0.00
1700s	0	11.5	0.00
1800s	0	23.1	0.00
1900s	3	22.8	0.13
ACAD	0	5.0	0.00
NEWS	0	5.0	0.00
FICT	3	4.8	0.63
ORAL	0	4.2	0.00
ALL	6	100	0.06

Table 5.26: Distribution of the verb *be* Indefinite Article N **ualqu** in the whole corpus

Century	Frequency	Words (m)	Per mil
1200s	0	7.9	0.00
1300s	0	3.0	0.00
1400s	0	9.7	0.00
1500s	1	19.7	0.06
1600s	0	14.8	0.00
1700s	0	11.5	0.00
1800s	5	23.1	0.26
1900s	23	22.8	1.0
ACAD	2	5.0	0.40
NEWS	4	5.0	0.81
FICT	10	4.8	2.10
ORAL	7	4.2	1.65
ALL	52	100	0.52

5.3 The semantic side of the grammaticalisation

In this section, I will spell out the change from a relative clause into a quantificational pronoun and determiner from the semantic point of view. The change into a postnominal modifier will be discussed as well.

5.3.1 The prenominal determiner

I assume that the determiner/pronoun *qualquier* has its origin in the relative clause and that it is the quantificational interpretation of a free relative clause such as *qual quier(e) que* that triggers the reanalysis into a quantificational determiner. I will first illustrate this assumption with the interpretation of a relative clause with a free choice interpretation in Modern Spanish and then apply the semantic interpretation to Old Spanish. As (34) shows, free relative clauses can be replaced by a universal quantificational pronoun ‘everyone’:

- (34) a. Puedes invitar a quien tú quieras.
 can invite to whom you want
 ‘You can invite whom you want (to invite).’
 b. Puedes invitar a todos (los que tú quieras invitar)
 can invite to all (the that you want invite)
 ‘You can invite everyone (you want to invite).’

I adopt the denotation of English Free Relatives (FRs) in English (see Šimík 2020) to (FRs) in Spanish. The truth-conditions of (34) are provided in (35).

- (35) a. $\llbracket \text{quien tu quieras invitar} \rrbracket = \lambda P. \forall x [\text{want}'(x)(\text{you}') \rightarrow P(x)]$
 (the set of properties that all people that you want to invite)
 b. $\llbracket (305) \rrbracket = 1$ iff
 $\forall x [\text{want}'(x)(\text{you}')(\text{invite}')] \rightarrow \text{can}(\text{invite}'(x)(\text{you}))$
 For all people you want to invite, you can invite them.

Free relatives can thus be analysed as DPs which can be modelled by the insertion of a covert DP with the definite interpretation ‘the NP that’ or universal interpretation (‘everyone’) depending on the verb mood above the relative clause structure; free relatives embedded under modal verbs usually have a universal interpretation:

- (36) Puedes invitar [_{DP} a todos [_{CP} a⁹ quien tú quieras]]
 ‘you can invite everyone you want’

It is thus possible to analyse free relatives in Old Spanish as DPs under the assumption that empty syntactic categories correlate with certain semantic interpretations (see also Rivero 1988):

- (37) [_{Spec, TP} [_{DP} D° ‘everyone’] [_{CP1} qual_j TP₁ pro T° quier [_{CP2} t_j que TP₂ pro T° lo viesse t_j]]] T° hauria ende gran dolor].
 ‘...who one wants that had seen it, would have had great pain and a lot of pity.’
 (13th c., Anonymous, *Gran Conquista*)

Once *qual quier* lost its transparent relative clause structure, it was reanalysed as a determiner D° or a pronoun DP and filled the empty DP in an earlier stage (see Section 5.3.1):

- (38) [_{TP} [_{DP} [_{CP} qual quier que lo viesse]] T° hauria ende gran dolor].
 [_{TP} [_{DP} qualquier (NP)] T° hauria ende gran dolor].
 (my example for demonstration)

Let us now see how the syntactic change was interpreted semantically. A compositional analysis of Old Spanish example in (38) is presented in (39). I assume that in Old Sp. *qual quier* means something like ‘which(ever) one wants (to choose)’. I underline the interpretation of the verb *quier* and discuss it below in detail. The interpretation is derived step by step. First the relative clause is interpreted as an open proposition due to the wh-feature of *qual* and the clause structure (CP) in (39a), then the relative clause is interpreted as a nominal modifier, that is, as a property of the noun N in (39b), then the DP is interpreted as universal quantification in (39c). The truth conditions of the sentence in which the DP occurs are spelled out in (39).

- (39) a. $\llbracket [\text{CP } \text{qualquier que lo viesse}] \rrbracket =$
 would see it (x) $\wedge$ one wants to choose (x) *open proposition*
 b. $\llbracket [\text{NP } \emptyset \text{ ‘person’ } [\text{CP } \text{qualquier que lo viesse}]] \rrbracket =$
 $\lambda x[\text{person}(x) \wedge \text{would see it}(x) \wedge \text{one wants to choose}(x)]$ *property*

⁹I assume that *a* is not a preposition but a case marker that belongs to the DP (see López 2009, among others).

- c. $\llbracket [\text{DP } [\text{NP } [\text{CP } \text{qualquier que lo viesse}]]] \rrbracket =$
 $\lambda P. \forall x [\text{person}(x) \wedge \text{one wants to choose}(x) \wedge \text{would see it}(x) \wedge P(x)]$
universal quantifier
- d. $\llbracket \text{qualquier que lo viesse hauria ende gran dolor} \rrbracket = 1$ if would have
 had' ($\forall x [\text{person}(x) \wedge \text{one wants to choose}(x) \wedge \text{would see him}(x)]$)
 (great pain)
 Prose: For every person x that one wants to choose and that would
 see it, x would have great pain.

I will now discuss the semantics of *qual quier* under the transparent meaning of the verb *quiere* and the subject *pro* at Stage 1 of the relative clause analysis. The most important question is whether this meaning is part of the truth conditions of the statement in (39). I assume that it is not; that is, the open proposition x *would have great pain* is true independently of the value one chooses for x . In other words, facts in the real world are independent of belief states. Thus, the statement *Any even number (wich-ever one wants to choose) can be divided by 2* is true independent of whether someone wants to choose 4, 6, 8, etc. We can analyse the literal meaning of *qual quier* rather as a side comment on the part of the speaker about the variable x , similar to appositive relative clauses as in *My colleague (who is a nice guy) moved to Germany*. This side comment can be interpreted as a different illocution from the truth-conditional statement, namely as an invitation of the speaker to the addressee to choose any value for x . In this case, *pro* is interpreted as a pronominal form of the addressee, as in *pro quisieres* 'you (informal) would like' in (40). Note that in the example (40) *qual quisieres* interrupts the sentence *pon una estrella fixa por su longura*, which confirms the side comment analysis of *qual quisieres*:

- (40) damos te ejemplo a esto. pon una estrella fixa *qual quisieres* por su
 give you example to this put a star fixed as wish for its
 longura del equador con el grado con que passa medio
 length of.the equator with the degreee with which crosses halfway
 cielo.
 sky
 'We are giving you an example of this. Put a fixed star (whichever you
 want) along the equator in an angle such that it passes through the
 middle of the sky.
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Astronomía*)

5.3 The semantic side of the grammaticalisation

The form *qual quisier** becomes less frequent in the 14th and 15th centuries and disappears completely in the 16th century. This is expected with the decrease of transparency of this variant of the construction.

In more formal texts, such as legal texts, where the addressee represents the general public or the reader of the law such as the context of (40), the form *qual quisieres* ‘which you (informal) want’ cannot be used. The subject *pro* in (40) refers to the general public and the legal statement is true no matter which value the general public wants to choose for *x*, where *x* represents a person such that if *x* saw it, *x* would have great pain. According to the impersonal interpretation of *pro*, it is guaranteed that the set of possible values for *x* is defined as large as possible (i.e. it contains all possible people the public can think of choosing for *x*). One direct consequence of this analysis of *qual quier* as a side comment is that one should be able to find two verbs of *querer*, one inside the proposition that has an effect on the truth conditions, and another inside a side comment that does not have any effect on the truth conditions. According to this analysis, only the embedded verb *quisiere* in (41) has an effect on the truth conditions and *qual quier* is interpreted as a side comment ‘whichever value one wants to choose for *x*’, where *x* is represented by *qual*:

- (41) Degrado deuen ser dadas las cosas espirituales & no por preçio.
of.grace should be given the things spiritual & NEG for price
onde qual quier que quisiere entrar en orden de religion no deue
where QUAL QUIER who wishes enter in order of religion NEG should
dar precio ninguno
give price any
‘Spiritual things must be given not bought. *Whoever would want to enter in the realm of religion should not give any price.*’
(13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete partidas*)

The crucial assumption is that at the stage, when *querer* was analysed as a lexical verb (i.e. before the 13th c. and partially also in 13th c.), the side comment expressed by *qual quier* as ‘whichever one wants to choose’ or by *qual quisieres* ‘whichever you, informal, would like to choose’ is literally expressed, whereas in later periods, when *quier* is no longer interpreted as a verb, free choice is not literally encoded in the relative clause, but in the indefinite itself as part of its conventional meaning (see Chapter 1 and example (4) repeated here in (42))

- (42) Puedes traer *cualquier* libro.
can bring CUALQUIER book
‘You can bring any book.’

Conventional meaning: ‘You can bring me a book, and each book is a possible option.’ (Aloni et al. 2011: 2)

Another consequence of the change is that the choice to pick a value for *x* no longer depends on the generic subject *pro* of *quier* as in Old Spanish, but on the agent of the clause in which *cualquiera* is used. In the Modern Spanish example in (42), the subject of free choice is expressed by the grammatical subject *pro*, which refers to the addressee, who can pick any book he/she wants, not the generic *pro* inside *cualquier*, which is no longer transparent in Modern Spanish. Another consequence of the grammaticalisation is that the indicative mood and perfective aspect increased (see Section 5.2). As was demonstrated in Section 2.3, *cualquiera* has a ‘random’ interpretation or an evaluative interpretation under volitional verbs with perfective aspect (see Section 2.3 and Chapter 3), repeated here in (43). Under both interpretations (RCI and EVAL), the generic *pro* is no longer visible as the agent of choice. In (43) the random choice depends on the explicit agent Juan and (43) does not express any choice at all, but speaker’s evaluation.

- (43) Juan compró un libro *cualquiera*.
 Juan bought a book CUALQUIERA
 ‘Juan bought a book.’
- a. John bought a book, and he choose it indiscriminately. (Random Choice)
 - b. John bought a book, and the book is not special or remarkable (according to the speaker). (EVAL)
- (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018: 2)

According to my analysis, the semantic change can be summarised in the following steps. The grammaticalisation of QUALQUIER has induced a change in the interpretation of QUALQUIER with respect to the subject of ‘want to choose a value for *qual*’. When *qualquier* was still transparent (before the 13th c. and partially still in 13th c.), free choice depended on the generic *pro* and was expressed explicitly by the verbal phrase *pro*_[generic] *quier*. After the loss of transparency, free choice was encoded in the indefinite and the agent of free choice depended on the grammatical subject/agent of the clause. Random Choice and EVAL appeared with the rise of indefinite nouns, indicative mood, and the volitional/predicative verb class:

- (44) 1. *qual pro* V°/T° *quiere que* V-subj. (before the 13th c.) →
Free Choice expressed explicitly and the agent of Free Choice is
*pro*_[generic]
2. Indefinite pronoun/determiner *cualquier,-a* (after the 13th c. till today)
→
Free Choice expressed implicitly as a conventional implicature and the
agent of Free Choice is the agent of the matrix verb.
3. UN N *cualquiera* under volitional verbs in indicative →
Random Choice Modality (from the 18th c. until today)
4. UN N *cualquiera* under predicative verbs in indicative (from the 18th c.
till today)
EVAL

Given the syntactic and semantic change suggested in (44), the grammaticalisation of the indefinite does not correlate with a loss or weakening in meaning as Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo (2009) suggest — the grammaticalised form *QUALQUIER* is not void of meaning — but it correlates with a change from an *explicit* to an *implicit* encoding of Free Choice, once *qual quiere* is no longer analysed literally (already in 13th c.); and it also correlates with the change of the agent of Free Choice from generic to grammatical subject/agent of the matrix clause. From the 13th century until today, Free Choice meaning remains, but it is encoded differently. Only much later, from the 18th century onwards, we observe that a new meaning (EVAL) appears due to the increase of indicative mood, predicative verbs, and the increase of UN N *cualquiera*. I will discuss the meaning change to EVAL in Section 5.3.2.

5.3.2 Analysis of *QUALQUIER* as a postnominal modifier

The relative clause *QUALQUIER que...* could also appear postnominally with an overt noun as antecedent in the 13th century.

Let us now look into this type more closely. The antecedent of the relative clause introduced by *qual(quiere)* could not only appear with bare nouns, as shown in Section 5.3.1 (which was the most frequent construction in the 13th century, as shown in Section 5.2), but also with overt quantificational determiners as in (45), the frequency of which is very low in the 13th c.):

- (45) a. Mas si por *alguna otra* *razon* *cualquier* que no *fuese* *delas*
but if for some other reason *QUALQUIER* that NEG was of.the

sobre dichas enestas leyes deseredase el padre a su fijo [...]
 about mentioned in.these laws disinherits the father to his son
 ‘But if for some other (whatsoever) reason, that is not among the ones
 mentioned before in these laws, the father disinherits his son [...]
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete Partidas*)

- b. [...] que ayan poder de tomar casas vinnas huertas
 that have power to take houses vineyards orchards
 oliuares molinos tiendas atahonas aldeas e todo otro
 olive.groves mills shops attics villages and all other
heredamiento qualquiere que sea de todo omne [...].
 inheritance *QUALQUIERE* that is.SUBJ of all men
 ‘[...] that they have the power to take houses, vineyards, vegetable
 gardens, olive groves, tents, horse mills, hamlets, and any other
 inheritance, whichever it might be, from every person [...].’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Doc. Cast. - Andalucía*)
- c. o por abenencia o por aluedrio o por conposicion o por toda
 or by benevolence or by free.will or by composition or by any
otra manera qualquiere que el touiere por bien
 other way *QUALQUIERE* that he considers for good
 ‘by the agreement or by arbitral award or by a deal or by any other
 manner that he approves of’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Doc. Cast. - Castilla la Nueva*)
- d. [...] Desi dixo domjngujllo que le diese el Rey vn omne qual
 thus said Domjngujllo that him give the King a man *QUAL*
quier a que le firiese e quando le oujese
QUIER to whom him would.strike and when him been.heard
 ferido que se yrie para el castillo
 wounded that REFL should.go to the castle
 ‘Then Dominguillo said that the King should give him a man
 which(ever) one wants whom he could hurt, and after hurting him, he
 would go to the castle.’
 (14th c., Anonymous, *Veinte Reyes*)

This shows that *qualquier* cannot be interpreted as a quantificational determiner at this stage yet. Otherwise we would end up with two different quantifiers that quantify over the same NP or over the same domain. This is impossible in natural language; consider, for instance, English **some whichever reason* or

**every whichever inheritance* or **every whichever manner* (see also Chapter 2 on the exclusion of double quantification). Let us analyse the example of *todo otro heredamiento que* in (45), of which I only present the relevant part in (46):

- (46) ...que ayan poder de tomar casas, ... e todo otro heredamiento
 that may.have power of take houses, and all other inheritance
qualquiera que sea
 QUALQUIERE that may.be
 ‘...that they can take every inheritance that one wants it to be’

The interpretation is derived step by step in (47). First, the relative clause is interpreted as an open proposition due to the *wh*-feature of *qual* and the clause structure (CP), then the relative clause is interpreted as a nominal modifier, that is, as a property, then the DP is interpreted as universal quantification. The truth conditions of the sentence in which the DP occurs are spelled out in (47d).¹⁰

- (47) a. $\llbracket \text{qualquier que sea} \rrbracket =$
 (i) there might be(x) open proposition
 b. $\llbracket \text{heredamiento qualquier que sea} \rrbracket =$
 (ii) $\lambda x[\text{inheritance}(x) \wedge \text{there might be}(x)]$ property
 c. $\llbracket \text{todo otro heredamiento qualquier que sea} \rrbracket =$
 (iii) $\lambda P. \text{All } x[\text{other}(x) \wedge \text{inheritance}(x) \wedge \text{there might be} \wedge P(x)]$
 universal quantifier
 d. $\llbracket (46) = \text{que ayan poder de tomar todo otro heredamiento qualquier que sea} \rrbracket = 1$ iff
 can take $(\forall x [\text{inheritance}(x) \wedge \text{there might be}(x)])$ (they)
 prose: according to the law they can take every inheritance that there might be

The only difference between headed relatives as in (47) and free relatives suggested in Section 5.3.2 is that the nominal antecedent is overtly present in headed relatives in contrast to free relatives with a covert nominal antecedent in Section 5.3.2. The function of the relative clause CP *qual quier que sea* is the same.

¹⁰ Another possibility would be to interpret the postnominal *QUALQUIER* as a free relative clause without an overt antecedent. On this analysis, one could interpret the free relative clause as a proposition with a discourse variable and not as a property that modifies an antecedent NP:

(i) Some other thing. Whatever it [=this thing] might be.

I leave it for future research, to distinguish between the two options.

It modifies an (overt) nominal antecedent and is thus of a property type $\langle e, t \rangle$, similar to adjectives or other nominal modifiers:

(48) *Qualquier* with an overt antecedent:

- a. $[_{DP} \langle e, t \rangle, t \rangle \text{ alguna/toda } [_{Spec, NP} \text{ otra } \langle e, t \rangle [_{NP} \langle e, t \rangle \text{ razon/manera } [_{CP} \langle e, t \rangle [_{Spec, CP} [_{D^\circ} \text{ qualquier}_j] \text{ C' C}^\circ \text{ que TP}_2 \text{ pro T}^\circ \text{ sea } t_j]]]]]$

I will show now what happened after *qual quier que* was no longer analysed as a relative clause in headed relatives. In a nutshell, the idea is that the string *qual quier* lost its transparent status as consisting of the wh-pronoun *qual* and the verbal form *quier* (see Section 5.3.1); that is, the wh-feature disappeared, and the verb was no longer analysed as such, with the consequence that the embedded clause introduced by *que* was no longer necessary. This is why the frequency of *qualquier, -e, -a que...* decreases, as already shown in Section 5.2. The postnominal *qualquier, -e, -a* thus can appear without the embedded clause (see, e.g. 49):

- (49) o con cuchillo o con *otra cosa qualquier*
 or with knife or with other thing QUALQUIER
 ‘or with a knife or with some other thing whichever one wants’
 (13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete Partidas*)

The crucial question is what syntactic category and semantic interpretation the postnominal *qualquier, -e, -a* acquired in structures like (49), once it was no longer analysed transparently.

I assume that the postnominal *cualquiera* has preserved its syntactic status as a nominal modifier (like relative clauses) and its semantic status as a property of type $\langle e, t \rangle$, as shown in (50). The only difference to relative clauses like those in (48) is that the new postnominal CUALQUIER is no longer clausal, but a complex compound word (for details, see Chapter 3):

- (50) $[_{DP} \text{ una } [_{NP} \text{ cosa/razon } [_{ModifP} \text{ cualquiera}]]]$

As I already pointed out, postnominal *cualquiera* does not have the evaluative meaning before the 17th century (see Section 5.1 and Section 5.2). The free choice interpretation of the postnominal modifier is triggered by some modal verb, subjunctive, or generic operator (see Chapter 2):

(51) postnominal CUALQUIERA

...sea debajo de la equinoccial o (sea) en *otra parte cualquiera*» A
 ...be under of the equinoctial or (be) in other part CUALQUIERA to
 este propósito, trae Celio Rodiginio lo de Arriano, historiador griego
 this purpose, brings Celio Rodiginio the of Arriano, historian Greek
 ‘... be it under the equinoctial or (be it) in any other place» In this respect,
 Celio Rodiginio says of Arriano, Greek historian’ (brackets my own)
 (16th c., Torquemada, *Jardín*)

The free choice meaning of the postnominal modifier *cualquiera* in (52) is similar to the meaning of a postnominal relative clause *qual quiera* at earlier stages (see Section 5.3.1). To illustrate this example, here it can be roughly paraphrased as *some place x*, where *x* can have any value (one wants). The semantic shift from FCI to EVAL in the 17th century in (52) can be analysed as a shift from free choice *cualquiera* as ‘any (one wants)’ to a property *cualquiera* that ‘anyone has’ and thus to a property with the meaning ‘ordinary’, because this property does not distinguish individuals from each other (see Chapter 3 for details):

(52) Juan es un hombre *cualquiera* (para mí)

Juan is a man CUALQUIERA (for me)

‘Juan is a man with a property that anyone has’ (literal) →

‘Juan is an ordinary man (to me).’

(@ 151)

The evaluative interpretation has triggered a further shift of postnominal modifying *cualquiera* into nominal *cualquiera* as in *es una cualquiera*, which appears late in the CdE from the 18th century (from 14th to 18th c. 0.0 per mil in each century, 18th c. 0.20 per mil, 19th c. 0.73 per mil). Note that, semantically, this nominal *cualquiera* is still interpreted as an evaluative predicate of the type <e,t>, but behaves differently from the postnominal function in that it also encodes the feature [+animate] and female gender:

(53) *¡ya se ve!, es una cualquiera;*

already REFL sees is a CUALQUIERA

‘One can already see! She is a promiscuous woman;’

(19th c., Rizal, *Noli me tangere*)

Recall that, in Argentinian Spanish, the semantic shift into the evaluative predicate has triggered a further syntactic reanalysis of CUALQUIERA a gradable adjective (see Chapter 4):

- (54) Juan es muy *cualquiera* (para mí) (ArgSp)
 Juan is very CUALQUIERA for me
 [ordinary' (Juan) (to me) (to a high degree)]
 'Juan is very common/ordinary to me.'
 (@ 152)

I assume that it is the semantic interpretation of relative clauses as properties that enables one to interpret *cualquiera* as a property with an evaluative meaning 'ordinary' in predicative position such as *es un hombre cualquiera* 'he is an ordinary man' or as an evaluative property of women that has been lexicalised in *una cualquiera* (Chapter 3 on EVAL). The rise of the indicative mood and predicative verbs has further enhanced the property interpretation of *cualquiera* as in N *cualquiera* (see Chapter 3).

The different analyses of prenominal and postnominal *cualquiera* explains why only the postnominal *cualquiera* has different lexical meanings (FCI, EVAL) in European Spanish, but not prenominal *cualquiera*. The reason for this is that only postnominal *cualquiera* has a predicative status and is interpreted as a nominal modifier similar to adjectives, whereas the quantificational determiner is a functional category that is more restricted in meanings than a lexical category.

5.4 Summary and discussion

I have proposed an analysis that shows how the reanalysis of QUALQUIER as a relative clause into a quantificational determiner (which Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo 2009 and others call grammaticalisation of QUALQUIER) has taken place, namely from a relative clause to reanalysis as a word compound QUALQUIER (without the ending *-a*), which was categorised as a quantificational determiner D° with a FC interpretation 'any(one/thing)'. I have provided a detailed analysis of the reanalysis process that involved a loss of compositional meaning of the generic subject pronoun, the modal verb *quier* and the relative wh-pronoun *qual* and the appearance of a single word with a free choice interpretation associated with the matrix subject. The steps and empirical evidence is summarised as follows.

- (55) Free relative clause *qual quier* was reanalysed as an indefinite determiner (grammaticalisation as a determiner, see also the Innovation/Grammaticalisation Hypothesis in §2)
- Free Rel. Clause → Determiner as in *cualquier* N

- Evidence:
 - The separated forms in which a noun or an NP can be placed between relative pronoun *qual* and verb *quier* (e.g. *qual manera quier* lit. ‘which manner one wants’) from 13th c.
 - After 13th c. *qual quier* N(P) ‘which one wants N(P)’ continued the path of grammaticalisation, becoming more fixed, as shown by graphically synthetic form *qualquier* and later *cualquier*.
 - The rise in frequency of *qualquier* NP, the decrease in use of relative clause markers such as *que* ‘that’ is another support for the grammaticalisation.
- Interpretation of Determiner *cualquier*: FCI only

I have suggested that the change of postnominal QUALQUIER (with the ending -a) was a change from a headed relative clause into a postnominal modifier as in UN N *cualquiera* with the subsequent change into a noun *cualquiera* as in UN *cualquiera* in European Spanish. The steps and evidence are summarised as follows.

(56) Headed Rel. Clause [N *qual quiera*] was reanalysed as a nominal modifier *qualquiera*

- NP Rel. Clause → bare N *qualquier* → bare N *qualquier* → Article N *cualquiera* → Article *cualquiera*
- Evidence:
 - graphically synthetic form *qualquier,e,a* and later *cualquiera*,
 - the increase of Art N *cualquiera*
 - the increase of ambiguity between nominal modifiers and adjectives,
 - the increase in lexical meanings (FCI, EVAL),
 - the increase in UN *cualquiera* (EVAL)
 - the increase in definite Art N *cualquiera* (EVAL)

Recall from Chapter 2 that Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo (2009) assume that QUALQUIER has gradually lost its semantic interpretation under the assumption that grammaticalisation correlates with a loss or weakening of semantic content (Lehmann 2002 [1982], Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo (2009)). At the same time, Company-Company & Pozas-Loyo (2009) assume that QUALQUIER undergoes a “subjectification” process going from “election” to “generalisation” to “valorisation”. These two processes (grammaticalisation and subjectification) do not represent a contradiction, if we take the syntactic nature of QUALQUIER into

account and the linguistic context in which it appears (e.g., indicative and modal verbal mood). It's the postnominal *QUALQUIER* under indicative verbal mood, not the prenominal *QUALQUIER*, that undergoes the "subjectification" process and acquires the new meaning *EVAL* in European Spanish, which triggers a further process of syntactic reanalysis into a gradable adjective as in *re/medio cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish (Chapter 4). The postnominal *QUALQUIER* certainly has grammaticalised to some degree, as it lost the transparent relative clause interpretation of the *wh*-word *qual* + modal verb *querer* and was reanalysed as a single word (see Lehmann 2002 [1982] on prototypical features of grammaticalisation). However, the grammaticalisation of the postnominal *QUALQUIER* into a nominal modifier that is similar to the syntactic category of adjectives is what triggered further linguistic changes such as the appearance of articles and meaning ambiguity depending on the linguistic context (+/- indicative verbal mood). The two elements – the determiner *QUALQUIER* and the postnominal modifier *QUALQUIER* – followed a different linguistic path. One could also describe the path of the postnominal modifier *QUALQUIER* in the diachrony of Spanish as "constructionalisation" (Traugott & Trousdale 2013) because it has acquired both new form and new meaning, which is particularly seen in Argentinian Spanish where it has acquired the new form of a gradable adjective with the meaning 'ordinary' and the new form of an evaluative noun with the meaning 'bullshit/non-sense'.

Finally, I would like to discuss the concepts of grammaticalisation and lexicalisation in order to understand which of these processes are involved in the linguistic changes of *QUALQUIER*. Many studies have recognised the challenge of distinguishing the processes of grammaticalisation and lexicalisation (e.g. Brinton & Traugott 2005, Diewald & Smirnova 2012, Lehmann 2002 [1982], Traugott & Trousdale 2013, Trousdale 2012, Van Rompaey et al. 2015). Compound words like *going to*, *a lot of*, *cualquiera* are among the most challenging cases with regard to the question of which of the two processes (lexicalisation or grammaticalisation) is involved in the linguistic change of these words (e.g. Brinton & Traugott 2005, Trousdale 2012, Van Rompaey et al. 2015). Both processes can involve similar linguistic mechanisms such as reanalysis, desemanticisation, and change in syntactic categorisation. Regarding reanalysis, linguistic elements can undergo reinterpretation in the process of grammaticalisation and lexicalisation. Grammaticalisation often involves a reduction in semantic content as the word compound *qualquier* transitions into a grammatical category (quantificational indefinite). Lexicalisation can also involve semantic bleaching, where a compound phrase becomes a single lexical item. Both processes can involve changes in the grammatical category. In grammaticalisation, words often lose their full lexical category status, while in lexicalisation, phrases can solidify into a single lexi-

cal category. This overlap suggests that grammaticalisation and lexicalisation are not completely distinct processes. The term lexicalisation has at least two meanings. It means the incorporation of a complex linguistic expression such as relative clause *qual quier* into the lexicon as a word(compound) (meaning 1) and it also means a reanalysis of a complex expression as a lexical category with lexical content (e.g. the complex expression *valer la pena* in Spanish means ‘to be worth’) in contrast to a grammatical or functional category with a grammatical function (e.g. determiners) (meaning 2). This said, the process of grammaticalisation of *qual quier* necessarily involves lexicalisation in the first sense of the term (meaning 1). The second sense of the term lexicalisation only applies to the postnominal modifier *cualquiera* that has been reanalysed into a lexical category nominal modifier or a noun with lexical meanings such as ‘ordinary’ as in *un día cualquiera* or ‘male nobody’ as in *un cualquiera*.

6 Overall summary and conclusions

This book had two major aims. The first aim was to probe a compositional analysis of meaning change of modal indefinites. In order to achieve this goal, it was necessary to characterise and define different meanings of *cualquiera* in Modern Spanish varieties. The reason why *cualquiera* is particularly interesting for a linguistic study is that this word has different meanings that appear to be unrelated such as the Free Choice (FC) meaning ‘any’ and evaluative meanings such as ‘ordinary’ and ‘low value’ (which I called EVAL1) and ‘nonsense’ (EVAL2). I focused on European and Argentinian Spanish, because these varieties show different degrees of lexicalisation of these meanings. One research question was whether the different meanings of *cualquiera* in Spanish varieties represent a case of polysemy (Hypothesis 1) or whether *cualquiera* has only one basic meaning (assumedly the FC meaning ‘any’) and other meanings can be inferred from the general meaning pragmatically (Hypothesis 2). Moreover, I investigated the relation between syntax and semantics, i.e. whether certain meanings appear under particular morphosyntactic conditions, which is the core assumption of the compositional framework of meaning change. The second aim of this book was to investigate the diachrony of these meanings, i.e. when they appeared over time and under which linguistic conditions they occurred. The major scope of this book is thus a synchronic and diachronic description and analysis of different meanings of *cualquiera* in European and Argentinian Spanish. In the first half of this book, I investigated the synchrony of *cualquiera*, and in the second half I investigated its diachrony. I will summarise how I proceeded in my analysis and what the most important results and new findings to the study of *cualquiera* are.

In order to describe the synchronic meanings of *cualquiera*, I first reviewed the data and various analyses as discussed in the literature in Modern European and Argentinian Spanish. I have shown that semantic and syntactic analyses are missing on *cualquiera* with EVAL1 ‘unremarkable’ present in European and Argentinian Spanish and EVAL2 ‘nonsense’ present only in Argentinian Spanish.

In Chapter 3, I presented new data and a new analysis of N *cualquiera* with EVAL1. I analysed new data from a subcorpus of Corpus del Español (CdE_web) and have identified various flavours of the evaluative meaning ‘unremarkable’, namely COM (common: ‘regular, normal’), DER (derogative: ‘ordinary, without

any particular quality worth mentioning'). I argued that EVAL1 in European Spanish is a special case of interpreting *cualquiera* as a quantifier with a free choice interpretation 'any'. I have shown that by deriving the evaluative meaning from the quantifier meaning, *cualquiera* is not a case of polysemy (i.e. Hypothesis 2 of Section 1.1 is verified and Hypothesis 2 is falsified, contra Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2018). In order to derive the evaluative meaning 'ordinary' from 'any', I have analysed *cualquiera* as a quantificational predicate (modifier) similar to adjectives, which has the interpretation of a comparative clause expressing similarity between the actual referent and a comparison class, i.e. *Juan es un hombre cualquiera* is interpreted as 'Juan is a man and he is like anyone else' (whereby 'anyone else' is a set of comparable male individuals, see Section 3.3). The similarity between individuals entails the meaning 'common' as having similar properties like anyone else entails having common properties. The derogatory meaning of 'low value' or 'nothing special' is a pragmatic inference of the 'common' meaning. The free choice meaning 'any' is the basic lexical meaning of *cualquiera* and EVAL1 'ordinary' follows from this basic meaning. This analysis is the first analysis that provides an explanation how different meanings and functions of *cualquiera* are interconnected and it provides further support for the compositionality view on meaning change.

I discussed a small data set in the corpus CdE_web (e.g., definite determiner N *cualquiera*) that shows signs of lexicalisation of the evaluative meaning. According to this data set, the SIM meaning (i.e. *cualquiera* as 'like anyone else') has been reanalysed as a property of kinds of individuals with the meaning 'common/typical/ordinary'. This lexical meaning co-occurs with definite nouns and quantified nouns (e.g. *el hombre cualquiera* 'the typical person/man' or *algún día cualquiera* 'on some ordinary day') as well as with coordination (e.g. *un ser mediocre y cualquiera* 'a mediocre and ordinary human being').

In Chapter 4, I analysed *cualquiera* with EVAL1 and EVAL2 in Argentinian Spanish and suggested an analysis for the interpretations and licensing of *cualquiera* in episodic contexts in this variety. Episodic contexts usually do not license modal indefinites like *cualquier* 'any'. I suggested that *cualquiera* with EVAL1 should be analysed as a degree adjective in Argentinian Spanish. I have argued that the difference between European Spanish and Argentinian Spanish *cualquiera* with EVAL1 is primarily syntactic: In Argentinian Spanish but not in European Spanish, *cualquiera* is used as a predicative adjective with degree modification (e.g. *es muy cualquiera* 'he/she/it is very ordinary'). I analysed the meaning of the adjective *cualquiera* as 'bad', as a pejorative interpretation of *cualquiera* as 'common' or 'ordinary' under the assumption that speakers who use the pejorative version 'bad' assume that 'being ordinary' counts as a negative

property in contrast to ‘being special’ or ‘having a distinctive property’. I have proposed analysing EVAL2 ‘nonsense’ in parallel with the free choice indefinite *cualquier cosa* ‘anything’, which is interpreted in episodic contexts as ‘anything possible’ or as ‘something random’. The evaluative meaning ‘nonsense’ is a pragmatic inference, which comes about as follows. The judge (usually the speaker) evaluates the modal component of the free choice *cualquiera* (‘every possibility is an option’) on a scale of preferences, namely as the least preferred option. Under verbs of saying like *decir* or *mandar* ‘to say’ in Argentinian Spanish, this pragmatic inference works as follows. The expression in Argentinian Spanish *decir/mandar cualquiera* ‘saying anything possible’ implies saying contradictory things or saying something random or saying unreflected things according to the judge (usually the speaker). This pragmatic evaluation has been lexicalised in Argentinian Spanish under transitive verbs of saying and this evaluative meaning further generalised to other verbs, e.g. predicative verbs (e.g. ArgSp *lo que me decís es cualquiera* ‘what you are telling me is bullshit/nonsensical’). The diachronic data of Argentinian Spanish *cualquiera* is unfortunately too scarce to draw strong conclusions. Nevertheless, there are some hints that suggest that the origin of the meaning ‘nonsense’ is its occurrence under verbs of *decir* ‘to say’. Concerning the research question of this book whether EVAL1 and EVAL2 are lexicalised meanings, I have argued that the answer is positive for Argentinian Spanish (or, in other words, Hypothesis 1 holds) as these meanings correlate with different syntactic categories than the indefinite *cualquiera* with FC ‘anything’, namely degree adjectives and evaluative nouns. However, what looks like a case of polysemy in Modern Argentinian Spanish is not a polysemy from the diachronic perspective. I argued that, in diachrony EVAL1 and EVAL2, are the result of pragmatic inferencing that has been lexicalised and has driven syntactic reanalysis into different categories in Modern Argentinian Spanish, namely from a pronoun into gradable adjective with the meanings ‘ordinary’ and ‘nonsensical’ and into an evaluative noun with the meaning ‘nonsense’. I have shown that this path of reanalysis from FC *cualquiera* into evaluative *cualquiera* is not a special property of *cualquiera* in Argentinian Spanish, but is also present in French (e.g. *n’importe quoi*), Mexican Spanish *equis* (‘any’ in modal contexts and ‘ordinary’ under predicative verbs) (Kellert 2020) and other, non-Romance languages, as for instance in Czech (see Šimík 2008). Chapter 4 presents the first in-depth contrastive analysis of *cualquiera* in Argentinian and European Spanish, based on corpus data and quantitative analysis.

After the synchronic analysis of evaluative meanings and the diachronic analysis of EVAL2 in Argentinian Spanish, I focused on the diachronic analysis of *cualquiera* in European Spanish in order to find evidence for my synchronic anal-

ysis, namely that the free choice meaning is the basic meaning and the evaluative meanings are secondary or following from the free choice meaning. My assumption was that the free choice meaning occurred diachronically first and the evaluative meanings later. Moreover, I looked at the change of linguistic conditions (e.g. change of episodic contexts, syntactic position, etc.) to see how the meanings arise diachronically.

In Chapter 5, I have shown on the basis of quantitative data and their statistical analysis on the basis of historical data from CdE when and how *cualquiera* has developed its functions and meanings in the history of Old and Middle Spanish as well as Modern European Spanish. I analysed different syntactic properties such as the position of *cualquiera* with respect to the verb and the noun and have shown on the basis of statistical tests that *cualquiera* has been used increasingly in different syntactic structures such as declaratives, in postverbal position, etc., which I interpreted as an argument for the grammaticalisation hypothesis. I have modelled the path of grammaticalisation of *cualquiera* in a generative framework and have analysed the meaning components that have changed from the relative clause with free choice interpretation *qual quier,e,a* ‘which one wants’ to *qualquier,-e,-a* ‘whichever’. The most important semantic component that changed from the meaning of relative clause *qual quier,e,a* to the free choice indefinite *qualquier,-e,-a* is related to the judge parameter. The free choice interpretation of the indefinite (in contrast to the relative clause) is no longer dependent on the generic *pro* as in *qual pro_{generic} quier,-e,-a*, but can be associated with the agent of the matrix clause, (e.g. *Pablo puede invitar a cualquiera* ‘Pablo can invite anyone’). What both linguistic expressions (relative clause Old Spanish *qual quier,-e,-a* and the modern indefinite *cualquiera*) have in common is that they do not contribute to the truth conditional semantic meaning of the clause ‘Pablo can invite someone’. They have rather the function of a side-comment, e.g. ‘Pablo has free choice of inviting whoever he likes’. I have shown diachronic evidence for the side-comment analysis as relative clauses such as *qual quier,-e,-a* behave very much like adjuncts and they can even interrupt a sentence (e.g. *pon una estrella fixa qual quisieres por su longura del eguador* ‘put a star [which you want] along the equator’).

Another important finding of my diachronic study is that the postnominal *cualquiera* is the result of a process by which the relative clause *qual quier,e,a* has been lexicalised into a single compound, meaning that the lexicon has been updated with a new entry *cualquiera* as a nominal modifier. In this function as a nominal modifier, it has persevered in its semantic function as a nominal property (Noun + *qualquier,-e,-a*). The evaluative meaning of postnominal *cualquiera*, which appeared in the 17th century, is thus directly related to the property function of relative clauses in a postnominal position in contrast to the prenominal

quantifier *cualquier*. I have concluded that postnominal *cualquiera* did not undergo grammaticalisation into a quantificational determiner as the prenominal *cualquier* did. It is thus necessary to distinguish between different syntactic functions of *cualquier(a)* (prenominal determiner, postnominal modifier, pronoun) to understand the different processes involved in the diachrony of these elements. This chapter provides the first in-depth diachronic analysis that combines statistical analysis with a theoretical explanation of meaning change of *cualquiera* and offers a new perspective on the grammaticalisation of *cualquiera*. A more general contribution to the research on *cualquiera* is that I have shown the necessity of looking at different syntactic properties and categories of *cualquiera* in diachronic and diatopic variation to understand the processes involved in the semantic and syntactic changes.

I have shown that there are (at least) two diachronic paths of *cualquiera* depending on its part of speech and syntactic position, which can be summarised as follows. For the diachronic development of postnominal *cualquiera* in European Spanish and Argentinian Spanish the following steps have been identified:

1. Use of postnominal *cualquiera* often after *otro* ‘other’ + *noun* with a complement clause after *quier* expressed by *que* ‘that’ and a selected subjunctive (e.g. *qual quier que sea*) with modal interpretation ‘whichever one wants that it may be’ in 13th century Old Spanish:

e.g. *o de otra razon qualquier que sea*
 or of another reason *QUALQUIER* that may.be

‘or for some other reason whichever one wants that it may be’ (13th c., Alfonso X, *Siete Partidas*)

Use of nouns between *qual* and *quier*, which show that *qual quier* could be analysed compositionally in 13th century (Pato 2012):

e.g. [...] *en qual manera quier que sean*
 in which manner wants that be.SBJV

‘in whatever manner’ (13th c., Alfonso X, *Libro de las cruces*)

2. Recategorisation of postnominal *cualquiera* as one word, lexicalisation of the modal meaning (‘which one wants’ → ‘any’) (see also Elvira 2007). Empirical evidence:
 - a) disappearance of *qual NP quier*,
 - b) orthographic non-separated form *qualquier* increases,
 - c) decrease of complement clauses after *quier* and selected subjunctive: *qual quier que ...*,

6 Overall summary and conclusions

- d) increasing use of postnominal *cualquiera* with an indefinite N as in *UN N cualquiera*.
3. Use of *cualquiera* in predicative and postnominal position under negation (e.g. *no es un día cualquiera, es un día especial* ‘it’s not an ordinary day, it’s a special day’) (in 16th c. in European Spanish until today in European Spanish and in Argentinian Spanish).
4. Increase of copular predicates without negation in present and past tense (e.g. *es un día cualquiera* ‘it’s an ordinary day’) (from 18th c. in European Spanish).
5. Extension of the use of *UN N cualquiera* to definite articles + N *cualquiera* and quantified nouns as in *la/mucha gente cualquiera* ‘the/many ordinary people’ (in European Spanish in 20th c. and Argentinian Spanish).

The diachronic development of postnominal *cualquiera* continued in Argentinian Spanish, but not in European Spanish:

6. Use of *cualquiera* as a predicative complement without the noun (in Argentinian Spanish in 19th c. until today), e.g. *Su ocupación era cualquiera*. ‘His position was nothing important.’
7. Appearance of degree modification with the predicative complement (in Argentinian Spanish in 20th c.) as in *re/muy/pero/tan/medio cualquiera* ‘very/really/a bit ordinary’.

The diachronic development of pronominal *cualquiera* has been identified in Argentinian Spanish, but not in European Spanish:

1. Use of the pronoun *cualquiera* and *cualquier cosa* with a modal meaning (‘any (thing)’) from Old Spanish until today in European Spanish and Argentinian Spanish.
2. Increasing use of the pronoun *cualquiera* and *cualquier cosa* under a particular lexical verb group, namely verbs of saying with present and past tense morphology as in Chapter 4 (in 19th c. in Argentinian Spanish until today, not in European Spanish).
3. Extension of the use of verbs of saying to other verbs and appearance of nominal modification of *cualquiera* and *cualquier cosa*, e.g. *cualquiera total* ‘complete bull-shit’ (in Argentinian Spanish in 20th c., not in European Spanish).

I have argued that the new evaluative meaning ‘ordinary’ in Argentinian Spanish is the result of reanalysing the old meaning ‘any’ with contextual information (Blank 1997, Traugott 1989, Eckardt 2006, among others). More precisely, the free choice meaning (the original meaning) is enriched by the contextual information triggered as the result of using *cualquiera* in the postnominal position of a negated predicative complement that is associated with focus or emphasis (e.g. *no es [un día cualquiera]_{focus}*predicative complement). This focus or emphasis of the postnominal position of a predicative complement used under negation expresses a contrast between free choice alternatives of *cualquiera* and another focus alternative, which is the opposite of free choice, namely an alternative that can be described as specific or definite and which is recoverable from context (e.g. *no es un día cualquiera, es un día especial* ‘it’s not just any day, it’s a special day’). This contrast between free choice alternatives and the specific contextual alternative has in turn induced a contrast of properties between *cualquiera* characterising free choice alternatives as ‘non-specific’, ‘general’ or ‘common’ as opposed to ‘specific’, ‘unique’ or ‘uncommon’, which becomes clearly visible in the use of definite articles and quantified nouns with [N *cualquiera*] (e.g. *la gente cualquiera* ‘the common people’). I adapt the new meaning as ‘common’ following the semantic literature on predicate modification of kind nouns (Carlson 1977, Gehrke & McNally 2015) to make the new meaning of *cualquiera* more explicit in formal semantic terms. In my reconstruction of the reanalysis path, the change from a quantificational indefinite *cualquiera* ‘any’ to a predicate modifier *cualquiera* ‘common’ is the first relevant meaning change. The previous changes represent (only) grammatical changes rather than meaning changes as the free choice meaning of ‘which-ever one wants’ and ‘any’ are preserved in the grammatical change from a relative clause into an indefinite. The meaning change from ‘any’ to ‘common’ has further induced syntactic/grammatical changes from a predicate modifier into a predicative complement without nominal modification and later into a degree predicate in Argentinian Spanish. As for the question of how much the meaning change involves compositionality (Frege 1997, Eckardt 2006, Aloni 2021, Bar-Asher Siegal 2020, Condoravdi 2015), my answer is that the reanalysis process from ‘any’ to ‘common’ is based on the compositionality principle, because the derivation of the meaning of *cualquiera* in the context of negation is compositional, that is, the negation of free choice alternatives leads to the assertion of a specific alternative. This step was necessary for speakers to make an abstraction of properties from the contrast of focus alternatives (unspecific vs. a specific contextual alternative). However, the compositionality itself is not what triggers the change. It is the characterisation of focus alternatives as properties, along with the high frequency of the negative context,

that leads to the lexicalisation of the pragmatic context and the lexicalisation of the property with the meaning ‘common’ (for the role of frequency in the context of language change, see Pagel et al. 2007, Bybee 2006). Still, the contextual or enriched meaning is derivable compositionally from the use of *cualquiera* in the negation context and focus association of postnominal *cualquiera*. The derogatory meaning of *cualquiera* as ‘nothing special’ or ‘bad’ is an instance of pejoration of interpreting ‘common’ in relation to a pragmatic scale according to which the property of being ‘common’ is interpreted as being non-distinguished or ordinary in the context of evaluation. The pejoration of the meaning ‘common/standard’ is a well-known process in other languages, e.g. Latin *vulgaris* ‘common’ >> French *vulgaire* ‘vulgar’/ ‘obscene’, etc. (Borkowska & Kleparski 2007). The meaning change of the pronoun *cualquiera* is based on the pragmatic strengthening of the meaning ‘anything’ in the context of verbs of saying (e.g. *decir*, *mandar*, *hablar* ‘say’ in Argentinian Spanish), whereby the meaning of *mandar cualquiera* ‘saying anything’ implies ‘saying anything possible’ or ‘saying unspecific things’ including contradictory or wrong things or saying random or unreflected things according to a judge (usually the speaker) in a conversation context (Grice 1975, Chierchia 2013 on pragmatic strengthening of indefinites). This pragmatic reasoning has been lexicalised under the meaning ‘non-sense’ and its semantic variants (e.g. ‘bullshit’) under transitive verbs such as *decir/mandar* ‘say’ in Argentinian Spanish. The new meaning further generalised to other verbs, e.g. predicative verbs (e.g. ArgSp *lo que me decís es cualquiera* ‘what you are telling me is bullshit/nonsensical’). The meaning change from anything to ‘nonsense’/‘bullshit’ is not unique to Argentinian Spanish, French *n’importe quoi* shows similar meaning changes.

In sum, this book provides further support for the transparency and compositionality principle involved in meaning change and variation in the domain of modal indefinites like Spanish *cualquiera* and it shows that it is necessary to distinguish different uses of *cualquiera* in order to understand the linguistic changes the word underwent, which have led to different grammatical functions and meanings. Some uses of *cualquiera* such as postnominal and pronominal uses have acquired new (evaluative) meanings and have undergone the process of syntactic recategorisation into an adjective and a noun in Argentinian Spanish.

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The (in)transparency of meaning change and variation

This book investigates the development of the indefinite *cualquiera* in European and Argentinian Spanish, tracing the path from modal meanings like free choice and random selection to evaluative and even pejorative uses. Drawing on corpus data, variation across dialects, and formal semantic tools, the study probes how transparent these shifts are and what they reveal about the mechanisms of meaning change. The findings will interest linguists working on indefinites, variation, or the interface between form and interpretation – whether in synchrony or diachrony.